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ようこそ実力至上主義の教室へ2年生編
Welcome to the Classroom of the Second-year
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Welcome to the Classroom of the Second-year
衣笠彰梧×トモセシュンサク


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Prologue: The Monologue of Amasawa Ichika

Test-tube babies. Have you ever heard the term before?

Apparently, they're no longer called that nowadays. Rather, society has taken to using the term 'IVF babies' instead.

I am one of those born from that very process. A human brought about through in vitro fertilization.

However, I don't know anything about my origins outside of that. I've never even seen my parents' faces.

Where they are now… What they're doing… Why they put me in the White Room… Nothing.

But, to be completely honest, I'm not really that interested in finding out.

There's one thing I learned when I was finally old enough to understand the world around me:

That my parents were both extremely talented people.

As such, I must be an incredibly blessed child born with the qualifications to become a genius then, right?

Though, as right as that may be, my existence runs in direct conflict with that of the White Room.

A facility whose ultimate goal is to raise all people unto equivalent superiority.

A facility where they seek to prove that the limits of humanity are decided not by one's genetics, but by their environment.

In other words, they want all people to harbor outstanding talent, not just those blessed with excellent genes like me.

In the end, for the White Room, I'm surely just another experiment.

And while I'm not really all that opposed to being an experiment, I find myself wondering if they really think they'll succeed.

I personally concluded long ago that it's impossible to homogenize intellect, personality, and ethics.

In fact, doesn't my very existence serve as the greatest proof of that?

Ever since I was a child, I've been proud of being different from those around me, though I never showed it. I'd kill off the light in my eyes and indifferently pretend to go through the motions, all the while questioning the significance of the White Room's existence.

Do I truly want to grow up dedicating my life to furthering the ideals of the White Room?

Am I really willing to put my life on the line, toiling day after day, desperate to become the world's utmost example of a successful upbringing?

Wouldn't that be like, you know, kinda pathetic? Wouldn't you want to live more freely?

I would. At least, I'd hate to spend the rest of my life locked up in such a world.

Oops, it seems I've been rambling a bit. Let's get back to the matter at hand, shall we?

Ayanokōji Kiyotaka. The being whose preeminent success stood out from the rest of the White Room.

Of course, I was skeptical when I first heard of him.

After all, how could I possibly believe that, despite all my painstaking efforts, he had scored far higher than me in every way?

But… alas. After seeing the data, meeting him in person, talking to him… I finally understood.

Understood how special he truly was.

However, I'm sorry Senpai.

I really want to take your side, but that's just not how fate is going to play out.

Because, there are those I've known for much, much longer than you, Senpai.

I'm way more compassionate than I thought I was... Who wouldda guessed?

As one of your faithful admirers, I'll be looking on from a distance once 'that time' finally comes.

Chapter 1 : Hidden Movements

Intro

The pouring rain had gotten stronger and the fog, thicker.

It was hard to hear or see anything due to the weather, but I could feel an ominous presence approaching us from behind.

There was a deliberate, almost exaggerated sound of mud being trampled underfoot and strewn into the air.

It seemed that Nanase had immediately noticed it as well.

Looking over my shoulder, I caught sight of a student who had come to an abrupt stop behind me, her red hair swaying in the wind.

“Seems it’s gonna really start coming down, huh Sen~pai?”

It was none other than Class 1-A’s Amasawa Ichika, standing there in the rain.

While it had long-since been established that she had the same table as Nanase and I, this was by no means a mere coincidence.

There weren’t any other students nearby, and she didn’t have a backpack or tablet either.

This begged the question: How exactly did she make it all the way up here?

One possibility was that she had simply hidden her things somewhere nearby before approaching us.

Alternatively, she could’ve been tailing us for an extended period of time, empty-handed from the start.

I suppose it was also possible that someone had been tracking us with the GPS and relaying our position to her via walkie-talkie.

Nonetheless, it was probably fine to rule this out as simple coincidence.

No matter the method, her arrival was not a welcome one as far as I was concerned.

Besides, it wasn't like Amasawa was completely empty-handed either. Clasped in her left hand was a thick wooden stick: one that was more than capable of being used as a weapon to bludgeon someone.

Was she trying to take us by surprise, only for Nanase and I to unexpectedly notice before she could do so?

But, in such bad weather, she could've been far quieter with her approach if she truly planned on attacking us.

"Please get behind me, Senpai."

As I thought about the reason behind Amasawa's sudden appearance, Nanase, despite still being exhausted from earlier, inserted herself in front of me.

From the brief look I had of her profile, her gaze was firm with a blatant sense of distrust written all over her face.

"Oh? Nanase-chan, shouldn't you be happy to see me? How aw~fully cold you are to a dear companion from your very own group. Wait, are you perhaps nervous about this little stick friend of mine~?"

She casually tossed the wooden stick down to the ground between us in what seemed to be a show of good faith.

Even so, Nanase didn't relax her guard whatsoever.

"You— cannot be trusted."

"How me~an. How could you say something like that? I'm super-duper cute~!"

I didn't think that being cute had anything to do with whether or not you were trustworthy, but that didn't really matter at the moment.

"Why do you say that she can't be trusted, Nanase?"

There was certainly something about Amasawa that made it hard to tell what she was truly thinking.

It wouldn't be an overstatement to say that she had extraordinary acting skills and the uncanny ability to put plans into action.

So while it was natural to be cautious of her, it's not like I wasn't already doing that at this point.

But that was no explanation for the excessive distrust and caution Nanase was showing her.

Of course, Amasawa clearly had a reason for showing up here.

One could assume that Nanase was just overreacting now that she had become my ally, but…

"Jeez. I'm not some bad guy, right Ayanokōji-senpai~? I just wanna chat for a bit, kay?"

"Please don't listen to her, she's dangerous."

Though Amasawa wasn't showing any hostility, Nanase remained merciless and firm, refusing to budge an inch.

Despite voicing complaints only moments earlier, Amasawa didn't appear to be bothered by Nanase's seemingly unwarranted accusation.

"Senpai… There's something I've been silent about for a while now… Back when Shinohara-senpai's group was attacked and Komiya-senpai and Kinoshita-senpai retired from the exam, do you remember how you left to climb the slope with Ike-senpai?"

She was referring to the fourth day of the exam, when Ike heard a sound coming from the top of the slope and took off in a panic, thinking that Shinohara might be there.

Having decided that it was too dangerous for him to go alone, I had followed after him.

"While you were gone, I noticed that someone had been watching us from nearby, so I tried chasing after them."

"Is that why you weren't with Sudō and the others when we were making our way back after finding Shinohara?"

She gave a slight nod.

“So what happened?”

“They ran from me. And while I wasn’t able to catch up with them… I did manage to get a good look at their hair.”

With that, Nanase slowly lifted her right arm into the air and pointed at Amasawa.

“Back then, the one watching us from the shadows was you, wasn’t it Amasawa-san?”

“Ahaha, so I was seen after all.”

Rather than try to deny it, Amasawa laughed, admitting to it immediately.

She didn’t seem remotely surprised about having been caught red-handed, her attitude the same as ever.

As such, it was probably safe to conclude that the presence I had sensed back then really had been Amasawa.

“You also hurt Komiya-senpai and Kinoshita-senpai, didn’t you?”

“Eh? Aren’t you just, like, jumping to conclusions? Maybe I just happened to be in the neighborhood.”

“Then you didn’t need to run away from me, did you?”

“If a girl came running at you with a scary look on her face, who wouldn’t run away? Plus, I didn’t wanna be suspected.”

“I don’t believe you. Not at all.”

“So in other words, Nanase-chan, you’ve just up and decided that I pushed those two senpais down the slope, is that right?”

“I’m sure of it. It’s almost impossible that I’m wrong.”

“You’re soooo sure, and yet you felt the need to throw in an ‘almost’, huh? Wouldn’t it, like, make more sense to say you’ve actually got no idea?”

The two girls, fellow group members, exchanged words back and forth, keeping one another in check.

“Then, can you swear to me that you weren’t the one who hurt them?”

“I can swear it, sure, but it doesn’t really matter whether I keep my word or not, right?”

Amasawa was basically saying that, at the end of the day, a verbal promise didn’t mean anything.

“Lemme just ask: If it really was me, what would you do? What then?”

Rather than try to escape from Nanase’s incessant questioning, Amasawa instead dove in head-first of her own accord.

Nanase was probably feeling a little overwhelmed at this point, but she pressed on nonetheless, determined to find out the truth.

“I’d want you to tell me why you did something like that. To give me a reason. No, before any of that, why didn’t your name come up back when the teachers investigated the surrounding GPS signals in the first place?”

This didn’t seem like something that Amasawa needed to explain, so I spoke up instead.

“It’s not that hard to get rid of a GPS signal. You just need to break your watch, that’s all.”

“Ding ding ding~ Correct~! Whether intentionally done or not, a broken watch is a broken watch. And you can get it replaced for free too!”

With a delighted expression, Amasawa showed us the watch attached to her right wrist.

“But even if you broke your GPS before the attack, wouldn’t the school have taken notice?”

“Yeah prolly. But in this case at least, I think it wouldda been pretty tricky to notice with how much of a rush they were in at the time.”

There were well over 400 GPS signals on the island. Even if one or two had been missing from the map, there’s no way they would’ve noticed it back then, and it’s not like they

had the time to check everything either. The teachers rightfully needed to prioritize the safety and well-being of the students.

“The school would still conduct a thorough investigation later on though, right? It’d only be a matter of time before they found out.”

Since Shinohara herself had testified that they had been attacked by someone, the school would definitely investigate the case in detail.

And, in the process, it was highly likely that they’d find out that Amasawa’s GPS signal was the only one that had disappeared.

However, therein lies the problem.

“If Amasawa’s GPS signal was the only one missing back when Komiya and Kinoshita were attacked, the school would definitely be suspicious. But that’s it. Due to a lack of evidence they wouldn’t be able to conclude that she’s the culprit.”

“That—”

Having personally witnessed Amasawa’s presence at the site of the attack, Nanase wanted to identify her as the culprit.

However, proving a crime was much harder than she was making it out to be. No matter what, the school had to avoid forcing someone’s retirement due to a false accusation.

Originally, the wristwatch had been meant as a way for the school to safeguard the rules of the exam and maintain order, and yet students could effectively circumvent that to their heart’s content.

In order to prevent students from abusing the system, the school would have to implement strong penalties for breaking the watches, such as limiting the number of times they can be replaced, charging points, or even mandating retirement.

However, the stronger the penalties, the more susceptible to abuse the system becomes as a whole. For example, it would open up the possibility of tampering with or breaking a competitor’s watch to make them face the penalties. Furthermore, if students were forced to retire due to a genuine accident or software malfunction, it would probably make for a fairly unsatisfactory special exam.

“Poking holes in the rules is standard practice. If the school can’t even find any evidence, you’re free to do whatever you want.”

Although her phrasing was a bit awkward, what Amasawa was saying was correct.

“If they can’t find any evidence, then I’ll just have to testify that I saw you there, Amasawa-san.”

“Same difference. Be it my broken GPS or my presence at the scene of the crime, it would only end with suspicion at best.”

If it had been one of the more problematic students like Sudō or Ryūen, who had a history of highly violent behavior, the school might have been more suspicious. Amasawa, however, was a first-year high school girl with a spotless record. Given her character evidence, the probability of the school finding her guilty wasn’t very high.

What’s more, Komiya and Kinoshita didn’t even testify that they had been attacked in the first place, and Shinohara herself had only been able to make a vague statement, unable to say who it was she saw.

Nanase’s testimony of seeing Amasawa in the area would be treated no differently.

Without conclusive evidence, it would be impossible to get the school to punish Amasawa.

“That’s how it is, Nanase-chan.”

At the end of the day, we still didn’t know the reason why Amasawa had come here.

The continuous back and forth between Nanase’s questions and Amasawa’s evasive wordplay didn’t seem to be getting us anywhere.

As such, it was getting harder and harder to believe that she’d suddenly spring a trap on us at this point.

For the time being, we might as well set aside the matter of whether or not she was the one behind what had happened to Komiya and Kinoshita.

I figured that I should ask something to get past the current stalemate and steer the conversation back on track.

“What are you doing here Amasawa? No, how did you find us?”

Considering that there was still more than a week left in the special exam, it would be best for all of us to avoid standing out in the pouring rain like this.

We needed to pitch our tents and escape from the downpour as soon as possible.

“No need to be in such a hurry, Ayanokōji-senpai. Let’s just appreciate that we could meet each other like this~!”

“Sorry, but the rain has been far more taxing on my stamina than I anticipated. Let’s get this over with. Please.”

“Well~, how about I help you pitch a tent and we spend the night together, just the two of us? How’s that?”

Boys and girls were expressly prohibited from spending the night together in the same tent, something that she too, should’ve been fully aware of.

She was probably trying to stall for time by engaging me in a meaningless conversation.

“Ah, are you worried about breaking the rules? It’s fine, it’s fine. Even the school can’t monitor everything, you know?”

As soon as Amasawa took a step forward, Nanase immediately closed in and grabbed her by the arm.

“What’s with this, Nanase-chan?”

“You were about to lay your hands on Ayanokōji-senpai, weren’t you?”

“Since when were you his knight in shining armor? Weren’t you like, plotting to get him expelled together with Hōsen-kun?”

“That… That has nothing to do with you. Why did you come here?”

“I just happened to get lost, so I came to try and ask you guys for help.”

Amasawa told a bald-faced lie, seemingly without any intention of keeping up appearances anymore.

Had she perhaps come all the way out here to see the outcome of my fight with Nanase and survey the aftermath?

She'd probably be able to tell that Nanase had changed sides as well, given the way she was acting.

But that didn't add up. After all, there'd be little reason for her to stick around and take part in such a meaningless conversation if that were the case.

"I'd like to chat with Ayanokōji-senpai, so could you let go and step aside?"

"Why don't you just talk from where you are?"

"Well there's no way I could do that. It has to do with the White Room, after all~"

Amasawa confessed, having apparently come to the conclusion that there was no point in hiding her true identity any longer.

Surprised, Nanase turned around and looked at me.

Throughout this first semester, the existence of the White Room student had always been on my radar, yet I hadn't been able to pinpoint their identity.

That being said, I had never imagined that I'd find out due to an outright confession.

"Do you get it now? Little miss *outsider*~"
If Amasawa really was the White Room student, then it would certainly make sense that she would call Nanase an outsider.

"Let go of her arm Nanase."

Although clearly somewhat dissatisfied, Nanase obediently let go of Amasawa's arm just as I instructed.

"Wow, you're such a good girl Nanase-chan~! It's like you're his loyal dog; it's a better look for you than I thought."

At that, Amasawa slowly began to draw closer to me, little by little.

I was exasperated, but at least the conversation might finally get somewhere now.

"Sorry but given a prior misunderstanding with Nanase, I won't be jumping to any conclusions just because you brought up the White Room."

“That’s fine, I’ll prove to you that I’m the real deal. However… letting Nanase-chan hear it is a bit…”

She trailed off, mouthing the words ‘You get it, right?’ with that usual devilish grin of hers plastered onto her face.

I lightly motioned to Nanase, instructing her to distance herself. Although she was reluctant to leave me alone with Amasawa, she eventually gave in and followed suit. The pouring rain had grown stronger, to the point where she wouldn’t be able to hear us if we talked quietly from a few meters away.

Treading the muddy ground below, Amasawa finally came within arm’s reach.

“Now then, where oh where should I start~?”

She put her hand on her chin, a grandiose motion meant to signify that she was thinking over how exactly to go about explaining herself.

In any case, the fact that she came here in the first place really didn’t make any sense to me.

For the past several months, the White Room student had been lurking in the shadows, waiting for their chance to get me expelled.

And yet, Amasawa had appeared in front of me and revealed her true identity without so much as a single trick up her sleeve.

Furthermore, the fact that she was of two minds over what to say at this point was strange to begin with.

It seemed fairly obvious that she was intentionally drawing this out and stalling for time.

Just as I began to contemplate whether or not to press her about that, Amasawa opened her mouth.

“Senpai, the curriculum you took back when you were 10 years old included Systems’ Theory based on Project 5. And at the age of 11 it was the Theory of Relativity based on Project 7. I took part in both myself, so I remember them well.”

She began mentioning specific pieces of information about the White Room to prove that we had come from the same place.

“The classrooms, the corridors, our assigned living chambers… everything was a world of pure white.”

At the very least, it seemed Amasawa knew a lot more about the White Room than Nanase did.

And it was too hard for me to imagine that she had heard about it from Tsukishiro.

He would never talk about the inner workings of the White Room with someone unrelated – an outsider.

As such, it was probably safe to conclude Amasawa’s *guilt*.
From the things she knew to the way she conducted herself, she fit the image of a White Room student to a T.

“Why would you go through the trouble of making yourself seem like a normal person only to reveal your identity to me like this?”

“Sure sure, I figured you’d be curious about that. It’s cuz I wanted to tell you that I’m not your enemy, Senpai.”

“That doesn’t add up. The White Room student was sent here in order to force my expulsion. To say that you’re not my enemy in light of that doesn’t make much sense.”

Completely unconcerned with the fact that our clothes were being drenched by the rain, Amasawa continued to speak.

“You wouldn’t know this as part of the fourth generation, Ayanokōji-senpai, but the later generations harbor immense feelings of jealousy when it comes to you. The higher-ups probably thought that they could select someone promising and manipulate this jealousy to force your expulsion. However, they chose the wrong person. They didn’t predict that I was but a young maiden who secretly idolized you.”

“So, that’s why you revealed yourself?”

She nodded with a quiet ‘Mhm’.

“Then, wouldn’t it have been better for you to do this back when you first enrolled here? You even managed to step foot in my dorm room on more than one occasion, so you should’ve had plenty of chances to tell me.”

“Well, no matter how much you might idolize someone, that’s just like, all in your head, you know? You’ve gotta talk with them and meet face-to-face before your admiration starts to feel justified. That takes time.”

In other words, if I hadn’t turned out to be someone Amasawa deemed worthy of idolizing, then it’s possible that she would’ve moved to eliminate me. And based on the flow of our conversation thus far, that seemed fairly reasonable.

“Do you understand?”

“I guess. Only someone who’s been at the White Room would be able to say so much about it.”

“There we go~. It feels kinda strange, doesn’t it? To pass the days at school as an ordinary high schooler.”

Before, I had been the only one to experience the strange, peculiar sensation she was talking about. But knowing that another White Room student was now going through the same thing had filled me with genuine curiosity.

“If you feel the same as I do, then surely you’ve also noticed how interesting this school is, right?”

“I know exactly what you mean, Senpai. I too have thought about how nice it’d be if I could just enjoy being a student like this up until graduation. I’ve thought about it several times, actually. I suck at making friends though, so I just don’t have very many people to talk to.”

In a way, she was quite similar to me.

Although I could talk to people like Horikita and Ike, it had always felt like there was some sort of distance between us.

Thinking back on it, for quite a while, it felt as though I couldn’t honestly call anyone a friend.

“That doesn’t mean that I lack communication skills like you do Senpai.”

As if fully aware of what I was thinking, Amasawa spoke up to clarify.

“I was taught essentially the same stuff you were, Senpai. But at the same time, there are certain things that only the fifth generation of students that came after you could learn.”

She paused for a moment to see if I wanted to say something before continuing.

“It’s said that, before the fifth generation, children were often crushed one after another due to their excessive individualism. Of course, those with poor scores notwithstanding, those with excellent scores were still allowed to come in contact with each other. In my generation, on the other hand, all children were required to maintain a minimum level of interpersonal communication.”

If she was telling the truth, then I could understand why it seemed so easy for her to make such a rich assortment of different facial expressions. Even though I could pretend to be someone else in the short-term thanks to my acting skills, it was hard to break the habit that had formed from living most of my life devoid of emotion.

“Still don’t believe me?”

“I believe you’re from the White Room, but I’m not convinced with the reason you gave me for why you revealed your identity.”

“You’re awfully calm and composed for someone who believes that I’m a White Room student. Perhaps you don’t think I’ll be a threat to you?”

I said nothing in response to this, prompting a smile to creep onto her face.

“Well then~ I’ve said everything I wanted to say to you, so I guess it’s about time I excuse myself.”

Saying that, she turned her back to me, content with simply being recognized as the White Room student.

“What are you thinking, Amasawa?”

“Jeez~ Didn’t I tell you already~? I admire you, Ayanokōji-senpai. That’s all.”

Looking back, she reached out and brushed the tips of her fingers, wet and cold from the rain, up against my cheek.

“So please, don’t go and get yourself crushed without my permission, okay?”

And with that, she pulled back her hand and walked away, headed off to who knows where.

She said ‘don’t go and get yourself crushed’… but by whom? Tsukishiro? The first-years who had their sights set on the twenty million private point bounty? Or, perhaps…

“Ayanokōji-senpai, are you alright? She didn’t do anything to you right?”

Having noticed Amasawa’s departure, Nanase rushed back over to me, worried. I nodded along to try and ease her concerns before looking over toward my backpack.

“The rain. We’d better hurry.”

I wanted to take some time to process everything, but there were other things that took priority at the moment.

“Yes! We should set up the tents, right?”

“Yeah.”

I responded affirmatively, but there was still one thing I couldn’t afford to forget about.

Namely, checking the footprints that Amasawa left behind.

“Senpai…?”

“The rain will wash away her footprints soon.”

Amasawa had only just left, and yet her footprints were already starting to lose their shape.

“Amasawa-san’s… footprints? Is there something wrong with her footprints?”

“Back when Komiya and Kinoshita were attacked, I found some footprints nearby the scene of the crime. From what I can tell, I’m fairly confident that they’re the same size as Amasawa’s.”

In other words, Amasawa had definitely been there, just like Nanase claimed she was.

“So rather than just happening to be in the area, you’re saying that she’s the one who pushed them down the slope?”

“I don’t know about that. It’s probably safe to conclude that she’s the one who was watching us back then, but there’s still no conclusive evidence pointing to her as the one who pushed them.”

For a moment, it didn’t seem like Nanase understood what I was talking about.

“There may not be any solid evidence. However, shouldn’t it be fine to assume that it was her?”

“Based on the information we have on hand right now, Amasawa is certainly the most likely culprit.”

“Exactly, I think so too. I know I’m repeating myself at this point, but she’s definitely the one I saw back then.”

And she clearly wasn’t wrong about that either.

“However, it’s not like you actually saw her push them.”

“That… well… she just confessed not too long ago though.”

“It’s hard to call that a confession. She just asked what you’d do if she was the one who pushed them. That’s a far cry from explicitly admitting that she’s the culprit.”

“Maybe she only put it that way because she was afraid that we were recording her or something?”

“With how loud this rain is and the circumstances we’re in, I don’t think she needed to be on guard about that.”

At a glance, this didn’t seem like the type of environment suitable for recording anything.

“You still can’t be absolutely certain. She’s well aware that you’re an opponent she ought to be wary of, so it’s reasonable to assume that she took any and all precautions necessary.”

To eliminate all potential risks, that would indeed be a wise choice.

“If she deliberately inflicted potentially life-threatening injuries on two upperclassmen, then she should’ve hightailed it out of there immediately after she did the deed. Why would she stick around and let you see her as she ran away?”

Nanase pondered how to respond for a moment as she retrieved her backpack.

“That’s… I imagine that’s because she was interested in what happened to Komiya-senpai and Kinoshita-senpai. It’s the same mentality as how an arsonist always returns to the scene of the crime.”

It’s true that there was a saying that arsonists, or criminals in general, always return to the scene of their crime.

Although there were plenty of theories about this phenomenon, it was risky to try and relate it to this particular situation. If we were to speculate based on the assumption that Amasawa was the culprit, then we wouldn’t be able to see past the superficial.

“Pushing two people down a slope is a heartless act in and of itself, so it doesn’t make sense that she’d risk returning to the scene of the crime just because she was interested in what happened to them. There’s also the fact that you were able to identify her as she ran away. Honestly, I find it hard to believe that someone sent here by Tsukishiro would make a mistake like that.”

I began to trace back the rapidly fading footprints so as to make sure I wasn’t missing out on anything.

“That being said, I wonder why she revealed her identity to us like this?”

“I figure she did it because she knew I saw her back then and that she wouldn’t be able to hide it anymore. Even though it wouldn’t prove her guilt if I were to report it to the school, it would still lead to problems for her, right? After all, the mission Acting Director Tsukishiro entrusted her with would be put in jeopardy.”

“In the end, that contradicts the fact that she returned to the scene of the crime.”

“Can’t we just chalk that up as a careless mistake on her part?”

“That’s impossible.”

Perhaps Amasawa intentionally let Nanase find her for some reason?

Just as I began to mull over that very possibility, I came across a new hint.

“As I thought, there’s something about each and every one of Amasawa’s actions that can’t be overlooked.”

“Something that can’t be overlooked?”

I pointed at Amasawa’s trail of footprints, which were now on the verge of being washed away by the rain.

“Her footprints seem clean and steady as she was making her approach from behind, but… the ones before that—”

“Eh!? These…”

Nanase finally noticed the strange discrepancy as well.

“These are someone else’s footprints, aren’t they?”

“Yeah.”

There were another set of footprints that seemed slightly larger than Amasawa’s, but it wasn’t possible to determine their actual size because they had already lost their shape.

“Whoever it was, it looks like they were closing in on us until right around here, where they met with Amasawa’s footprints. Something happened at that point since the tracks get messy, but you can see here how the mystery footprints end up turning back around.”

“So, you’re saying that… someone else was here only moments before Amasawa-san called out to us…?”

Whether they were a student or a member of the school’s faculty, there seemed to be no way to tell for sure.

“Can you fetch me that stick Amasawa was holding earlier?”

“O-okay!”

She went off to fetch the stick and handed it over to me.

Once I saw it close-up, all of my speculation thus far finally arrived at one singular answer.

“What do you think, Nanase? Do you notice anything?”

“Do I notice anything…? Well I think it’d be dangerous to hit someone with it. Wait, actually…”

Nanase took back the stick and after holding onto it for a second, it dawned on her.

“This… This doesn’t seem like something you’d find lying around the forest.”

“Yeah. It’s been whittled down in certain places so it can be better used as a weapon. Looking at other branches in the area, its shape is just too unnatural.”

“Do you think she was going to use this to try and attack you, Ayanokōji-senpai?”

“If Amasawa really planned on attacking me, then she should’ve tried to catch me off-guard instead of calling out like she did. That being said, even though she had a dangerous weapon in hand, it didn’t seem like she had any ill intentions. If anything, I think she just wanted us to notice her presence.”

And, there was yet another thing that could be gleaned from this.

“That is to say, she had no intention of attacking us from the very beginning… Wouldn’t that mean that the one who originally brought this here was not Amasawa-san, but the mysterious person who vanished before she approached us?”

The mystery footprints seemed to take short strides as they approached us, but when they turned back after meeting with Amasawa, the strides they took grew further apart. They left as if they were trying to avoid being noticed, or rather, as if they were trying to run away.

“But why?”

“From what Amasawa told me, I’m apparently the subject of her admiration. So it doesn’t seem that far-fetched to think that she might’ve just wanted to protect me when I was about to be attacked.”

“It feels a little risky to assume she’s an ally based on that alone though…”

“Naturally. However, these footprints are clearly targeting me, and I can’t even hazard a guess as to who made them.”

“Do… you perhaps think it could’ve been a school faculty member?”

“That’s possible, but it’s also true that I have a bounty on my head.”

There was a high chance that these mystery footprints belonged to a student who had their sights set on cashing out my bounty.

It was completely conceivable that someone would be willing to stake their own future to try and force my expulsion.

“Oh! That’s it!”

Having apparently come to some sort of realization, Nanase suddenly raised her voice.

“Senpai, let’s do a GPS Search right now! It hasn’t been that long since Amasawa-san first approached us. Even if this mystery person ran away at full speed, they shouldn’t have been able to get very far with the weather like this, right?”

She wasn’t wrong. If we did a GPS Search right now and there were signals in the surrounding area, we could narrow down the list of suspects all in one go. It’d be as simple as going through the closest signals one by one to see who they were.

“Oh, but we wouldn’t be able to identify them if they broke their watch like Amasawa-san did, would we…”

“No, that’s not true. When you break your watch, your GPS signal disappears. Amasawa aside, if we did a search right now and there was only one student with a missing signal, what then?”

“…Then that’s our guy.”

“Yeah. Therefore, we can conclude that the person who tried to attack me definitely didn’t break their watch.”

“It’s worth our while to spend the point on a search then, right?”

It had only been about fifteen minutes since Amasawa first called out to me.

So, even if they ran at full speed, they would’ve only made it to the edge of area D3 by now at the very most.

With a bit of luck, there would only be one signal that fit these conditions, allowing us to pinpoint the owner of these mysterious footprints.

As such, it made sense that I should go along with Nanase's idea and do a GPS Search right here, right now, but…

"I won't be using the GPS Search."

"Eh!? W-why not!?"

"At the end of the day, it wouldn't be surprising if this was all part of a strategy to bait me into making a GPS Search so that someone completely unrelated who just happened to be nearby would come to the forefront."

It was hard to say with any finality that this wasn't an attempt to mislead us into suspecting an innocent person. One should always exercise caution in situations where an opponent was spoonfeeding you information, such as how Amasawa deliberately allowed Nanase to catch sight of her as she fled the crime scene, or even Amasawa's presence here today in general.

"It still feels like a bit of a waste to not even check."

"If it were me, I wouldn't be foolish enough to get caught by something as trivial as this. If they can't even take the GPS Search feature into account before taking action, then they're certainly not anybody we need to be worried about."

Although Nanase didn't seem fully convinced, she eventually conceded and complied with my decision.

In any case, even though I still wanted to collect my thoughts, that wasn't going to happen given the way the weather was headed.

After deciding to cut the conversation short, we hurriedly went about setting up our tents.

It wouldn't be an exaggeration to say that heavy rain was really coming down at this point.

Our tents were pitched with the entrances put face-to-face, and once everything was in order, we promptly hid ourselves inside, taking refuge from the rain.

I peeled off my drenched gym uniform, jersey, and underwear before drying my hair and body with a towel.

And then, after changing into a spare set of clothes, I slightly unzipped the entrance and took a peek outside. It was still early afternoon, but the outside world was as dark as night.

We were probably going to be stuck here for the rest of the day, at the very least.

The raindrops were practically shoving their way in through the hole in the entrance, so I zipped it closed and laid down on my sleeping bag.

In this short time, I had found out about Nanase's past and identified Amasawa as the White Room student.

However, that didn't mean that all the fog had been lifted.

Part 1

As the downpour continued, a message arrived from the school. Unsurprisingly, it was an announcement that the exam would be canceled for the day. Since it'd be difficult for groups to make a comeback with all the lost opportunity for Tasks and area movement, the message also stated that they were looking into ways to compensate us so that students didn't have to go to bed worried about missing out on points.

The school probably wouldn't specify how they planned on compensating us until the weather began to clear up.

That being said, no matter what they eventually came up with, it wouldn't change the fact that the day had been wasted.

While the compensation would help groups reach the same overall score in the long run, the strategies they had planned for today would all be in vain.

Personally, as far as I was concerned, the cancellation could not have come at a worse time.

My plan had been to conserve my energy so that I could go all-out during the second half of the exam, stealing a march on the groups who were in a slump after exhausting their energy during the first half and racking up a ton of points in the process. However, now that the seventh day had essentially turned into a full day off, everybody would have the time to rest and recover their stamina.

Of course, an uninhabited island during a rainstorm wasn't exactly a day at the spa, so it's not like their fatigue would disappear entirely. But, the disparity between getting time to rest and not getting any at all made all the difference in the world.

"——pai!"

"Hmm?"

I could just barely make out a voice through the incessantly loud sound of raindrops beating against the exterior of my tent.

"Sen—ai!"

Once again, the voice called out to me. It was most likely Nanase, trying to talk to me from the tent across from my own. I unzipped my tent's entrance a bit and peered out through the mesh fabric to see what was happening.

The visibility of the outside world was rather poor, but it wasn't so bad that I couldn't make out Nanase's tent in front of me.

"I'd like to talk to you for a bit, Senpai! Is it alright if I come and join you!?"

Nanase put forward a question, shouting out from her own tent.

She should've been aware that it wasn't exactly proper for a boy and a girl to huddle up alone together in a single tent, but she had apparently forgotten all about that.

The rules expressly forbade boys and girls from sleeping together in the same tent, so there technically wouldn't be an issue if we were only spending a bit of time together.

And as long as we didn't lose our sense of reason, there shouldn't be anything ethically or morally wrong about it either.

Having said that, the rain was still as fierce as ever. Even though our tents were less than two meters apart, there'd be no way for her to avoid getting wet again.

“That’s fine with me, but why don’t I come join you in your tent instead?”

I tried offering her an alternative, but she simply shook her head as she unfolded a towel and draped it over herself in preparation for the journey before fully unzipping the entrance to her tent.

Following her lead, I quickly opened my own entrance to usher her inside as soon as possible.

Just as I did, Nanase swiftly flew out of her tent and made her way into mine.

Of course, she was only in the rain for less than a second, so the damage had been kept to a minimum.

“Hah… I’m sorry for intruding upon your rest, Senpai.”

“No, it’s okay.”

In truth, Nanase was probably more exhausted than I was.

It had been an arduous journey to get all the way out here, one that was immediately followed by a fierce battle, misunderstanding as it was.

I was curious as to what she wanted to talk about, but she didn’t say anything right away.

Or, from what it seemed like, it might be more accurate to say that she couldn’t find the words.

For a while, the two of us sat in silence, merely observing one another…

“I’m pretty shameless, aren’t I?”

Saying that, Nanase lowered her head in apology.

“I treated you with such hostility for the longest time, Senpai. Saying all sorts of terrible things straight to your face… You must be annoyed that I’m reaching out all buddy-buddy like this.”

It was a bit late by this point, but it seemed that she was finally coming to terms with her guilty conscience.

“I really don’t mind, so please stop apologizing. At the very least, it’s been made clear that there’s no need for further hostility between us, or am I wrong?”

There was probably a part of her that wouldn’t be satisfied with a response like this, but we were currently in the middle of a special exam.

Hesitation of the mind would only cloud one’s conduct and judgment when it mattered most.

“No, you’re right.”

Having understood this for herself, Nanase once again lowered her head in apology.

“So? Despite the rain, wasn’t there something you wanted to talk to me about?”

“Ah, indeed!”

As if reminded of why she came to my tent in the first place, Nanase began to speak.

“I haven’t been able to get the image of Amasawa-san out of my mind, showing up out of nowhere in the rain… When I started thinking about all the hardships you’ve been put through, I just… I felt like I had to call out to you.”

Apparently, instead of having some sort of ulterior motive, she had simply been worried about me.

It was a slight problem that she was more caught up about the whole ordeal than I was, but I appreciated the sentiment nonetheless.

“I convinced myself that Amasawa-san was the one who pushed Komiya-senpai and Kinoshita-senpai down the slope. I thought that she was just hiding her true nature because she wanted to hide the truth, but then you said that she wasn’t necessarily the culprit and now I just don’t know what to believe anymore…”

“That’s because the truth is still shrouded in darkness.”

Amasawa’s color was grey, a grey that just barely toed the line before being dyed in black, but she definitely hadn’t crossed that line just yet.

“I wonder what the culprit’s goal is. Whoever they are, why would they do something so risky like this?”

“We wouldn’t be having such a hard time if we knew the answer to that. So, let’s move forward under the assumption that Amasawa is not the culprit.”

We decided to review our thoughts regarding the Komiya-Kinoshita incident.

After all, by exchanging opinions, we’d be able to shed light on things we may not have considered otherwise.

From what we knew: someone had pushed Komiya and Kinoshita down the slope. And, judging from the fact that there were no other GPS signals in the area at the time, it was clear that it had been a premeditated attack, rather than something done in the heat of the moment.

Furthermore—

“That… Uhm, wouldn’t that be strange though?”

As soon as she began to speak, Nanase furrowed her brow, as though there was some sort of discrepancy she couldn’t wrap her head around.

“It’d be weird if Amasawa-san was completely unrelated, right? I mean, her watch just ‘happened’ to be broken when Komiya and Kinoshita just ‘happened’ to get attacked, and she just ‘happened’ to be watching from somewhere nearby? And to top it all off, I just ‘happened’ to catch sight of her as she fled the scene?”

“With so many coincidences happening back-to-back, it’s hard to call the entire thing one as well. We’d basically be setting ourselves up for failure telling ourselves that Amasawa is 100% unrelated to what happened.”

“Even if Amasawa-san isn’t the real culprit, they’d still have to be someone she knows, right? Therefore, isn’t it also possible that she’s an accomplice of some sort?”

With that, an alternative theory began to take shape: that someone close to Amasawa had pushed Komiya and Kinoshita instead.

“That seems reasonable. Those footprints I found earlier could’ve belonged to the real culprit as well.”

If we were to look at what happened as an attempt to help the real culprit, it’d more or less explain Amasawa’s actions.

“I suppose it’s not hard to imagine that Amasawa-san is capable of exercising violence in much the same way.”

Nanase nodded to herself as she said this, confident that we were on the right track.

“However…”

At this point… Well, I started feeling caught up about something completely unrelated to any of this.

“However what?”

It had to do with Nanase, but when I saw her looking over at me with a puzzled expression on her face, I felt hesitant to say anything.

If I had to give a reason for that, it was because I simply couldn’t understand the ‘mechanisms’ behind what was going on.

This was our seventh day on the uninhabited island, and Nanase had been together with me for effectively the entire time so far. As such, neither of us had the time nor space to wash our bodies properly.

Of course, she had the opportunity to rinse the sand and sweat off her body back when she changed into a swimsuit during the Beach Flags Task, and she had also probably taken a shower after taking part in the swimming Task in the starting area.

That being said, even a single day’s worth of sweat and perspiration would usually end up being fairly noticeable.

Since there wasn’t very much room inside my cramped one-person tent, Nanase’s scent had slowly filled the space. But, strangely enough, it wasn’t exactly an unpleasant smell. Even though it was possible that she masked the smell of sweat by diligently wiping down her body, I just couldn’t wrap my head around how she managed to make herself smell so good.

I wanted to ask her about it, but that was clearly not something a tactful senpai ought to be doing.

“No, I just misunderstood something. Don’t worry about it.”

“Is that so?”

She nodded along without probing any further, and perhaps without even suspecting anything at all.

Although I had a girlfriend, I was still just a beginner when it came to this sort of stuff, and there were just too many things that I didn't understand.

Things like deodorant and antiperspirant spray were relatively cheap and easy for us to get our hands on because of the rules, so I ultimately opted to tell myself that she used something like that. It was the only answer I could come up with at the moment.

Even though I had chosen not to say anything, the mood between us had somehow gotten strangely awkward.

And while Nanase didn't seem to think anything of it, I decided to get our conversation back on track in an attempt to loosen up the atmosphere again.

"We don't have any way to confirm whether or not Amasawa actually did something to Komiya and Kinoshita, but I do have a pretty good idea which Table everyone belongs to."

Nanase tilted her head to the side, seemingly unable to understand what I meant by this, so I took out my tablet and showed it to her.

"Uhm… Your personal information is on there, right Ayanokōji-senpai…? Are you sure it's okay for me to be seeing this?"

By personal information, she was probably talking about the points I had earned thus far. This was indeed very important information since the points and rankings of groups outside of the top and bottom ten weren't publicly disclosed.

"Nanase, I thought we had a relationship where we could trust each other without hiding anything. Or was that just a misunderstanding on my part?"

I spoke openly, prompting her to match her eyes with mine, clearly taken aback.

"What? No! Thank you for placing your trust in me! I'm very grateful!"

Her words were filled with a slight mixture of embarrassment, happiness, and guilt.

In fact, her reluctance to write off the discourtesy she had shown me so far was very fitting of her.

“Besides, since we’ve been moving together, you should already be able to get a rough estimate of how many points I’ve earned just by thinking back on it.”

Although I had taken part in a handful of Tasks on my own, from what I knew of Nanase, she’d at least be able to estimate my score under the assumption that I had taken first place in them.

Therefore, without paying any mind to the fact that I was revealing sensitive information, I began with my explanation.

“Anyways, regarding what I said earlier about knowing who was included in each Table—”

“Wait, isn’t your score somehow… lower than expected?”

Astute as ever, Nanase immediately noticed that a certain something was out of place before I could even get into the thick of it.

“What do you mean?”

I responded to her question with one of my own, testing her. She began counting on her fingers as she ran the calculations in her head.

“There are Arrival Bonuses, Early Bird Bonuses, and Tasks… then subtracting points for any penalties— Ah, I’m also assuming that you took first place in the Tasks you took part in while I was taking a break.”

All things considered, her memory seemed quite solid.

This was a good thing too, as a solid memory would probably prove useful for her at some point in the future.

“I’m surprised you noticed. Properly speaking, I should have 88 points right now.”

“But you only have 78, 10 points less. I don’t think I forgot a penalty or something either…”

Thus, it begged the question: how, when, and why did those 10 points disappear? The answer to which I would now elaborate.

“For this special exam, designated areas are announced four times per day as students move throughout the island. This time window lasts for ten hours per day, from 7:00 AM to 5:00 PM. Yesterday, when the school lifted the restriction on the GPS searching feature, I decided to do a total of ten searches. The first was at 7:00 AM and I repeated it every hour on the hour until 5:00 PM. That is, with the exception of the break at noon.”

As for why I had done this, it didn’t seem like Nanase had connected the dots just yet.

“The GPS searching feature is an extremely convenient tool that allows you to find out the location of every student on the island. However, if used only a single time, you’d just get a glimpse at everyone’s current location, so its overall usefulness is marginal. But by splitting up the day into parts and doing ten of them, you’re able to find out all sorts of things that you couldn’t before.”

By connecting all the different dots into lines, you’d be left with the various routes that everyone had taken throughout the day. If someone else were to run ten searches of their own, they’d learn that Nanase and I were always traveling together.

“Uhm, I already understand what you used your points on, Senpai. And I agree that if you know where everyone’s moving on an hourly basis, you might be able to find out which Tables they belong to. However, it didn’t seem like you were doing very much with your tablet yesterday, and it’s not very easy information to memorize either… Are you… Are you really telling me that you memorized everything in an instant?”

“That’d be impossible. It’d take an enormous amount of time just to check everyone’s name and location.”

I opened up my tablet’s picture storage and showed her the images I had saved there.

“After running the GPS Search, I took a high-quality screenshot of the results and saved it. This way, I can study the images during my spare time and slowly analyze the movements groups made that day whenever I want.”

While we couldn’t send messages or photographs to anyone during the exam, saving screenshots to our own device was a built-in feature of our tablets, so it was only natural that we could make use of it. By repeatedly scrutinizing the screenshots, it was possible to keep a detailed, persistent record of every single student’s position.

“By thoroughly cross-referencing the images, I’m left with what’s essentially a record of an entire day’s worth of movement that can be viewed at any time.”

There’d be plenty of time to look at the data too, be it just before going to bed at night, in the morning before the exam started, or even during the two-hour break period at lunch.

And while it was only for the sixth day, the screenshots also showed the details of the Tasks that were available at the time, so we could gain some insight into the higher-level strategies that each group was using as well.

"...I didn't even realize that you had done this, Senpai."

"I'm not so foolish as to let a potential enemy catch wind of what I'm up to. After all, I had no idea what kind of person you truly were."

At the time, I still saw Nanase as an enemy, so it would've been immensely foolish to tell her about what I was doing with the GPS Search. Students had quite a few reasons to always be using their tablets, from confirming their current locations to checking the details of nearby Tasks, so it wouldn't seem that unnatural for me to be focused on it throughout the day.

It had been as simple as taking a screenshot of the GPS Search results every hour or so, all while staying on top of my designated areas and Tasks.

Impressed, Nanase began to swipe through the screenshots. Every time she went to the next image, the GPS signals of every student on the island would change places on the map.

"I say this with all due respect, but is this really worth paying ten whole points for? If it was possible to share the screenshots with someone, then there might be some added value, but it'd take a considerable amount of time for one person to analyze the movement patterns on their own, wouldn't it?"

It was true that these images would be more valuable if we could attach them to a text message or email of some sort and send them out to our peers. By collaborating with several people, it would open up the possibility to run searches in shorter time intervals, or even keep track of other groups outside of the standard exam hours. I wouldn't be shocked if the other classes implemented a plan exactly like that if we weren't explicitly restricted from doing so.

"Even if I'm just one person, it all depends on how I make use of it. You could say that whether or not this was worth the points I spent will be decided in the days to come."

"And by that you mean...?"

"Well, let me show you some of the information I've found out from it so far."

From the first-years to the third-years, all kinds of new things could be found out by looking at the data based on grade level.

In the case of the third-years, in particular, there was clearly something peculiar going on with regard to their movements.

“For example, some third-year groups moved fairly unusually throughout the day yesterday. Furthermore, these groups are always closely related to Nagumo’s group or Kiriyama’s group. When I looked into it, I noticed something pretty interesting.”

Starting at 7:00 AM on the sixth day, we traced the position of Nagumo’s group hour-by-hour as they moved throughout the island.

“To begin with, Nagumo’s group was in area B8 at 7:00 AM that morning.”

“Does that mean his last designated area on the fifth day was area B8?”

“That’s highly likely, but he was at the southernmost edge of the area, so he could’ve actually started at area B9 instead. In any case, the only other GPS signals in the area at the time were those of his own group members.”

However, at 8:00 AM, only an hour later, several other groups had begun to concentrate in the area around Nagumo.

The trend became even more pronounced at 9:00 AM, making it clear that groups were actively seeking out and meeting with him.

And from that point on, the large conglomerate of groups began to move.

By 10:00 and 11:00 AM, the obscurity of what was taking place became even more apparent.

“There are so many groups moving around together… almost like they’re a school of fish.”

“With just a glance at the data, you wouldn’t even notice it, but it paints a completely different picture once you know what to look for, right?”

Nanase nodded a few times in response as we proceeded to flip through the next couple of screenshots. Once we got to the one I had taken at 3:00 PM, she asked a question.

“Are they… doing this to monopolize Tasks?”

“Most likely, the point is to have Nagumo effortlessly secure first-place in any Task they come across by fixing the competition in his favor.”

It wasn’t complicated in the slightest. Rather, it was a very simple strategy, and a potent one at that.

“However, groups other than President Nagumo’s won’t be able to score points as a result, right? I can’t imagine that they’re all part of the same Table either. Working together for the success of a specific group… It’s an idea that pretty much anyone could come up with, but it’d be impossible to put it into practice effectively.”

Groups would need to forego their own designated areas as they wasted their time traveling with those in other Tables.

Moreover, by yielding first place to Nagumo’s group, they wouldn’t be able to earn many points from Tasks either.

“You’re not wrong. But, the reason the strategy works is because it disregards one of the most basic principles of this exam. Tell me, what’s stopping students from working together to have a specific group come out on top?”

“That would be due to class points and the overarching threat of expulsion, of course.”

At that, I motioned for Nanase to zoom in closer and look at the students that had gathered together around Nagumo.

“They… they’re all from groups down at the bottom of the rankings…”

“And there aren’t any Class A students mixed in with them. Not a single one.”

“The gap in class points between Class 3-A and the other third-year classes must be so hopelessly large that there’s no way for them to catch up…”

“Or, to put that another way, the third-year is in such a state that it doesn’t really matter to them who loses.”

Both first and second-year students still hadn’t gotten to the point where they’d consider giving up on the class competition, and it was precisely because they had their sights set on reaching Class A by any means possible that sinking down to the bottom rankings felt so utterly unacceptable.

However, the same didn't apply to the third-year students. In their case, the four classes were more than capable of looking past that and working together with one another.

"The strength of this strategy is that the groups down at the bottom of the rankings are free to do anything they want during the exam. When you're in last place, there's no difference between having one point and having fifty. At the end of the day, you'll still lose class points and get expelled all the same."

"If you're really doing everything you can to support a specific group, you most likely wouldn't have any points of your own, right? So while it's true that these third-year groups are down at the bottom, don't you think it's weird that they each have 20 to 30 points?"

If they truly forewent all designated areas and Tasks, they naturally wouldn't have earned any points as a result.

Therefore, Nanase was saying that it would make more sense for them to be hovering at or around zero points instead, due to the ramping penalty that came with missing designated areas.

I chose not to say anything in response to this, subtly prompting her to think about it for herself. And after a little bit, it seemed the answer slowly began to dawn on her.

Ultimately, I decided to add in a couple of words to help accelerate the process.

"A strategy becomes less effective once people catch onto it. So, what should be done in order to prevent that from happening?"

"If you have two or three groups with zero points, then the other school years will obviously realize that something weird is happening. Therefore, as long as they have at least some points on hand, it'll make it harder for others to notice what's going on…"

She peered over at me as she spoke, having arrived at an answer all her own.

And, she was probably right. That was exactly why Nagumo's strategy was so brilliant. If multiple groups all had zero points, it would be far too conspicuous. It would be like they were going around and declaring to the public that they were up to something sinister.

"In fact, while there are several groups that seem to be providing support for Nagumo, there's always at least one member from each who's dedicated to reaching designated areas."

“So they’re trying to prevent the ramping penalty from getting out of hand.”

And in the process, they’d gradually accumulate points, however few in number they might be.

“In a sense, we should also assume that the groups supporting him are competing with each other. Sure they’re conceding first place to Nagumo, but second and third are up for grabs by whoever’s adept enough to grab hold of it. That’s why, even among the bottom groups, the rankings will change around from time to time or the point disparity between them will start growing larger. It also helps make it seem as if they’re taking the special exam seriously.”

If you didn’t run ten GPS Searches, you’d never be able to see through this strategy.

Even if you suspected that something was going on, it wouldn’t end up as anything more than suspicion.

“Would they really want to let Nagumo win, even at the cost of their own expulsion? Even if they can’t rise up to Class A, I can’t imagine that they’d want to leave the school, right?”

“There might be some eccentric exceptions among them, but for the most part, I agree. Behind the scenes, Nagumo has probably prepared some relief measures of his own.”

“Relief measures of his own…?”

“It’s impossible for the other third-year classes to graduate as Class A by coming out on top through special exams. That being said, what if it’s possible to get into Class A by agreeing to work together with Nagumo instead?”

“If that’s really the only option they have, then… I guess I can see why they’d cooperate.”

If faced with the choice between graduating as a member of one of the lower classes and putting everything on the line to try and graduate as a member of Class A, it wouldn’t be strange for there to be those who volunteered themselves for the latter.

“In a way, I can’t even tell who’s running this exam anymore: the school or the student council president.”

“Honestly, you’re probably onto something there as well. Nagumo has the entire third-year in the palm of his hand after all. He’s not here to follow the rules; He’s here to make and dictate them to the rest of us.”

The mere fact that he orchestrated this situation in the first place was highly impressive. It probably wouldn't be an exaggeration to say that, throughout the entire history of the Advanced Nurturing High School, Nagumo was and will be the first and last of his kind.

Of course, we second-year students weren't just going to sit back and watch as he did whatever he wanted either.

On the fifth day of the exam, I approached both Ryūen and Sakayanagi with a certain proposal of sorts: to clear specific Tasks together with the help of a 'select portion' of the second-year student body. Or, put more simply, a strategy similar in nature to the one that Nagumo had adopted. However, it differed from his in that the points wouldn't all be concentrated in a specific leading group.

Since the flames of competition between the second-years were still burning strong, the proposal wouldn't have gotten anywhere the moment points got involved. Therefore, I made it a condition to cooperate with respect to something else. Both Ryūen and Sakayanagi were worried about the success of some of the groups that their classmates had formed, so they agreed to negotiate on equal footing with more of a 'you scratch my back, I scratch yours' kind of approach.

As an example, certain Class 2-A groups would help Class 2-D with increasing the maximum group size of Sudō's group, and in exchange we would help them increase the maximum size of one of their own that needed it. That was the general idea behind it.

Despite our being mutual enemies, as long as our interests were aligned, we could join hands without so much as a second thought.

I guess you could say that was one of the strengths of those leading the second-year.

Naturally, I don't think the proposal would've worked nearly as well if this had taken place a year ago.

Rather, it was all thanks to the past year and a half of experience we've had together that we could put this plan into motion.

"I think I understand now. You're saying that, for you, it wasn't a very big risk to spend ten points in exchange for this information, right Senpai?"

"Somewhat. I haven't exactly done away with my goal of reaching the top or anything. Fortunately, Kōenji has been putting in a lot of work of his own, so instead, I've been focused on gathering the resources necessary to support my peers who need help."

“Kōenji-senpai sure is amazing, isn’t he? Giving President Nagumo a run for his money all by himself.”

Kōenji was indeed amazing, but the truth behind what was going on here was probably a little bit different. Every time someone went to check the top rankings, they’d see Kōenji and Nagumo’s group locked in a close back-and-forth struggle and think that Kōenji was squaring off against an entire group all on his own. In reality, however, Nagumo’s group was most likely just putting on an act as they slowed down to match pace with Kōenji.

The rankings would be available for public view until the end of the twelfth day, so Nagumo was probably going to keep up the ruse until then.

And then, once the rankings were hidden again, he and his group would pick up the pace for the final two days of the exam.

By doing so, it would paint the picture that Nagumo had emerged victorious over Kōenji, who had run out of steam during the exam’s endgame. The fact that he’s used such a large number of allied groups to rack up a ton of points from Tasks wouldn’t be exposed either.

Though, given that he was slowing himself down to match his pace with Kōenji’s, that also gave the rest of us a chance to snatch up the win for ourselves.

“Anyways, for now, let’s use this info to take a look at the movements Amasawa was making on the sixth day.”

With these words, Nanase clearly made the connection that there was all sort of value hidden in the screenshots that even I hadn’t uncovered yet.

“It doesn’t look like Amasawa was in the designated area that morning.”

Given that she had the same Table as us, it wouldn’t be strange for her to pitch camp in the same designated area as us as well.

However, her GPS signal showed her to be two areas to the south instead.

Furthermore, there were no other signals overlapping with hers, indicating that she had spent the night alone.

“Here’s the screenshot from 8:00 AM, one hour after the first designated area was announced.”

“The area we were headed to at the time was B6, right Senpai?”

“Yeah. It seems like she took a different route to B6 than we did.”

She was also moving quite fast, given the distance she managed to travel from the previous screenshot.

Was it that she had just traveled faster than expected, or had she just taken the most optimal path?

Either way, it didn’t seem like the movement of a lone girl walking through the forest.

We then checked the next map at 9:00 AM, and she was in area C6, one area to the right of the designated area.

It was likely that she had stepped foot within the designated area at some point earlier and was now heading off toward a nearby Task.

“This really is amazing. Every movement that someone did throughout the day is right at your fingertips, clearly displayed on a map.”

At least during the morning hours of the sixth day, she seemed to be diligently taking the exam just like any other student.

We soon began to analyze the next seven screenshots, focusing our attention solely on Amasawa’s signal.

But in the end, she didn’t do anything that stood out. She just participated in three or so Tasks as she diligently made her way to the designated areas. We could probably find out whether or not she placed high in said Tasks by cross-referencing with the logs on Nanase’s tablet, but her performance didn’t really matter here.

“At the very least, there’s nothing to indicate that Amasawa was following us, or up to anything suspicious in general as of 5:00 PM yesterday.”

“…So in the end, we haven’t learned anything?”

“No, we’ve learned plenty. This makes it clear that Amasawa’s taking the special exam at least somewhat seriously. Plus, this means that she isn’t leaving any openings that we might catch wind of through GPS Searches.”

It was safe to assume that she was up to something once the scheduled exam hours were done for the day, that is, from dusk till dawn. But while it was possible to run a GPS Search during that time period, that'd just end up being nothing more than a waste of points.

At this point, we received a notification from the school about the compensation we'd get because of the exam's suspension for the day.

『Due to ongoing complications with the weather, only one-fourth of the day's quota of Tasks and area movements were able to be completed. To compensate for the lost opportunity, the school has passed the decision to double all points earned through Arrival Bonuses, Early Bird Bonuses, and Tasks on the final day of the exam. According to the forecast, the weather is expected to improve sometime before tomorrow morning.』

The final day of the exam was similar to the first day, with only three-fourths of the day dedicated to the special exam.

So in that sense, you could say that the compensation they had chosen to go with was just what the doctor ordered.

"Senpai, this looks like it could end up changing everything."

The final day was when the majority of conflicts would be settled, so with double the points on the line, the chances of successfully making a comeback were very real.

"The school was right to tell us about this so far ahead of time. It'll give groups the chance to reassess their plans for the second half of the exam."

With today having turned into a full day to rest, there would surely be groups out there that think to pace themselves from tomorrow onward, conserving their stamina in anticipation for the finale. On the other hand, it also wouldn't be all that surprising if there were groups that chose to take advantage of that and go all-out as soon as tomorrow. In any case, this outcome was hardly a welcome turn of events as far I was concerned.

After staring at my tablet for a while, I realized that Nanase had stopped talking as much and watched as she began nodding off beside me. It was as if she was gradually slipping into the unconsciousness of sleep, her eyes at times wide open or slowly falling shut.

"I know it's still daytime, but maybe you should go and get some rest?"

She had forced herself to climb a mountain earlier this morning, only to use up the rest of her stamina fighting me immediately afterward. She'd no doubt gone two or three times over her limit today, so she was probably wrought with fatigue by now.

"Eh? Ah…! Sorry!"

She tried to straighten herself in a fluster, but a strong spell of drowsiness wasn't something you could snap out of so easily.

And this was even more true for someone with a tattered body like her.

"…I'll head back to my own tent then."

She was the one who knew what was best for herself.

If she were to continue to stay here while dozing off like this, she'd just end up being a hindrance.

"That sounds like a good idea."

Judging from the way the rain was still coming down, it didn't seem like we'd be able to get any productive traveling done today anyway.

With that being the case, we should take every second possible to give our bodies as much of a break as possible.

Though, it's not like resting inside a tent was exactly comfortable or anything, but that's just the way the cookie crumbles sometimes.

Just as Nanase was about to unzip the entrance, she turned and looked back at me from over her shoulder.

"As soon as the rain stops, I think I'm going to try to chase after Amasawa-san. It's clear enough that she's from the White Room, and I'm concerned with what she's planning to do after this."

Indeed, if she just continued to stick together with me like this, we wouldn't find out nearly as much about what Amasawa was up to.

And, as they were fellow members of the same group, I didn't think that Amasawa would do anything cruel to Nanase either.

“The fact that Amasawa managed to make it until now as a student of the White Room means that she’s a threat. It’s vitally important that you don’t underestimate her due to gender or age.”

“I’m not clear on all the details, but from what you’re saying she must be an extremely dangerous opponent.”

In terms of pure combat power, you could say that Amasawa was even a step above the likes of Sudō and Ryūen. While they may have her beat in terms of raw physical strength, she’d definitely be far, far ahead of them when it comes to technique and experience. No matter how hard she tried, Nanase herself probably wouldn’t stand a ghost of a chance against her.

“You have your other group member, Hōsen, to watch out for as well.”

“Yes. Given his sheer strength, he’s not an opponent I can handle either.”

Nanase nodded along, clearly believing herself to have understood, but Hōsen’s overwhelming physical strength wasn’t the only thing that made him dangerous.

You’d be better off thinking of Hōsen as the type of person who has more than just raw physical power going for him.

“I think it’s extremely unlikely that Hōsen is a White Room student, but after what happened with Amasawa, I’m not so sure about that anymore. In any case, put my matters on the back burner for the time being and just focus on protecting yourself.”

That is, of course, assuming that her primary goal doesn’t turn out to be getting me kicked out of school.

“I’m not afraid of getting expelled, Ayanokōji-senpai. I’ll do anything if it means protecting you, no matter the cost.”

Rather than offering advice, my words had been meant as more of a warning, but based on her response it didn’t seem like the message had gotten through.

“Let me put it slightly differently for you then, Nanase. It’s possible that your careless actions may cause me unintended problems. I want you to avoid doing anything that may put me at risk.”

I conveyed to her that this wasn’t me being apprehensive or worried about what would become of her, but what would, by extension, become of me.

Upon doing so, Nanase's valiant, loyal demeanor changed into that of a meek, frail puppy.

"That… That would be unacceptable of me. I can't be causing you any more trouble than I already have…"

"If that's really true, then in any case, I just ask that you be careful. Got it?"

"I understand, I promise."

Having told her all of this, I felt fairly confident that she wouldn't do anything reckless.

After all, I really didn't think she wanted to do anything that would bring more shame onto herself than she already had.

Once Nanase had returned to her own tent, my gaze dropped down to my tablet once again.

I wanted to quickly comb over the scores of the top ten and bottom ten groups and then iron out the exam's current state of affairs with my own score in mind.

『Top Ten Rankings』

1st Place: Second-Year Group Kōenji – 168 Points

2nd Place: Third-Year Group Nagumo – 166 Points

3rd Place: Third-Year Group Kiriyama – 150 Points

4th Place: Third-Year Group Mizoe – 133 Points

4th Place: Third-Year Group Ochiai – 133 Points

6th Place: Second-Year Group Ryūen – 128 Points

7th Place: Second-Year Group Sakayanagi – 127 Points

8th Place: First-Year Group Takahashi – 115 Points

9th Place: Second-Year Group Kanzaki – 104 Points

10th Place: Third-Year Group Kuronaga – 101 Points

I was currently ranked 49th overall with 78 points. There was a full, 90 point difference between myself and Kōenji, who was all the way up in first place.

Though it may seem impossible for me to recover from the gap in our scores, I'd still get 11 points for getting a first-place Early Bird Bonus. And with four chances per day, I'd catch up just by placing first nine times in a row. Of course, this was also provided that Kōenji wouldn't earn any points of his own in the meantime.

If Kōenji were to maintain his current pace and keep diligently racking up points, he'd end up with a final score of around 350, so if I wanted to bridge the gap, I'd have to earn close to 40 points per day for the rest of the exam. If you were to ask that of another group, they'd pass it off as impossible and probably give up on the spot. However, even an outlier like Kōenji would surely slow down during the second half of the exam.

"But tenth place has 101 points, huh?"

Back when the rules of this uninhabited island exam were first explained to us, I thought that groups would've had slightly higher scores by this point. However, from the current status of the top ten and the fact that I was currently ranked 49th overall, it felt like overall progress had stagnated somewhat since the exam entered the midgame. After overall efficiency hit its peak on the second or third day, a lingering sense of fatigue began to set in, and there had been a noteworthy increase in the number of missed designated areas, penalties, and Task abstentions.

At the same time, since small groups were also steadily beginning to merge with each other, the total number of groups was going down little by little. This was definitely something I ought to keep in mind as well.

In order for me to successfully break into the upper ranks, I'd need to show significant growth during the second half of the exam.

And the key to that was the tenth place score, which acted as the barrier between public knowledge and anonymity.

To that end, I previously strove to silently, patiently rise through the lower ranks during this first half without pushing myself too hard.

My efforts would've borne fruit starting tomorrow too, the eighth day, but with the exam having been put on hold today due to the heavy rain, I should expect another large spike of activity from all groups for the next two days or so. Furthermore, there would definitely be groups looking to conserve their stamina for the double points being offered on the final day as well.

This special exam seemed as if it was completely unwinnable for a one-man group. However, there was actually something contradictory residing within the relationship between the rules of the exam, basic movement, and Tasks.

If you tried to make it to your designated areas the fastest, you'd run the risk of missing out on Tasks; conversely, if you focused your energy on getting to Tasks, you'd most likely end up missing out on Early Bird Bonuses. This was a universal truth regardless of whether you were part of a large group or all on your own.

As a whole, the exam had been very cleverly constructed and balanced like this, from the fact that eligibility for Early Bird Bonuses was based on when the last person of a group stepped foot in the designated area, to the system put in place that required groups to venture out to Task sites without even knowing if they'd be able to participate.

It was unclear exactly when the rain would stop, and I was still worried about Nanase among a few other things, but starting tomorrow, the second half of the exam would begin, and I was going to fight with an all-new strategy in hand.

Chapter 2: Silently with All One's Heart

Intro

The heavy rain lasted until just about the break of dawn, casting a large shadow of anxiety over the students.

However, by 6:00 AM, the rainclouds had vanished as if they'd never existed in the first place, painting the sky with the same clear blue as the days before. That being said, the forest's canopy was so thick that it completely blocked out the sunlight in certain places, leaving behind a muddy forest floor that would take a while to dry up.

"I'll have to address the food shortage sooner rather than later…"

I was gradually starting to run out of energy, unable to maintain the daily caloric intake necessary for a high school student. As I had never undergone intentional starvation training before, this was my first time experiencing what it was like to have an empty stomach for such an extended period of time.

While it'd be possible to stay active as long as I kept myself hydrated, that wouldn't exactly be the best routine to fall into. My immune system would take a hit and leave me susceptible to illness and disease. I guess it wouldn't be impossible to hunt for wild animals or insects, but it shouldn't have to come to that unless I had no other option.

You could buy food back at the starting area if you still had provision points left over, but that wasn't an effective long-term solution, nor was it available to me.

In other words, my only real option to get more food was to get it from Tasks, either by placing high in the ones that awarded it, or by getting it for free from the ones that had it as a participation prize.

However, the Tasks that provided food would only continue to get more and more competitive from now on.

"I'm all packed and ready to go."

Having finished tidying up the makeshift campsite, Nanase approached me with her backpack strapped to her back.

“Amasawa’s most likely just going to head to the next designated area, right?”

“Based on the number of points we’ve earned, I’d say that’s a safe bet. So if it’s all the same to you, may I continue to accompany you until we reach this first designated area?”

I silently nodded in response. Since we were both going to the same place, there was no reason for us to separate from each other just yet.

Shortly after we began walking, Nanase spoke up.

“Amasawa-san was following us as of the evening of the sixth day or the morning of the seventh, right?”

“Without putting too much thought into it, it’s probably safe to assume that she approached us using a GPS Search on the morning of the seventh.”

Since there was no way for us to see the search history, there was no concrete proof that Amasawa had used the GPS Search at all. However, if it was clear that the group’s score had decreased at some point over the course of the seventh day, then we could at least be sure that *someone* from the group had used it.
Amasawa’s group wasn’t a part of the top nor bottom ten at the time though, so as a member of the group, only Nanase would’ve been privy to that information.

“Naturally, I’ve referenced this with the data on my tablet already, but… as far as I recall, our score didn’t go down whatsoever yesterday.”

In short, if Nanase’s memory was to be trusted, then Amasawa hadn’t used the GPS Search.

“Although it’s unknown where on the island Amasawa-san was that morning, you and I were traveling quite fast at the time. It wouldn’t have been very easy for her to catch up to us unless she was already somewhere nearby, right?”

“That’s probably why she came up with a clever plan to help close the distance.”

Unlike the two of us, who were carrying around heavy backpacks and gear, Amasawa had been traveling light.

As a result, even if she had started out a fair distance away, she was more than capable of closing the gap between us.

“I’m guessing she used a trick of some sort to find out my exact location.”

“Are you saying that Amasawa-san had somebody else disclose where you were, Ayanokōji-senpai?”

“Possibly.”

As it stood now, it was hard to be absolutely certain as to what method she had used.

Part 1

“It looks like this is where we part ways, Senpai. At least for now.”

Once we had both earned a one-point Arrival Bonus for crossing the boundary into area E3, Nanase finally broke the ice.

“How do you plan on joining up with Amasawa and Hōsen?”

The GPS Search was an excellent tool for finding out where other people were located, but it was hardly cut out for facilitating a get-together.

That was a job far more suited to a tool capable of direct interpersonal communication, such as a walkie-talkie.

“I can’t imagine that I’d cross paths with them by aimlessly wandering around the island, but it’s not like I can waste a bunch of points searching for them either. With that being the case, I’ll start out by using the point I just got and try my best to chase after their GPS signals. If I can’t find them after that, I guess I’ll just travel to the next designated area.”

This meant that she was probably going with a minimalist approach, searching for Amasawa and Hōsen during whatever downtime she had between areas.

I thought about asking her to share Amasawa’s location with me before she left, but since she hadn’t even started with the search yet, I decided to simply let it slide.

“I think it’ll take a first-year student like me to poke around and find out what other first-years are up to. If I catch wind that something bad is going down, I’ll come running and let you know, Ayanokōji-senpai.”

While Nanase was brimming with enthusiasm, I was afraid that she’d end up lost, aimlessly going around in circles.

“Just don’t overdo it.”

With a respectful nod of the head and her tablet in hand, Nanase set off.

It’d be nice if she could meet up with them soon, but that would all depend on how the other two behaved moving forward.

If they were consistently touring the designated areas, it’d be over and done with fairly quickly, but knowing those two, it wouldn’t be surprising if the both of them ended up moving erratically instead.

After watching Nanase’s figure disappear into the depths of the forest, I took out my tablet.

I was finally back on my own again, and with it, I could officially get started with the second half of the exam.

“No Tasks nearby, huh?”

There was one about 400 meters away from here, but it had already opened up registration more than twenty minutes ago, which would turn into thirty-five minutes given that it would take me fifteen or so just to get there. Furthermore, only five groups would be able to participate.

Ultimately, I decided that going after this Task wouldn’t be very practical, so I opted to take a break instead. I’d sit back and wait for the next designated area to be announced so that, by the time my strength was fully recovered, I’d be ready to get up and take action.

When the clock struck 9:00 AM, I picked up my tablet and readied myself for what was to come.

Whether I’d make a beeline for the designated area or head for a Task instead, it all depended on where the next area unveiled itself.

I quickly checked my tablet, only to find out that it was the random designation for the day.

The area in question was area E6, three areas to the south of here, which wasn't actually all that far away, considering the fact that it had been randomly designated.

I started walking immediately but kept my eyes glued to my tablet as I did.

After inspecting each of the Tasks that had also appeared at the turn of the hour, I decided on my course of action.

In order to earn as many points as possible in the time I had left today, I needed to be *efficient*.
To that end, it was crucial that I did everything in my power to discount the influence of *luck*.

Part 2

Shortly before 4:00 PM. I had just finished up with a Task I was participating in and was about to take my leave from the site.

"Ayanokōji-kun?"

Thereupon, I crossed paths with Horikita for the first time since we parted ways at the start of the exam.

Although she looked a little surprised to see me, she didn't seem particularly tired.

"It's been eight days, huh?"

"That it has."

We were currently in area F7, reunited once again since our last conversation back on the first day of the exam.

"Did you come for the Task, or are you simply passing through? Where are you headed after this, Horikita?"

“I’m heading to G8. I ended up passing through here on the way. What about yourself?”

Apparently, the area she was headed toward was right next to mine.

“F8. It looks like we’ll be going in the same general direction.”

Since it’d be a waste of time to stand here and talk, the two of us immediately set out together without so much as another word.

Traveling together seemed like the best way to go about this, given that we’d be taking the same route for the most part.

“You’re in better shape than I expected. And from the look of it… I assume you’re still on your own?”

“Yes, I am. It’s troublesome in many ways, but being alone tends to make many things easier as well.”

It was true that, by being alone, you didn’t need to worry about taking care of others or matching their pace.

However, throughout the entire exam so far, Horikita’s name had never shown up in the bottom ten. While that was decent proof that she was doing well for herself in terms of points, it was strange that she didn’t seem tired at all.

“Is it really so hard for you to believe that I’m still in such good shape?”

“Most of the students I’ve come across have looked awfully tired.”

“Hmm. Did something unusual happen?”

“Unusual? Ah… now that you mention it, have you heard about what happened with Shinohara?”

“Yes. To be exact, I heard about it today. In light of that, I’m glad that I ran into you.”

Apparently it had gone something like this: somebody from Class 2-A had reached out to Horikita while she was near the starting area earlier today, and they had urged her to meet with Sakayanagi, whereupon she was informed of Komiya and Kinoshita’s retirement.

Afterward, Sakayanagi told her about the strategy that I had proposed back on the fifth day and the two began to negotiate.

“You didn’t refuse to cooperate, right?”

“I had no reason to do that; I had to prevent Shinohara-san from getting kicked out of school. I heard that you were one of the first on the scene at the time, do you know the details of what happened?”

“No, not really. I think it could’ve been both an incident or an accident.”

I explained what I knew as someone who had seen the aforementioned crime scene from up close.

Of course, I kept certain things to myself, such as the fact that Amasawa had been watching from the shadows.

“Shinohara-san’s group ranking has been dropping lower and lower every day. Currently, she’s placed seventh from the bottom. At this rate, it seems she’ll fall far enough to qualify for expulsion by the end of the day today, so we have to hurry. If worse comes to worst and we can’t find another group for her to join, I’ll take matters into my own hands. Before I ran into you, I was lucky enough to secure first place in a Task that rewarded me with three additional spaces in my group.”

This was good news. The Tasks that increased maximum group size were fairly uncommon, and they were highly sought after as well.

Taking first place in such a contested Task couldn’t have been easy.

“But if that’s how things play out, then it’ll be just you and Shinohara scoring all the points. If possible, I hope our collaboration with Sakayanagi goes smoothly so you can merge with a group that’s doing better for themselves.”

Horikita nodded in agreement.

“At any rate, over these past eight days that I’ve been walking around the island, I’ve really come to realize that a lot more groups have walkie-talkies than I anticipated. I’ve seen students making use of them all over the place, Sakayanagi-san telling her fellow classmates about what happened to Shinohara-san is only one such example.”

“It seems like a particularly strong trend among the upper classes, who are capable of taking charge and have the points to spare. Walkie-talkies let you exchange information

over long distances, so depending on how well you make use of it, it could be worth spending such a large number of points."

"If we trusted one another a little more, I wonder… if we could've done that as well…?"

Horikita pursed her lips ever so slightly, perhaps having found the notion fairly difficult to imagine, despite having mentioned it.

"While walkie-talkies are certainly useful, that doesn't necessarily mean that they'd do all that much for us. It'd just be a waste if we didn't end up doing anything with them."

"That's true enough."

I took out my tablet to see if any new Tasks had appeared, only to find that a risk-free, hassle-free Task that gave out food as a participation prize had shown up not too far from our current location.

Furthermore, there was room for as many as fifteen groups to register for it.

However, it only gave out a single point that all groups would get for participating, so it wasn't all that appealing on the points side of things.

"I'm running low on food, so I think I'd like to drop by this Task. How about you Horikita?"

If she had her sights set on her designated area's Early Bird Bonus, then she'd be better off pushing forward without batting an eye.

"I don't have that much food remaining either, so I'll drop by the Task as well."

Since our priorities were identical, we decided to change course and proceeded on our way to the Task.

Although the Task itself was a blessing, participating in it would be highly competitive.

Horikita and I began to pick up the pace as we hurried to the Task site. On the way, we gradually began to catch sight of other groups. From first-years, third-years, and even second-years, all of them seemed to have their sights set on the same destination, given how they were all moving in the same direction as us. In fact, the majority broke into a run as soon as they realized that they were surrounded by direct competition.

“Horikita, you don’t need to worry about me. Go ahead and hurry to the Task site.”

“Look who’s talking. If you’ve really run low on food, then you ought to be a bit more pressed yourself.”

“I just don’t have the energy to run anymore.”

“And I’m in the same boat.”

Despite the rush, it seemed her stance regarding the wasteful expenditure of stamina was the same as mine.

She was all on her own, and yet it was clear that she was acting with a certain degree of flexibility, methodically pacing herself as she tackled the uninhabited island exam.

Not long thereafter, we arrived at the Task site just in time to participate, whereupon we both decided to take some time to mingle with some of our classmates that we hadn’t seen in a while. After all, even if we rushed to our designated areas from here, we’d probably be too late to qualify for any Early Bird Bonuses. With that being the case, we’d be better off looking to exchange information until the last minute so that we could make the most of the rest of the exam.

Moreover, many of our classmates still didn’t know about what kind of situation Shinohara had been put in.

Later on, once the exam was done for the day, I tallied up my score. I had earned 4 points from Arrival Bonuses and 14 points from participating in four different Tasks, for a total of 18. This brought my overall score up to 96, 23rd place on the leaderboards.

On the whole, I got the impression that groups had been more active today than on the fifth or sixth. However, since there were also groups that, for the most part, hadn’t been active at all, a distinct line had been drawn between those who were looking to conserve their stamina and those who weren’t.

The eighth day, which I had otherwise expected to devolve into a fierce battle, hadn’t actually been that bad in the end. There hadn’t been any significant changes in the scores of the top ten either, as the Kuronaga group was still in tenth place with a total of 111 points.

Tomorrow, my goal was to maintain an ideal rank and, if possible, meet up with Sakayanagi once again.I fell asleep that night hoping that the upcoming designated areas would lead me toward the starting area.

Chapter 3: A Battle Against Solitude

Intro

After brushing away the cobwebs that had tangled around my clothes, I slowly took off my backpack and set it down on the ground.

The Uninhabited Island Exam had entered into its ninth day, and it was as hot and humid out as ever.

By the time I had safely arrived at the fourth designated area, I was already breathing heavily.

One way or another, I had managed to reach my intended destination, just as scheduled.

The sweat on my brow slowly began to trickle down the bridge of my nose, so I wiped it away with the sleeve of my jersey.

Area D5, the designated area revealed at 3:00 PM, had been a considerable distance away from the previous area H9. It had taken quite a lot of effort to make it within the allotted time period.

In fact, I had even run into a decent Task along the way, but chose to give up on it so as to minimize the risk of accruing a penalty.

Although the journey had taken me almost two full hours, it didn't seem that very many other groups had arrived yet, as I had successfully earned the third-place Early Bird Bonus.

I wasn't dissatisfied with my progress for the most part, but I still hadn't been able to make it back to the starting area and meet up with Sakayanagi.

It'd just be a waste of stamina if I forced myself to go there now, and I didn't want to overwork myself. I had crossed paths with several Class 2-A students throughout the day today, but unfortunately, none of them had walkie-talkies. I thought about whether or not I should just bite the bullet and go there tomorrow morning, but… well, that would make things fairly complicated.

After deciding to put aside the whole situation with Sakayanagi for the time being, I went ahead and took a look at everything that had happened today.

“So with all the points I earned today, I’ve upped my total score to 112, huh?”

The Kuronaga group, who had maintained their 10th place spot, had a comprehensive score of 123 points, a mere 11 points ahead of me, who had risen up to 13th. Given that it would soon be 5:00 PM, this 11 point gap was most likely where things would end for the day.

My goal was actually to reach 11th place, but an 11 point difference seemed well within my tolerance range. Although it happened slightly behind schedule due to what happened with Nanase and the rough patch of weather, I had finally secured the strategic position that I’d been aiming for since the very beginning.

That’s right, I had been aiming for 11th place since before the uninhabited island special exam even started. I was currently in 13th place, which was a bit lower, but that wasn’t the important thing here. Rather, I just needed to make certain of one thing: that I didn’t rise up to tenth.

In order to stand on the winner’s podium, you’d have to put in the work to pile up points. However, regardless of whether you were all on your own or in a seven-man group through the use of the ‘More People’ card, by being part of the publicly-visible top ten, you’d inevitably end up garnering attention, even if you didn’t want to.

And by garnering attention, your rivals would become wary of you, and you’d have to face the risk of being sabotaged before the end of the exam.

In order to avoid that and yet still have your sights set on a top spot, 11th place was the most ideal position to be in. That being said, there were still a few drawbacks to this strategy. Given the exam’s nature, staying in control of your score can be fairly difficult. Therefore, if you didn’t keep a close eye on your score, it’s possible that you might find your group’s name inadvertently showing up on the leaderboards, even if only for a moment. And if that were to happen, the entire strategy would be for naught.

Furthermore, an even greater drawback was the fact that it was heavily dependent on the score of the 10th place group. The smaller the gap between 10th place and 1st place, the easier it’d be to mount a comeback. However, if the gap was on the larger side, it’d be increasingly difficult to turn things around since you’d need to earn a larger number of points to catch up.

For that exact reason, it was important that the top groups strove to actively impede each other’s progress.

But… that had been happening less than anticipated. So much so, in fact, that certain groups had been allowed to run away with the lead.

Fortunately, the absence of pressure from the first and third-years meant that the second-years were at a relative advantage, although that didn't exactly mean very much given all the other drawbacks. In order for groups to interfere with each other, they'd need to sacrifice their own ability to earn points, so it'd be difficult to put anything into motion unless you already had a substantial number of points on hand.

I was curious about what Nagumo was going to do moving forward. It seemed like it'd be a good idea for him to take on countermeasures of some sort to deal with Kōenji, his foremost competitor for the top spot. However, from what I saw during my previous GPS Searches, there was no indication that he had any plan to run interference at the moment. It was conceivable that he was simply pouring his energy into scoring points right now instead, but…

"With the way things are going, even if I don't win, I won't have any complaints as long as Kōenji takes first or second."

By staying at or around 11th place, I wouldn't attract very much attention. And even if I were to have my progress stunted via sabotage by Amasawa or one of the other first-years, I wouldn't have to worry about dropping all the way down to the bottom of the leaderboards.

All I needed to do at this point was maintain a high rank until the end of the twelfth day of the exam.

I took a well-earned rest in the shade of a nearby tree, and once the sweat had faded from my brow, I put my backpack back on and set off, headed toward the neighboring area.

Rather than set up camp right on the border, I wanted to find a nice, open spot located a bit further out.

Just around the time when the sun began to set and I needed to make a decision as to where I'd be camping for the night, I caught sight of an isolated, one-man tent pitched in a clearing not too far ahead of me. The entrance was zipped shut despite the sweltering heat, so it didn't seem like its owner was resting inside. Perhaps they were out scouting the surrounding area, or possibly even going to the restroom.

"What a nice spot."

It was hard to find such a flat, open spot in this neck of the woods.

It'd make things a lot easier for me personally if I could just set up my tent somewhere around here.

However, compared to when I had Nanase accompanying me, I was currently a boy traveling on his own.

As such, if this tent's owner was a girl, my presence could lead to inadvertent trouble if they didn't trust me to be here.

What's more, whoever it was, I wasn't sure what to make of the fact that it was a one-man tent.

Were they acting separately from the rest of their group, or had they been on their own since the beginning?

If it were the latter, then it was almost certainly someone I was acquainted with.

At this point, I at least wanted to find out their identity, regardless of whether I ended up pitching my own tent here or not.

I decided to stick around for a little while to see if the owner would turn up.

If they were out for a walk, then they should be back before sundown. And, if there were noises coming from inside the tent, then I could just call out to them.

I was fully aware that it'd be more efficient to try calling out to them now, but… well… you get the idea.

I waited for about ten minutes after that, but there was no sign nor sound of anyone.

The longer I waited, the more possible it began to seem that they had simply gone to bed early.

And since I had no reason to believe that anyone else would show up looking to use the campsite, I finally made up my mind and called out from beside the tent.

"Is anyone there?"

I held my breath for a few seconds and listened carefully for a reaction of some sort, but it was perfectly silent.

“Sorry, but I’d like to set up my tent nearby. Please let me know if you have a problem with that.”

I went through the formality of asking for permission, and, having reached the conclusion that there was truly nobody inside, lowered my backpack down to the ground.

That is, after having appropriately distanced myself from their tent, of course.

Although I was still somewhat curious about who it was I was sharing a campsite with, I quickly finished pitching my own tent.

Time and time again, I’d been thoroughly impressed with how much easier this tent was to set up than the one used during last year’s uninhabited island exam.

And that wasn’t the only thing. It was also nice to have a tent all to myself without having to fuss over sharing the space with somebody else.

Though, this introverted way of thinking may just be the reason why my friends were so few and far between.

A sunny, cheerful person would probably say that sleeping in a tent without other people would be boring.

I couldn’t help but wonder if there would ever come a day where I’d think so as well.

“…I really can’t imagine it.”

It was a future that would probably never come.

“I thought I heard some weirdo show up, but to think it was you of all people.”

Just as I was sorting out my change of clothes for tomorrow, a voice called out to me from behind.

Apparently, the owner of the lone tent just across the way was none other than Ibuki.

“Did I make too much noise?”

“Not really.”

Her response was brief, and she immediately followed it up with a piercing glare.

I thought that she'd say something else, but she instantly went back inside her tent instead.

Feeling like something was out of sorts, I decided to go and see what she was up to.

"You got a minute?"

I called out to her from outside her tent, but she ignored me. The only thing I could hear was a faint, indistinct noise coming from inside.

"I'd like to ask you something."

I tried calling out to her again, but she still refused to respond.

At first I thought that she was merely ignoring me, but upon further inspection, it seemed like she was actually up to something in there.

"I'm gonna unzip the flap, okay?"

Just to be safe, I waited for thirty seconds or so before unzipping the entrance to her tent.

"…What do you want?"

Upon looking inside, I was met with the sight of a seated Ibuki who seemed to be chewing on something.



“You’re really— Wait, no, what are you eating?”

“Jerky.”

“Jerky…? That wasn’t included in the Uninhabited Island Manuel they handed out to us before the exam, though?”

In other words, she had secured fresh meat somehow, perhaps by purchasing it, and dried it into jerky all by herself.

However, it’d take quite a lot of time and effort for her to go through the jerky-making process on her own.

Back when the exam first began, she had started out by provoking Horikita before immediately setting off for the first designated area. If she had been carrying raw meat back then, it went without saying that it would’ve spoiled within a few hours of this scorching heat.

With that in mind, it made more sense to think that this was a part of a strategy that the entirety of Class 2-B was in on.

I could imagine that some Class 2-B group out there had taken on the job of making a large quantity of jerky for the rest of the class.

It would only be possible because it was cost-effective and cheap on the wallet. No matter how portable it might be, straight-up buying premade food that has a long shelf-life, such as dried meats, wouldn’t be very practical from a cost-performance standpoint due to the high prices the school would charge for it. So, rather than buy the processed result, you could get more bang for your buck by going through the effort to make your own jerky out of raw beef instead.

I hadn’t seen what Ryūen’s food situation was like back when I crossed paths with him, but it was probably safe to assume that he was carrying emergency rations as well, jerky in particular. Even though it couldn’t hurt, the students of Class 2-B could look past the highly competitive Tasks that supplied participants with food.

“What’s it matter to you? It’s none of your business.”

I could stand here thinking about this all I wanted, but it didn’t sound like I’d be hearing the truth from her any time soon.

At any rate— as far as I knew, Ibuki's name hadn't shown up in the bottom ten groups so far, even though she was taking part in the exam all on her own. It seemed that she had managed to maintain a somewhat decent score.

For Ibuki, taking a top spot in a Task centered around academic ability would be a lost cause.

With that being the case, her main source of income had to be the Arrival Bonuses and Early Bird Bonuses that came from traveling to designated areas, and outside of that, she'd be limited to the Tasks that tested our athletic skills.

As a result, she'd inevitably wear herself out at a faster rate than other students.

Anyone with eyes could see just how much physical and mental stress she had been put under.

In fact, it was entirely possible that she had already gone well past her limit.

"How many people have you spoken with since the exam started?"

"Wha…?"

It didn't seem like she had been sleeping very well, as I could see faint, dark circles taking shape under her eyes.

"…Just Horikita. You heard me say I wouldn't lose to her, right? You were there."

"In other words, you're saying you haven't had a proper conversation with someone since day one?"

At best, she had probably only opened her mouth to answer yes-no questions during the Task registration process.

"You should try and find someone to talk to, even if only a little bit."

"Ain't no way I'm gonna talk with my enemies."

"Then talk with a classmate. If you wander around long enough, you're sure to come across someone."

"I don't think of my classmates as 'friends'."

Her current state was the result of her closing herself off from the outside world, hiding away in her shell. And to think she had been like this for nine days now, and yet still had five more to go before the end of the exam.

If the fraying thread that was holding Ibuki together were to snap, everything would most likely come crumbling down around her.

And, as a lone student, if she were made to retire from the exam, her expulsion would be all but set in stone.

However, this special exam was such that, if at all possible, you didn't want to let groups from your own school year get expelled. To that end, it would be ideal if Ibuki could dedicate a day to rest and recovery. If she could spend a full day taking it easy, that would probably be enough for her to regain most of her energy. Given the type of person she was, it wouldn't be impossible for her to make it through the remaining four days of the exam at that point.

But, reality was not so merciful. As easy as it may seem, taking a day off from the exam would be incredibly difficult.

And, even if she were to force herself to take a break, there was no saying whether or not her mental state would improve.

While you rested, your rivals would be racking up points, placing you at risk of not only being overtaken, but possibly even causing you to sink down to the very bottom.

It'd be impossible for an ordinary person to sit back and empty their mind while the rest of the world moved on with the exam without them.

Besides, missing out on all four of a day's designated areas would lead to a penalty, of which the ramping effects would only make the following days that much more strenuous.

"Get out already."

"…Alright."

Even though it was Ibuki, she was still a girl.

With the sun sinking further and further under the horizon, it wouldn't exactly be appropriate for a boy to be looking inside a lone girl's tent like this.

Even if Ryūen was here right now, I had my doubts that even he would be able to solve her problem.

After leaving Ibuki's tent, I went back to sorting out my clothes.

It had been a fairly windy day today, so I hoped that it'd be a relatively cool night tonight.

"Hey."

Just when I had reached a decent stopping point with what I was doing, Ibuki emerged from her tent.

She staggered a bit as she got to her feet, wobbling around somewhat haphazardly, but she regained her bearings soon enough.

And then, with her hands in her pockets, she proceeded to walk straight over to me.

"How many points you got right now?"

She had finally come out of her tent, only to follow it up by asking me something surprisingly bold.

"We're mutual enemies, you do know that right?"

"So you won't tell me."

In a low voice, she mumbled something that sounded like the word 'cheapskate', but I still had no intention of divulging that information.

I could tell her that I was currently in 13th place, but there wasn't a single person on this deserted island who'd stand to benefit from it.

"That's just how it is."

"Then, at least tell me if you're higher or lower than me. I've currently got—"

Just as Ibuki was about to willingly disclose her own score, I held out my hand to stop her.

“Sorry, but I won’t be answering your question, no matter what form you put it in.”

Merely telling her if my score was higher or lower would be no different from giving her a hint, and the same thing went for lying to her about it.

It may seem risk-free for me to say that my score was lower than hers, but if people were to learn that I was struggling to secure points, then there’s a chance that someone may try to force me into a desperate situation in order to expel me. No matter what, I had to prevent any intel about me from taking on a life of its own.

Ibuki clicked her tongue, her hands still in her pockets.

“…Whatever. It was a waste of time to bother with askin’ you anyway.”

“Fair enough. Besides, your true target here is Horikita, right?”

As soon as Horikita’s name crossed my lips, Ibuki’s tired, listless demeanor changed drastically.

She pulled her hand out of her pocket and presented me with her middle finger and a scowl on her face.

“When you next see that bitch, do me a solid and tell her that I’ll absolutely never lose to her.”

“That’s fine and all, but I’m probably not the one you should be giving the middle finger to.”

“You, her, same difference. After all, you two are on real good terms with each other.”

No, we weren’t.

She was completely off the mark, but from her perspective, it probably looked like Horikita and I treated each other that way.

Apparently, she didn’t have anything else she wanted to say to me, as she began to walk back to her own tent without another word.

“Hold on a moment.”

I called out as I went after her, only for her to look back just as I was reaching out to grab hold of her arm.

She was already more than wary of me, but upon seeing what I was doing, that wariness was cranked up to the maximum as she instantly moved to avoid my hand.

“Haaa? You tryna pull somethin’?”

She clenched her fists as she spoke. It seemed she had interpreted my actions as me trying to pick a fight with her.

“That wasn’t my intention here at all, but—”

Leaving my sentence unfinished, I extended my arm for a second time and, without giving her an opportunity to escape, swiftly grabbed hold of her wrist.

“The hell are you doing!?”

She sent a kick flying at me in a panic, prompting me to block her foot with my free hand. I expected her to try it again, but she instead let out a sigh of resignation and averted her gaze.

“I’ll admit I can’t beat you, sure, but one of these days, I swear I’m gonna get the satisfaction of kickin’ your teeth in.”

Personally, I’d rather she didn’t set such an unsettling goal for herself.

“So? Did Horikita put you up to this? Tryna get in my way?”

Not only did she fail to understand my true intentions behind grabbing her wrist, but her strange suspicions had led her to an even stranger conclusion all of her own.

As one of Horikita’s classmates, it didn’t seem like there was any way my words would make it through to her.

Thinking about it logically, the odds of getting Ibuki to willingly take a break had been minuscule from the very beginning.

“Your pulse is racing.”

“Hah!?”

“The inside of your mouth looks dry too, not to mention how cracked your lips are. You’re obviously dehydrated.”

With the way things were going, it wouldn’t be very surprising if her first Warning Alert was to go off soon.

Actually, it was entirely possible that it had already gone off by now.

The reason why she had been passively sitting within her tent was probably not just that she was tired, but that she had been trying to prevent an alert from going off due to her abnormal heart rate.

“I’m not all that thirsty… anymore.”

“Anymore? So then, you’re saying you were thirsty at one point?”

I let go of Ibuki’s wrist and she immediately distanced herself from me with an openly hostile look on her face.

“Mind your own business. There ain’t anything wrong with me.”

With that, she turned her back on me once again, but I immediately gave chase and made it to her tent a step ahead of her.

“Wait, wha—? What are you doing!?”

She wasn’t going to listen to me no matter how clearly I spelled it out to her, so I went inside her tent and dragged out her backpack.

“Show me what’s inside.”

“Haaa!? No way in hell I’mma show a guy. No, I wouldn’t even do it for a girl either.”

“Fair enough.”

Since she wasn’t going to grant me permission, I simply opened it up without permission instead.

“Hey! I said no!”

Inside her backpack, there were clothes, amenities, and a bit of food like jerky.

Aside from that, there was a plastic 500ml water bottle, but it was already empty.

Since the school had set up trash receptacles at certain locations such as Task sites, she should've already thrown away anything she didn't need by this point. However, there wasn't so much as a single drop of water inside the plastic bottle, indicating that it had been empty of its contents for quite some time now.

In addition, she didn't seem to have a walkie-talkie or any other form of communication device.

"How long have you been out of water?"

"I don't have to tell you anythi—"

"I said, how long have you been out of water?"

I asked my question again, this time with a stronger tone and a rigid, unsparing gaze.

"...A full day... and then some."

"So you've just been walking around without water like this?"

"Nope. I've been resting here all day today."

"What an obvious lie. There were no GPS signals anywhere near here this morning."

"You did a GPS Search?"

Of course I hadn't. I was bluffing. However, I didn't think Ibuki would call me on it.

After all, with how desperate she was to beat Horikita, I couldn't imagine that she'd willingly choose to take a break.

"Has your first Warning Alert gone off yet?"

"...It did about an hour ago. That's why I reluctantly decided to turn in early for the night."

Warning Alerts worked on a system where they would only stop going off once the detected abnormality stopped happening.

And then, if the same abnormality were to resurface later on, you'd be met with a new Warning Alert rather than having it escalate to an Emergency Alert.

"If you don't rehydrate at some point, it'll keep ringing even if you rest."

If she couldn't get her rapid heart rate under control, an Emergency Alert would be soon to follow.

By the time it came to that, she would likely be even more dehydrated, to the extent that if she were to receive a medical checkup, she wouldn't be able to prevent herself from being sentenced to retirement.

"I'll handle it tomorrow, and if push comes to shove I'll even go back to the starting area, so drop it and leave me alone."

"It's more than two kilometers from here to the starting area. If you were to collapse along the way, it'd be all over."

"Then I'll just do a nearby Task or some shit."

"You can't do that though, can you? Otherwise you wouldn't be in the state you're in now."

The only way to appease Ibuki's irrationality was to present sound logic of my own.

I went and fetched my backpack from my own tent and took out two plastic 500ml water bottles that I had gotten from Tasks earlier today.

"Trade me."

"What?"

"It just so happens that I'm running short on food. On the other hand, I have a bit of an oversupply of water. I'm asking you to negotiate with me since I think we can make a fair trade."

Ibuki swallowed audibly as she looked at the pristine water held within the plastic bottle, however warm it may be.

“How about it? I’ll say it again just to be sure, but I’m looking to make a fair trade here. You’ll have to give me a suitable amount of food in exchange.”

“Who the hell do you think you are to—”

“Feel free to say no, but I won’t be giving you a chance to change your mind.”

I maintained a firm, unyielding attitude, and Ibuki drew silent.

“If you retire due to dehydration like this, you’ll definitely lose to Horikita. In fact, I met with Horikita a little while ago. Her complexion was perfectly fine, and she didn’t seem to be having any problems with water or food either.”

Rather than emphasize the impending threat of expulsion, I dropped Horikita’s name, the most effective buzzword to spurn Ibuki into taking action.

“I get it… I’ll trade with you. But, how much do you want from me?”

With what she had on hand now, Ibuki would run out of food in a little less than two days.

However, if I were to ask for just a few meager scraps, it wouldn’t exactly be a fair trade, now would it?

“Half of your remaining food. That should be enough.”

“Only that much?”

“It’s at least better than sustaining myself by eating random weeds.”

Just like that, we finalized the trade and exchanged the food for water.

As soon as Ibuki had one of the bottles in hand, she popped off the cap and downed about half of it all in one go. Normally, I would’ve told her to try and conserve it, but considering that she was already suffering from dehydration, I felt it better for her to be hydrating herself as soon as possible.

Apparently, she didn’t like me seeing this side of her, as her usual sharp, pointed look quickly returned.

Even if her physical condition were to improve somewhat, her state of mind clearly wasn't normal right now. She had been subjected to a great deal of stress with no time to relax, left with no choice but to try and come to terms with her situation.

I couldn't help but wonder how much longer she'd be able to hold out.

Would it be a few hours, or a few days? Hopefully, she'd be able to persevere until the very end.

Ibuki and I had different Tables, so once we parted ways, we probably wouldn't meet again until after the exam was over.

As such, I felt like I should at least say something more here, for what it was worth.

"I'm not gonna thank you if that's what you're after. It's supposed to be a fair trade, remember?"

"I don't want you to thank me."

"Then whatta you want?"

She was probably sensitive to human contact due to constantly having her guard raised for the past day or so. That mindset would be useful in the short term for sure, but in her current situation, it would only bring about her own destruction.

"If you're not doing too badly with points, how about you spend most of the day tomorrow resting? That, or switch to a strategy where you only focus on acquiring food and water?"

"So you're sayin' for me to give up on scoring points? You've gotta be kidding me."

Upon hearing my suggestion, Ibuki flared up and lost her temper.

"I'm not puttin' in all this work 'cause I don't wanna get expelled. My only goal here is beating Horikita."

I was well aware of that.

And it was precisely because I understood what was motivating her that I was giving her the advice she needed to increase her odds of succeeding.

But… well… Ibuki has hated me ever since she found out that I was the ‘X’ Ryūen had been looking for.

Due to her warped, biased perspective of the type of person I was, my true intentions had no chance of getting through to her.

“I’ve got nothin’ more to say to you.”

Saying that, Ibuki went back inside her tent and zipped up the entrance.

My attempt at persuading her felt like it had been unsuccessful, but my words should’ve at least served as an effective warning.

At any rate, with this, Ibuki should be fine for the next day or two.

Beyond that, it’d be up to her. She’d just have to get back on her feet and secure food and water for herself.

Since she was alone, I was somewhat worried about her score, but having seen how adamant she was about her match with Horikita, she probably wasn’t doing that bad.

Although the night was still young, I had used up a lot of my energy today, so I decided to turn in early.

Despite the muggy summer heat, I spent the rest of the evening relaxing before drifting off to sleep.

Part 1

First thing in the morning, I left the campsite to use the bathroom in the nearby forest. When I returned with my sanitary disposal bag in hand, I caught sight of Ibuki crouching suspiciously beside my tent.

“What are you doing?”

“!”

Her head shot up with a look of surprise on her face. It seems that she had been so focused on rummaging through my backpack that she didn’t notice me return to the campsite.

“Were you trying to sneak a peek at my tablet, or was there something else you wanted?”

Unfortunately for her, it was impossible for a third party to gain unauthorized access to my tablet since I had enabled the lock screen.

“I wouldn’t do somethin’ like that! I just… I just wanted to make sure our trade was actually fair, that’s all.”

After saying that, she quickly distanced herself from my backpack.

“You’ve only got one bottle of water left in there, and you’ve already drunk some of it! I thought you said you had too much water?”

Although I had only been away for just under a minute, I guess I had been a little careless.

Apparently, that had been more than enough time for her to confirm the contents of my backpack.

That being said, I couldn’t exactly blame her given that I had gone through Ibuki’s backpack without permission just the day before. Even if I were to lie and say that I drank the rest of my water last night, she’d just have to ask where the empty bottle was. After all, it was against the rules to litter on the island.

“So what, were you trying to help me out to get me to owe you a favor?”

“If you hadn’t gone through my backpack, you never would’ve felt like you owed me anything though…”

“Grr…”

My words hit right on the mark, causing Ibuki’s cheek to twitch ever so slightly.

“In other words, I’m telling you that the truth doesn’t matter. It was a fair trade either way.”

“I ain’t convinced, but… I get it. If that’s the way it is, I’m not gonna give any water back to you.”

“If I did this to have you owe me a favor, would you pay it back?”

“No way.”

“…Is that so?”

Apparently, she had been compelled to rummage through my backpack simply because she couldn’t bring herself to trust me.

Since the conversation dried up after that, I went back inside my tent.

It was only half-past six when I heard sounds coming from over by Ibuki’s tent.

I unzipped my tent’s entrance to take a look at what was happening, only to find that she had already started to pack up her things.

If this had been the second or third day of the exam, I might’ve thought that she was just brimming with motivation, but…

The vibe she was giving off told me she didn’t want to be disturbed, so I simply looked the other way.

Before long, 7:00 AM arrived, and with it the first designated area of the day, which was announced to be area E4. I immediately decided to spend one point to run a GPS Search and pinpoint the locations of everybody else on the island.

This search was well worth the single point it cost to run it. My score was so close to the 10th place Kuronaga group that I might accidentally overtake them. By spending one point here, the gap between our scores would widen to 12 points. That way, even if I earned 11 points from taking the first-place Early Bird Bonus, I’d still be just barely outside of the top ten.

Looking at the map, there were about three other groups who had the potential to contest me for the Early Bird Bonus.

Among them, there was a certain, particularly formidable opponent sitting in an ideal position for sweeping up the bonus. With that being the case, I decided to give up on fighting for it, which worked out perfectly since my top priority right now was to replenish my resources. Incidentally, this GPS Search also let me see how many students

were nearby the Tasks I was interested in. In other words, it opened up the door for me to predict what the competition would be like before I dedicated any time to pursuing it.

By the time I had finished getting ready and stepped foot out of my tent, Ibuki was already nowhere to be seen.

There was little to gain from taking action before the exam started for the day, but I suppose she just wanted to get away from me as soon as possible.

Part 2

It was a designated area near the installation point, but it took me an hour and a half to get there. When I checked it with the signal delivered from my wristwatch, it was not a first come first serve reward but rather a finish arrival bonus stopping point.

Of course, I was not dissatisfied because I had collected my assignments on the way. From this great height, although for a little, you could see the uninhabited island.

"You have arrived quite late, Ayanokouji."

Right to the side of the view, looking down was Kiryuuin. She said that and directed her voice towards me.

"It looks like it is"

She was the most troublesome person in the same area as me, which I was able to find out at the beginning of the test.

"I thought I had a tough competitor for the reward in order of arrival, but was it you?"

“I don't know what's up with that. It’s not uncommon for there to be different tables in the same area. More than that, I thought that Kiryuuin-senpai was not interested in the top ten groups. "



Kiryuuin has risen from 11th or lower, and this morning she has jumped to 9th.

"This uninhabited island test was more fun than I thought it would be, and I was thrilled beyond my age."

You say beyond your age, but you're only a year older than me.

"I'm going to continue with my current rhythm for a while longer."

“Shouldn't you be aiming for number one?”

"Everyone is competing with each other for the podium. I could not continue with that game. However, if Miyabi Nagumo collapses down, the story could be a little different."

"Collapse", eh? At the moment it doesn't seem like it.

"Do you think Nagumo is going to release Kouenji as he is right now?"

Apparently, Kiryuuin also has some idea of what is going to happen next.

“In such a state of conflict and struggle, Nor can I say that Nagumo will ever win. Sure you have been watching everything up to now, but the time has come for you to move your chips. Depending on how things go, we could see a period where neither team scores. "

It is also possible that one of them will sink and move down the rankings.

"Because hitting your opponent is an important part of a battle."

The part of when he keeps it going is indecipherable, but if he keeps up like this, they will definitely clash.

"Don't you aspire to move to the top?"

"I'm sorry, but I don't see how can I be in the top ten."

"I see. I thought you would have scored almost as many points as I did. "

She seems to have a lot of interest in me. No, I'm not exactly sure I'm the only one. Observing and analyzing what kind of strategy is being used against the entire school from her path.

“Several groups will soon lose their performance. We just have to keep trying and not give up. "

I hadn't heard of Fuka Kiryuuin until recently, but I can see traits that she is quite talented. She is also a third year student with an insight that the OAA app cannot provide on its own.

"That said, from what I see in the table so far, what do you think of the fact that no group has withdrawn?"

"All I can say is that you can't let your guard down, not even for a moment."

“Yesterday I went through the starting point to obtain information. It seems that groups that have started to suffer from food and water shortages are trying to get ahead by separating some of their members to avoid joint collapse. "

"It is a wise decision."

No matter how many points you accumulate, if the whole group withdraws, you will be disqualified and expelled from school. It is safer to send one or two people to the starting point, even if it reduces efficiency. If water is abundant and hygiene is protected, it makes it easier to avoid diseases.

“I am sure that the last 10 will have some hope, no matter which group will withdraw. A man who has lost his way will use whatever means at his disposal. Stay alert, okay?"

"Shouldn't it be something a woman, Kiryuuin-senpai, should be worried about?"

"Hmm... It’s true that, as a pretty and merciful maiden, I might also feel a sense of danger"

It was something I said jokingly, but surprisingly, she thought of it seriously.

"Well if it comes to that ....., I would just have to force it out."

She said that and clenched her fist. The answer was not like a maiden at all.I don't know how serious it was.

“Huh, I'm sorry to take away so much of your time, because you and I need to take advantage of every minute and every second."

After saying that, Kiryuuin slightly raises her hand and walks away.

“Is it a task in the direction you are heading?”

"Aren't you going? Maybe now you still have a chance."

"I will refrain from doing so. I don't think I can compete with Kiryuuin-senpai and win."

At this time, we believe that there are atmost two pools of openings for the challenge; if there are more than three rival groups and Kiryuuin is also heading there, then there is little chance that she will be able to participate.
Looking away, Kiryuin stopped and looked back at a situation where she should hurry.

"So that's a.... no, I dare you to go there and see for yourself."

As if she had realized my strategy, Kiryuuin left saying that and addressed her challenge.

Part 3

On the tenth day, the sun had faded making it dark and it was after nine in the evening. It was when I was checking the stored GPS information in my tablet with the top 10 groups.
Suddenly a bright light flickered from outside the tent.
"Who moves at this time ……?"

It's risky, but you might be able to go through the last designated area that you couldn't step on in the middle of the night. I couldn't help but follow the light from inside the tent. It didn't shine on me, but it seems to glow here and there as it moved. The movement of the flashlight light is unstable and seems to be desperately searching

for something. I was curious to know what was going on, so I decided to leave the tent.
The light from the flashlight illuminates the forest slightly and gradually moves away from me. It seems the person is desperately looking for someone.
Maybe it's Amasawa who came to do something to me, is she looking for me?
No, if she did, I don't think she would use a flashlight this carelessly.
Once they have closed the distance with the GPS, I will take advantage of the darkness to get closer.

"... Yume... Yume-chan"

From where the flashlight was, I heard a faint voice say a few words. I don't know who owns the voice, but apart from the nickname, there is only one person in the school named "Yume".
There is no doubt that it refers to Yume Kobashi of 2nd year of class C. So, is it correct to assume that the owner of the voice is a member of that class? I'm sure there was a girl in Kobashi's group; it was ‘Shiranami Chihiro’.
Anyway, the owner of the voice seems to start crying at the moment. I can ignore it as it is, but being a C class sophomore it should now have a deep connection to Class A's Sakayanagi.
I took my tablet out of the tent and turned on the flashlight.
The light source is not reliable enough to function as an electric light, but it is enough for the other party to notice.
Soon after, the person noticed that light and turned on the flashlight.

"Yume-chan?"

While saying that I hear a voice of panic, the sound of approaching. After the dazzling light illuminated, the owner of the lantern slowly came into view.

"Yume-chan!"

"No, sorry, I'm not Yume"

"Ah....."

What appeared from behind the trees was Shiranami Chihiro.

"Um, Ayanokouji-kun ..... good night."

Although we are not close at all, she somehow showed a bit of relief.
I wonder if this is how dangerous the situation was.

“It is quite dangerous to go out alone in the middle of the night. What happened to Kobashi and Takemoto? "

"Oh, I lost track of where I was ... I was in a hurry and didn't know where I was going"

I'm not going to ask her why she was in the woods alone in the middle of the night. It is in the forest where the same landscape extends 360 degrees, even if you advance with a calm heart, you will lose your sense of direction in the blink of an eye.
As a result, Shiranami must have seen herself away from the group.

"How long has it been since you parted?"

"I don't know ..... 15 minutes or ... About 20 minutes or so .....?"

Even if we would be going in the exact opposite direction, it wouldn't be hopelessly far away, but at least it would have gotten to a point where I couldn't be able hear them.

"In any case, wandering aimlessly will only make things worse."

"Uh-huh."

I took the lead and motion for her to follow me as I used my tablet to light the way. It would be troublesome if we got lost too. I can't go out to find Shiranami and the group, leaving the tent and luggage as is. More or less, some people have been in trouble like this. Now it's just a matter of knowing if you can get back on the road by accident or if it takes a while.
However, if you can't go back, spending the night in the woods in the middle of the night is not an easy thing to do. Because, even if you don't have a big physical problem, you will be mentally exhausted all at once.
Shortly after returning to my camp, I called out to the restless Shiranami.

“There are a lot of bugs. You may want to get into the tent first. "

"Eh!?"

Her voice sounded somewhat fearful mixed with surprise.

"I'm not going in there, so don't worry."

I had some problems with my explanation, but I somewhat forced Shiranami into the tent and closed the entrance.

"I'm sorry ..... I was just resting and ...."

"Nothing happened. Instead, Kokobashi and Takemoto are fine right? "

"Yes."

If that's the case, they'd probably be panicking right now because it looks like Shiranami isn't coming back. I must analyze whether to go looking for them or stay where we are.

"Is there a plan in case someone gets lost?"

I asked, but Shiranami shook her head from side to side.

"There is a possibility that Takemoto will go out alone to look for Shiranami, but there is also the possibility that would become an additional disaster. On the other hand, it would be quite risky for the two of them to leave their tents and luggage and go looking for you. "

If two people start moving together with a tent and luggage, it is not an effective means because even when Shiranami returns alone, it may be out of place. If safety is valued to the maximum, it is desirable not to go to the position where you lose sight of the tent, but to wait for Shiranami to notice by relying on the light and voice of the surrounding area. However, if there is no detailed arrangement and a girl deviates, is it possible to maintain a normal mind? You would often be in a hurry to go looking for them.
What should I do....
Instead of asking for opinion, I was talking to myself. You could say that it would be a minor mistake, but from another perspective, it would be a major mistake. It is not irrational to be attacked by impatience.
The problem is the two boys in the group. No, or more in some cases.

"Is the group still a small group of three? Or is it growing to more than four? "

"That's....."
Shiranami, who had explained in detail so far, was speechless. She knows her group very well, so there is another reason for her to hesitate. Ichinose's class now cooperates with Sakayanagi's class. Of course, there are some friendship groups that transcend these borders, but most of them are created by the agreements of the central nucleus.
Of course, telling me the details of what happens in the group can be called leaking

information. In this sense, it can be assessed that Shiranami made the right decision by not talking about whether the group has been easily changed or not.

“Very good. You don't have to tell me the details of the situation. Just listen to what I have to say. "

In advance, I continued with my words.

"If I were a member of your group, I would be aware of the current situation. I would have concluded that my companion was wandering alone through the dark forest without being able to return."

Shiranami nodded a little.

“Of course I wouldn't leave her alone. First, I would raise my voice and try to harden the sound. However, as I said before, if there is no reaction from this, we have to make the next move. Assuming, for example, that Kobashi deviates by himself, what would Shiranami and Takemoto do? "

"... I don't know ... I think we would go look for Yume-chan ..."

"Even if it causes an additional disaster and they risk getting injured and retiring?"

"I couldn't leave her because she's my friend."

It's a typical response from Ichinose's class. Merits and demerits are another matter. Of course, telling me the details of the situation can be called leaking information. In that sense, it can be assessed that Shiranami made the right decision by not easily talking about whether the group had undergone a change or not.
In an emergency, they would come looking for her using GPS search.
However, in this darkness, I don't know if it will work well even in the vicinity with one or two searches.

“Can you pay points? If you use it 2 times, would you be concerned about your rating after using it three times?

"That's ... I wonder. I don't think it's good. "

Not that she ranks high, huh? Because you won't know if you'll end up in the unaffected range or if consuming those scores will make a difference until after the exam.
Even someone like Shiranami would break her heart to use her score to come looking for her. After all, it is better to wait, but ... but there is also the possibility that there are

patterns that do not appear in the search ....., or that are not found, if this happens, I will not be able to use the tent, so I'll spend the night outside. It will be one of the factors that disturbs the rhythm that has been carried out so far without breaking the rhythm. If we are going to act, it will be at this stage....

"How strong are you?"

"What?"

"Do you have the strength to walk?"

"Uh-huh. Okay, but....."

I urged her to leave the camp and waited for her to come out.

"Let's move so we can unite from now on"

"But how?"

"It is not a problem that can be solved by walking in the dark. We will use this. "

I showed her the tablet in my hand.

"We can use the GPS search to determine where we are going and the approximate distance travelled."

But it still won't be an easy reunion. It's very difficult to get through the forest properly in this dark.
For average students like Shiranami, it would be impossible without using repeated GPS searches."

"But why....are you going out your way to help me.....?"

"Why? Since this exam is a battle based on the same year, that's one aspect of it.

"But even using a GPS search is..."

For me, the use of one or two points is not such a burden. You can always pick up as long as you don't get more than 11th place. There's no point talking about it, so I'll try to

be convincing here.

“If I must say. Maybe it's because you're in Ichinose's class. "

The moment I answered that, Shiranami's face slightly hardened.

"...Maybe..."

“Hmm?” . Could it be that I made an uncomfortable comment?

"....Maybe it's because Ayanokouji-kun ... and Honami-chan .."

Although she said that, Shiranami closed her mouth.
Somehow, I understood without delay what she meant. It's because I remembered many things that Ichinose's classmates told me when I met them the other day.

"It’s nothing."



I replied as I was going to move on, but Shiranami's expression remained dark and hard.
I interrupted the topic for now and start searching. The fact that the GPS of the two names, Kobashi and Takemoto, were displayed on top of the other, it seemed certain that they were still together. We continued walking, looking for Shiranami's group.
I must have walked in the direction of Kobashi and the others' GPS responses for the next ten minutes.

"Chihiro-chan!!!"

As we made our way through a gap in the dark forest, Kobashi, who was carrying a backpack, spotted us. Takemoto, from the same group, was at her side, also with a backpack. It seems that they have come to look for Shiranami with their entire luggage.
Considering the fact that they came directly towards us, it was most likely a GPS search.
As a result, we all had to move to the place where I had set up the tent.

"Thank you, Ayanokouji-kun, for helping Chihiro-chan"

"No, I think you would have found her eventually, it wasn't a big deal."

"Yes it was. If we had gone further, we would have run in the risk of injuring ourselves and, above all, we would have had a hard time finding her. "
Even for Takemoto who was in a different class, he was very relieved that Shiranami was found as soon as possible.
When it comes to chasing, one or two GPS may not be enough.

"I have something to ask, do you have a walkie-talkie?" That's what I told Takemoto at the time.

"What? A walkie-talkie? I have one, but ... "

"If you don't mind, I would like to have a little conversation with Sakayanagi. I would like to ask her if any of the class D students she dealt with have returned to the starting point.

“I'll help you with that. Give me a minute."

Not displeased, Takemoto quickly pulls out a walkie-talkie if that's what it takes to thank me.
The walkie-talkies provided by the school are, of course, digital and have a feature called Confidential Mode. So to speak, it is a feature that allows you to speak only to a specific

person without being accepted by others. The group that prepared the walkie-talkier for this test should have prepared the code to prevent information leakage.
Takemoto used the walkie-talkie to call Sakayanagi to see if she answers.
Soon after receiving a reply from Sakayanagi, he handed me the walkie-talkie.

"I just want to talk to her in private."

When I saw the three of them nodding happily, I kept my distance. Of course, to prove I wasn't doing any tricks, I made sure the walkie-talkie was visible, then after talking to Sakayanagi for a while, I handed the walkie-talkie back to Takemoto.

"That's it, Sakayanagi. Sorry to bother you at this time of night."

Sakayanagi responds to Takemoto who tells her.
The call ended with an exchange that showed that everything was fine and that the conversation was over.

"You saved me; I got the information I needed from Sakayanagi."

" Okay then. Also, Sakayanagi asked me to give this to you,Ayanokoji. "

"Oh...thank you."

I got the walkie-talkie from Takemoto. Apparantly Sakyanagi had asked him the give the possession of the walkie-talkie to me.

"I'm the one who should thank you, huh?"

"No need, and again Ayanokouji-kun thank you for helping us."

Once again the three of them, including Shiranami thanked me, and the four of us decided to spend the night here.
I fell asleep listening to the stories of class A and class C, which I don't usually listen to.

Chapter 4: Encirclement : Koenji VS Free Group

Intro

Kouenji's departure doesn’t fade even after the second stage of the exam. Until today, on the tenth day, he has been scoring points to stick with Nagumo's group. After 5pm, when today's test ended, Ikuto Kiriyama, 3rd year of B-class, who finished speaking into a walkie-talkie, quietly closed his eyes once. He was a bit surprised that Kouenji was on the top podium when the top team’s scores were posted, but at that time there was nothing close to impatience in Kiriyama or Nagumo.
Everyone thought that he would reach the limit soon as long as he was alone.

“Kiriyama. Don’t you think Nagumo's answer is a step backwards? If so, you would have been in a position to take the lead by starting of the second part of the test. That’s why we have been postponing it, and it has not yet been resolved until the tenth day, because it is completely even. "

Mikitani, a student from class 3B, talks to me while showing me his tablet. The overall score of the tablet shows that Nagumo's group has 236 points, while Kouenji has 230. The difference between the two is 6, and yet they are in a position to turn the cake if they get first place in the order of reward of arrival. Nagumo's group, which has a much larger group and more members than Kouenji's group, can secure 7 points in the arrival reward as long as they arrive on time.
The Kouenji group, meanwhile, only has one point, but that makes it the only group that can easily get a reward for finishing first, and has the most rewards for finishing first of all groups.

“Even if Nagumo can get away with it, you'll finish third if you're not careful. If you lost to a loner sophomore(2nd year), our reputation as your supporters would take a nosedive. "

Kiriyama and his team now have a total score of 188 points. The difference between them and Kouenji begins to widen slowly.

“Oh, by the way, there was a rumor last year. Shortly after Kouenji entered the school; it was about the sophomores and juniors in a familiar way, flirting with the purchase of private points. What did you think at that moment?

"All I could think was: 'Don't get carried away just because you're wealthy.' ”

His academic ability was moderate, his physical ability appeared to be high, but he had no outstanding grades, and his family was wealthy. That was undoubtedly the image that all the students of this school had.

Mikitani nodded once at Kiriyama's reply.

“The main reason why Kouenji has not been appreciated is that he doesn’t have a sincere attitude towards things. He has not taken things seriously, he has gone against what he is supposed to do as a student, and he has had a strong attitude of dropping out of the exams from the beginning”.
It was a fact that had spread not only to second-year students, but also to third-year students.
If Kouenji had been a serious and sincere person, he would have been recognized as an enemy to be watched by Nagumo long before.

“I don't know what happened, but Kouenji has literally gone all out in this special survey of the uninhabited island. And the result is that he has become the strongest opponent of all the students. His stamina, especially his tirelessness, was terrifying. I could go all the way like this. "

He advances with his inexhaustible physical strength, taking advantage of being able to move alone. At this point, even as a third year student, I had to think of a move.
If left unchecked, Kouenji will definitely finish the exam in the top three places.
In some cases, it wouldn’t even be possible for me to reach Nagumo. Losing to a group from the younger years was a problem, but losing to a loner would be a disgrace for the third year.
As an adversary to be defeated, one must confront him as soon as possible.
Of course, violence should be avoided as much as possible. If a third year student had attacked Kouenji by surprise, injuring him and forcing him to retreat, there would naturally be a problem.
If they had tried to prevent him from entering the top ranking, they would inevitably face expulsion.
We have to sink Kouenji as peacefully as possible.

"Have you decided what you are going to do? Kiriyama ”.

"We will use the Free Groups."

Free groups. It is a group of three people selected from among five groups of each class, from B to D, prepared by Nagumo, which act as his hands and feet. There are a total of 15 groups, and two of them are assigned to follow the instructions, while the remaining group is assigned to follow the designated area in order not to receive any penalties.
This means that there are two students per free group who can move freely.

"Well, you're right. So how many are you going to use?

“The six groups that I have in custody. I am mobilizing them all ”.

"Six? Are you serious? You're dealing with just one person, and no matter how many there are, four groups with my custody should be enough. The other two groups will be in your custody... "

As if to interrupt Mikitani's words, Kiriyama continued.

“The only threat is Kouenji, and other than that, there is plenty of time to go after destroying him. We will be able to see the results until the end of the 12th. In two days starting tomorrow, we will fully contain Kouenji. Once Kouenji loses his momentum, he won't be able to surface again. "

Even if we met with some other group, it would be the same

“Didn't Nagumo say that there were other groups that interested him? If we attack Kouenji with all the available groups, we will not have enough personnel to dedicate ourselves to the others. "

Mikitani was not told which group it was, but if it was one of the top ten, it was Ryuuen's second year group, Sakayanagi's group, or Utomiya's group and the others in first year.

"I don't think you have to worry about that anymore. Nagumo's fears are unfounded."

Of course, Kiriyama knew which group he was looking for.

However, that group has not appeared in the top ten in ten days. Even if they keep scoring points at a fast pace, they will never reach the podium.

"Blame it on Nagumo"

"... It's rare that Nagumo makes a mistake in that kind of decision."

"An invisible ghost grabbed me by the shoulders, I am not surprised."

The only man Nagumo recognized, the only thing left of Manabu Horikita.
It's no wonder that Nagumo's eyes, which can see the battlefield with an eagle's eye, are clouded.

"So we'll let the six groups take care of Kouenji and we'll just score points as usual, okay?"

"No, I will take direct command to contain Kouenji."

"You? That's a bit inefficient, don't you think? Let me do it."

Kiriyama's Group is currently in third position, so it will affect the score if he moves to prevent Kouenji from advancing.

"Do you want me to put you in charge?"

“It's not that I have decided to win. Unlike you, who have decided to win, I have to earn Nagumo's reputation. "

Mikitani advised him to do so, but Kiriyama didn't seem to listen to him.

"That's not good. There are six free groups so, if you fail, it's a pretty big blow. "

“But you also have to get second place, right? Don't waste your time on unnecessary things. ". Mikitani , eager to get the credit, insisted.

“There is no one who can stop Kouenji except Nagumo and me. That is the end of the story. "

When Mikitani heard these words, he slightly frowned and made a disgusted face. But Kiriyama didn't notice, because he didn't even look at Mikitani.
To stop a student, six groups of students led by Kiriyama rushed to move at night.
If it were a normal opponent, Kouenji's unfathomable ability would be unheard of for Kiriyama. The question was, where would the designated zone be at 7:00 am tomorrow, the 11th?
Depending on where Kouenji starts moving, east, north, south, or west, the scope of the siege (encirclement of enemy) will change.
Therefore, the ideal would be to complete the siege of Kouenji between the hours of the night, when he would have to decide the camping place and stop moving, and 7 in the morning tomorrow.
Fortunately, B3, Kouenji's current location, and E3, where Kiriyama and the others are located, are relatively close to each other.
Since the scores of the groups in the highest places could only be monitored until the end of the twelfth day, there were only two days left, tomorrow and the day after, to see if they had made any progress.

"How far do you plan to go today?"
At the beginning of the long journey, Mikitani asked Kiriyama to ease his boredom.

"As much as possible. I know it's risky to proceed at night, but I want to get to an area around Kouenji in the worst case. We have to reach them before seven in the morning".

Once he starts to move, the difficulty of catching him goes up two or three degrees.

"I think it will be easy to kick him out if we have two days. There are seven groups here, including the six from Kiriyama, for a total of 18 people. "

When Mikitani turns around, he can see sixteen third-year students.

"Don't let your guard down. It is a large forest, there are many possibilities that he will escape. "

"I know he's a bad boy for a second year. But he's still younger than you."

Since neither Kiriyama nor Mikitani directly saw Kouenji's incredible physical abilities, it is difficult to make an accurate assessment. However, as third-year students they have worked with on various assignments have provided them with data on Kouenji's physical abilities.

"Be cautious. Recognize your opponent as your greatest enemy."

"The oldest? "

Kiriyama said to himself: "I knew I couldn't trust someone like Mikitani with this."
If we have become the enemy to defeat, we have to act with the intention that he stops breathing. If they respond with little enthusiasm, they could find themselves in the situation of being defeated.

Part 1

The next day, the 11th, a little after 6:30 in the morning. Kiriyama's group and six free groups, including Mikitani's, had succeeded in besieging Kouenji.

"What is the situation?"

“There doesn't seem to be any movement in the tent yet. He's sleeping slowly. It would be so much easier for us if he got sick and stayed in bed all day."

Mikitani started talking to the members of the free group.

"Hey, why don't we go around him and block him before he leaves the tent? If we make it impossible for him to leave the tent, Kouenji won't be able to move."

Mikitani made that suggestion, and the others in the free group agreed that it would be easy.

“If we interfere with his departure, we can delay the time it takes to reach the designated area. But what would your excuse be if a third party saw the situation? If you are going to interfere, you must refrain from doing something that can be easily recognized. "

Even if you break the rules, you should eliminate the risk as much as possible.

“Why don't you do a GPS search? Anyway, there are a lot of points to spend. ”

“Our tablets don't know where the teachers are. Do not forget that the search is not absolute. As originally planned, we'll be settling in when Kouenji clears the tent and starts moving. If you come across a freshman or sophomore, or an adult on your way to set a task, immediately open a distance of at least two meters from Kouenji.”
Kiriyama has nailed it: "Do not shorten the distance to the point of making contact."

As seven o'clock approached, the situation finally changed.

"It's on the move, it's Kouenji!”

He had no idea they were watching him, and he hummed as he began to take down the tent. They were well on our way and it seemed that they had finished preparations for departure before the clock struck seven. And with your tablet in hand, you expect the exam to start at seven.

"Go."

Kiriyama decides that this is the best time to leave and head towards Kouenji. Mikitani and the other members of the free group followed close behind.

Whether or not he was aware that Kiriyama and the others were silently approaching, Kouenji did not stop handling his tablet and didn’t even look up. Even after being surrounded by a total of 18 people, Kouenji continued to act as if he were oblivious to their presence.

"Can you give me some time, Kouenji?"

They called Kouenji by name, but his gaze stayed on the table and he didn't look up.

"Do you want something from me?"

This was not the way to address a superior, but Kiriyama continues without any reproach. Kiriyama is aware that Kouenji Rokusuke doesn't have any common sense.

"I didn't expect you to do so well in this special exam."

"Is this something we should talk about right now? It's almost seven in the morning. Shouldn't you hurry up and get ready to go to the designated area?"

"You know what I mean, Kouenji. You've got too many points."

Kiriyama said, since Kouenji was sounding like he didn't understand anything, but that couldn't be true.

"I want you to stay where you are the rest of the day."

"Does that mean you don't want me to earn points ……?"

"Yes."

Of course, there was no way for Kouenji to shake his head when saying this.

“I don't know who you are, but you only need to think a little to realize that it is an impossible proposal. But even so, the fact that you have brought so many people means that you are prepared to interfere with my plans even if I ignore it, right? "

“It is not good that you are in a group alone. I acknowledge that you have made great progress so far, but your results will most likely drop in the second half of the exam as you get tired. "

"Then you don't have to worry about me, right?"

“It is a matter of precaution. Also, it is difficult for a third year student to accept the fact that he is competing for the highest position with you, a lonely student. The following is not a bad idea, if you are willing to follow it. If you have the student council president, Nagumo, on your side, your school life will be more stable. ”

There are two options for Kouenji: he can be held back by force tactics, or he can obey and side with Nagumo.
The time is exactly 7 o'clock, and the first designated zone of the 11th appears on the tablet. After confirming it, Kouenji slowly put his tablet back in his backpack.
At that moment Kiriyama and the others were watching to see if it would move or not.

"I'm going to hurry, so if you'll excuse me."

As soon as the words of rejection were spoken, Kouenji accelerated instantly and ran into the free group.

"Hey, hey!"

Although they were surrounding him, there was still enough room to sneak around, so he took the opportunity. It would be a lie to say that everyone, including Kiriyama, had not been caught off guard; they had underestimated the likelihood that he would ignore the orders of the third-year students and flee.

"I'm going after him!"

Mikitani yelled, but meanwhile Kouenji disappeared into the depths of the forest.

- "Don't be scared, you will hurt yourself if you match Kouenji's rhythm."

"This is not the time to relax! We have lost it!"

“You may get the reward on a first come, first serve basis, but that's how far it goes. If Kouenji chooses to flee, he will not be able to take his time to participate in the tasks. On the other hand, if he chooses to participate with impunity in the challenge, we will be able to catch up with him there. "

Kiriyama knew that it would be dangerous to determine which area Kouenji was heading to based solely on the direction in which he fled, but he also knew that it would be impossible to hide from the GPS search. Still in a hurry, Mikitani started running after Kouenji.

Part 2

Kiriyama and the rest of the free group, led by Mikitani, were following Kouenji.

"What is Kouenji's position?"

"I've looked for it three times, but it hasn't moved at all."

It is unnatural for him not to move at all, even if it is not break time.

In case you are looking for the best way to get the most out of your business, you will want to take a look at this particular website. Kiriyama also peers at the tablet to find out what caused Kouenji's inexplicable behavior.

"It doesn't seem like there is a task nearby."

"Yes. We will reach Kouenji in about 200 meters. "

“This time we will be attentive and we will make sure to catch it. Good."

"I don't need you to tell me."

Kouenji wanders off, but about six hours after they start chasing him, they are surprisingly reunited.
The reason he hadn't moved was because he had fallen asleep even though it was broad daylight.
The third year students look at each other in disgust. Mikitani walks up as a representative, looks at Kouenji's face and says with a strong tone.

“Get up, Kouenji! You've been running for more than 10 days, so you took a nap from exhaustion, right? "

Even if he didn't want to sleep, he had to. When he thought about the reason why he was asleep in the situation he escaped from, he could only think of one thing: Mikitani.
Slowly opening his eyes, Kouenji smiles and laughs softly.

“I'm sure you will agree. I am a human being like you. "

“If that's the case, then go ahead and take the rest of the day off. You must be exhausted from all this. You must listen to the kind advice of your elders. "

“Take the day off? That's kind of funny. "

Kouenji gets up, unfazed by the situation around him.Mikitani had been looking down, but when Kouenji, who is over six feet tall, got up, his gaze reversed naturally.
His eyes were full of vitality and he seemed much larger than the Kouenji from before.

“Don't... make an effort. If you could get rid of fatigue just with a little rest, no one would have a problem. "

Mikitani, feeling intimidated, approached him.

- "Do not worry. My physical strength has already recovered perfectly. I don't want you to talk about me as a normal person. "

It is possible to take it as a mere posture, but Kiriyama directs his words to Kouenji, who seemed to be relaxed.

“You certainly look good. But like Mikitani said, you've run for the last 10 days or so with more energy than anyone. There's no question about it, since you've probably repeatedly ranked first in the order of arrival. But even if you have extraordinary stamina, you should have reached your limit by now. "

"I think that if you are reaching your limit, you are not in the realm of normal people."

"You mean you haven't reached your limit yet?"

Kiriyama's suspicion intensifies, but Kouenji responds immediately.

“I have a very short dream. I have an extremely low REM phase. "
[Note: REM phase is the part where dreams occur]

"What? What is that REM phase, huh? "

Mikitani lunged at Kouenji's comment, but here for the first time Kiriyama's expression hardened.

- “A short dream. .... If that's true, then we have a serious problem. "
- "What do you mean, Kiriyama?"

- "The ideal average daily sleep time for a human being is about seven to eight hours. It is said that the ideal amount of sleep is between seven and eight hours a day, because more or less is not enough to maintain good health. However, those who sleep little are those who are predisposed to maintaining good health, even if they sleep less than six hours. "

Sleep is an alternate cycle of REM and non-REM phases. The REM phase is the stage in which the brain is active and awake, so to speak. On the other hand, the non-REM phase is when the brain is asleep.
Since those who sleep less spend less time in REM sleep, they are able to rest their brain and body even with little rest.

"It seemed strange to me to sleep in peace, but I suppose that is what there is ..."
Kouenji has extraordinary physical strength, but even so, fatigue often appears after a long period of intense travel and repeated challenges.

The time remaining after reaching the designated area or when there are no tasks nearby.
By sleeping well here, Kouenji was able to keep his stamina at a high level.
If the claim that he has a super short sleep is true, it means that Kouenji is not only physically stronger than a normal person, but his resilience is also beyond normal.
For the first time, a slight impatience arose in Kiriyama.
Everyone was tired and exhausted, even when they were trying to keep up.
The mere act of walking makes your legs cry out for a break and makes your heart break for not wanting to take the exam anymore.
That is the common perception of students in their deep psychology.
With that premise in mind, he thought it wouldn't be difficult to contain Kouenji.
With that they thought that it would end up collapsing.

"By the way, do you still need me?"

"I don't care if you are physically strong or not, shut up ..."

If you're looking for the best way to get the most out of your business, you'll want to take a look at the following.

"I'm not here at all, don't worry about us."

He avoided direct expressions as much as possible and tried to keep things smooth.
Mikitani was even more frustrated by such a tepid attitude, but he complied.

"You seem quite belligerent when you say that."

He didn't seem to heed the third year's advice or threats.
In the middle of the conversation, when the third designated zone was announced, Kouenji glanced at his tablet and immediately started walking in that direction.

"I'm not one to accept advice, Kiriyama."

"It may be true."

"And he's probably bluffing when he says he has a super short sleep."

However, while many students have already lost a lot of effectiveness, Kouenji has maintained a good pace almost unchanged from the beginning. It is evident that he had constantly trained his body every day and also considering the special exam on the uninhabited island as one more part of his training. This is how he analyzes it.

“It's useless, I'll change my strategy. We will seal the matter. "

At this point, Kiriyama finally made up his mind and instructed each of them to hunt down Kouenji.
However, Mikitani's lips pursed in dissatisfaction.

“I'm the one in charge now. Don't interrupt the circle, Mikitani. "

"Tch, ..."

While they were puzzled by Kouenji's steady pace, the third-year students began to expand widely. The 18 formed a circle with Kouenji in the center.
Also, Kiriyama called his friends while communicating with them by walkie-talkie.
Without thinking about what was going to happen next, Kouenji kept walking.
He do not stop moving or stay still.
Kiriyama had three plans in total: The first was simply to persuade Kouenji to give up his top streak using words, which of course included surrounding him with various people to pressure him. The second strategy was to keep Kouenji in a circle and move on. The third strategy was to get ahead of Kouenji's task.
With six groups free and Kiriyama, a total of seven groups interfering, the obstacle to participating in tasks inevitably becomes quite high. Also, if they all stick around just to crush Kouenji, they can lower the chances of his winning the task.
Each task has different participation requirements, but the pattern was fixed.
There are two types of tasks: "Each task is open to a different number of players" and "Each task is open to a group of players".
In the latter case, a free group that does not have all its members together does not meet the participation requirements, but most tasks that require group participation basically

require two or more members. In other words, Kouenji, who is working alone, can only participate in assignments that require the participation of one person, so the third-year students here can participate as well.
For a time, the third-year students followed him without any distraction, but gradually they grew impatient.
Kouenji's speed was so fast that it could be mistaken for a foot race if you looked closely, and just keeping up with him consumed a lot of stamina. The simple act of walking at the same speed was beginning to make them feel extremely tired.
When they were forced to adjust to the unusual speed of the march, they felt a wave of exhaustion. It would be so much easier if they just ran.

"Kouenji! Don't be so harsh!"

Mikitani yelled impatiently, judging that he was only thrusting forward with empty energy.

"Well, well, they're getting noisy. So, let me pick up the pace a bit."

With these words, Kouenji started running again.

“Don't let him get away this time! Surround him!

The third year students who had been chasing him while keeping their distance simultaneously approached Kouenji. I'm not sure what to do, but I'm sure they can figure it out.

"No way, no way, no way ..."

The third-year student's words were drowned out by the wind. Kouenji's legs were as fast as if he was running in a well-kept field. He was as fast as a sprinter as he glided through the trees. Most of the twelve members of the free group were proud of their physical strength and in the OAA, their physical abilities are above a B.
These are the soldiers, so to speak, that Nagumo and Kiriyama have brought together to monopolize many of the tasks.

"Chase him! Don't let him escape!"

"Wait, Mikitani, don't act on your own!"

"Shut! I won't let him get away twice! Catch him and drag him! "

Ignoring the instructions, Mikitani and the others went after Kouenji.

"Moron..."

Kiriyama, who had momentarily wondered if he should hunt him down, calmly looked at his tablet and rethought his strategy.
It was hard to believe that Kouenji had started running for no reason.
They should consider whether his goal is a designated area or a task.

“There is a task at E3 that Kouenji can participate in. But the reward is 8 points for first place or ... No wonder the reward for first place of 10 points is the highest priority, but where is the designated zone for the... guys? "

D4 is the most likely direction, but it could also be any other random zone.

"This is not a good place to analyze ..."

Part 3

As a result, Kouenji's goal was to participate in an assignment at E3

He quickly got to the desired task and agreed to participate. He immediately stopped on his way. After a few minutes of delay, Mikitani and his team caught up with Kouenji. However, they were forced to wait until the end of the task because one person had accepted after Kouenji and the number of participants had reached their capacity. Task was an English test, and although there were participants in grades one through three, the content level was the same.
The result was that Dodo Michimichi, one of the most gifted third-year students, took first place, but Kouenji came in a close second, and was awarded four points.
With the teachers' eyes on him, Mikitani and his team planned to approach him as soon as he left the task area, but Kouenji ran before his eyes disappeared.
However, Kouenji fled before they could reach him. They were forced to distance themselves and just chase after Kouenji, who was too fast for them to catch up.
The next time they were able to circle Kouenji was just before 3:00 p.m., when they reached the designated area for the third time.

Mikitani and his team managed to corner him three times.

"They sure are working very hard."

"We cannot pretend to be something we are not".

On the eleventh day, they tried to anticipate the task in advance, but could not stop him even once.

It is no exaggeration to say that my pride as a third year student was shattered.
And when Nagumo found out about this result, he was very disappointed.
Calm is no longer a word that has any meaning in this situation.

"This is your last warning, Kouenji."

Kiriyama led the free group around Kouenji's path and told him.

"Only tomorrow. Take our advice and stay put. That's it."

If we can keep him at bay for a day, Nagumo will be able to escape with the safe first place. The important thing is not to let Kouenji take the top spot again.

"Oh hey, Nagumo wants us to keep him for two days. ……!? We should do it tomorrow and the day after tomorrow?

"The day after tomorrow, we will no longer be able to see the groups in the lead. I don't think there is any group that is going to come after us strongly, but we should concentrate on improving our own score instead of retaining the others."

This was the only decision of Kiriyama, who had seen the situation in Kouenji up close.

"I don't think it's a good idea to dedicate a total of three days to Kouenji."

"Then leave the minimum number of guards and leave him abandoned for two days!"

"Do you think Kouenji will accept that?"

If it's just for one day, chances are good that Kouenji will be able to hold the top two or three.

"It is impossible for him to accept defeat"

"It depends on how you do it."

Mikitani, who had been following Kiriyama with dissatisfaction up to this moment, turned towards him.

"... Do you think you can do it?"

“I can do it. If I can do it, I'll get a ticket for class A. "

He then turned to Kouenji and said.

“I'm sure you heard us. I'm going to ask you to stay here tomorrow and the next day. "

"Are you asking me for a favor?"

"No, it's an order."

"It is a request that I cannot ignore, but what happens if I refuse?"

"In the worst case, you will be expelled."

Although he didn't say it in words, it was clear from the fire that it was a form of violent suppression. Even with the threat, Kouenji didn't stop smiling fearlessly, waiting to see what the third-year students would do.

"If you don't answer, does it mean that you will obey me?"

"I don't obey anyone."

“Then I will make you obey me. You understand, Kouenji? Right...Kiriyama. "

"As long as Kouenji obeys, I will leave it up to you."

But as soon as the last designated zone for the day was announced, Kouenji got up. Seeing this, Mikitani rushes to give him direct instructions and surrounds him.

"I have told you. I told you to stay put. "

Since they were so close that their skin touched, the only way for Kouenji to move was to forcefully shove the third-year students.

“It is not a pretty situation. I don't like male sexuality. "

"What would you do? If you try to push me away, I will take it as a declaration of war. "

"Oh I see."

Laughing, Kouenji took a step forward.
Of course, that big step was enough to touch Mikitani in front of him. But there was no pretense of trying to push him away with his arm. He just started walking normally, so it was as if their shoulders were colliding with each other.
The point was, he was trying to force his way through without raising his hands. It could have been taken as a push, but Mikitani was confident that he would be able to hold his ground thanks to his good physique. This was an opportunity to show that being fast was not the same as being powerful.
But it was as if a large rock was slowly crashing into him, and before he knew it, he was forced to move to the side to give way.
Kouenji, on the other hand, showed no sign of having hit an obstacle and kept walking solemnly and silently.

"Hey, wait!"

Mikitani rushed to grab Kouenji's shoulders, but was unable to stop him with half-hearted force.
If Kouenji was allowed to go unnoticed by now, the stupid development will repeat itself.
Mikitani clicked his tongue and when Kiriyama saw all this he then changed his mind.
He then called one of his friends and tries to stop Kouenji with two of his own.

Morooka, who had been dragged to stop him, collapsed. Then he fell exaggeratedly and showed signs of suffering.

"What? I think I have broken my arm! "

Morooka ranted and ranted loudly like the appeal of a soccer player.

"You have done something terrible, Kouenji."

"You sound like a hit man."

"No matter what you say, it doesn't change the fact that you pushed Morooka away."

The modest strategy of a moment ago has disappeared.

“It seems that you are willing to hit us, your senpai. But if you did, you'd be in big trouble right? "

"You can not touch me."

He said, nailing it ahead of time. However, Kouenji continued after Mikitani.

“I have no intention of showing mercy to those who prevent me from moving forward, much less turning against me.”

Mikitani's expression froze for a moment as Kouenji replied that he was willing to resort to violence.

“What if we report it to the school?"

"What's going to happen, or is it just going to be a stain on the name of the third year students who tried to sink a lone kouhai?"

“I don't need to confirm that Mikitani's watch is working properly. Otherwise, they would not have been able to enter the challenge ahead of Kouenji. "

“It was about time, right? Your group has put a damper on my chances of earning the order rewards. ”

More than ten minutes had already passed since the announcement of the designated area. He was sure the rivals are heading to the designated areas that Kouenji should be heading to one after the other.
There is a good chance of regaining first place from here, but what will happen is unclear.

"I'm sorry, but you're not going to ..... go."

Based on her steadfast determination, Mikitani said that he would not hesitate to fight Kouenji.

"I can't be nice to you all the time."

"Does that mean you're going to turn against me?"

The third year students had been confused by Kouenji's environment up to that point, but they remembered their role. They knew it was an embarrassing situation to be surrounded by so many younger students, but if this was the only way to survive, they couldn't pretend otherwise. Normally, the other party would realize that there is no end in sight, but Kouenji was different. The man, who had no interest in anyone but himself, was only thinking about how to handle the situation here to make it beautiful. His blonde hair was as lustrous as a woman's, and he never failed to maintain it even while living on an uninhabited island. He lightly touched his slightly unruly bangs and smiled. Mikitani, momentarily shocked and frightened by this, walked away.

"Time is money, come quickly."

Kouenji, who was prepared to receive the attack, slowly spread his arms and gestured to accept the attack from the third year students.

"Didn't you, Mikitani? You really want to do it."

“... Ah. If that's the case, I'll go down with Kouenji in my arms. Let's do it! "

At the same time as the scream, three students rushed towards Kouenji at once. One of them will grab him from behind, while the other two from the front and left.
At first glance, it may seem difficult to deal with all three jumping at the same time, but that doesn't mean that all three are especially experienced in the struggle or be coordinated.
Just trying to compete with Kouenji at a similar time. No one is really trying to hit him, it's more of a weird kind of thinking for him.
Kouenji dodged them all with one spectacular stride, causing the surprised third-year students to collide head-on.

"Hey, hey, watch out!"

"You too!"

It wasn't a pretty combination at all, and the third graders complained to each other like they were arguing.

"Do not lose sight that the target is Kouenji."

Part 4

After a few moments, Kouenji found himself surrounded by exhausted third-year students and on their knees, breathing heavily.
He broke their spirits by continuing to nullify their attacks without directing a single fist.

“What... the hell is it...? You are a real monster. I'm sure it would have been a lot easier ... "

Even as Mikitani walked away in amazement and fear, Kiriyama realized that he could have taken advantage of the gap.

“It's not nice that you always follow me. It's not nice to have a dead leaf slapping my cheek over and over again. "

Hearing this, Kiriyama analyzed the situation without panicking, despite being in a difficult situation.

"I see. It is true that the current Mikitani was prepared to go after you until the end. If he was shown such an overwhelming skill difference, his spirit would be broken. But you are the only one who can devise and perform the trick of breaking your opponent's heart without counterattacking. "

"Even if I have to drop the reward for reaching the designated area, here I will nip the counterattack of third year students in the bud."

Kiriyama and the others were surprised by Kouenji, who had made that decision.

"Are you okay, Mikitani?"

"Oh yeah. I'm not hurt."

Some students fell to the ground in the form of self-destruction, but all were mostly unscathed, with only a few scratches on their hands at most.
In the face of such overwhelming power, it didn't even take a fist to show the difference.

"I'll go then, if it's okay with you."

"Do what you want, Kouenji."

"Now if you'll excuse me. Bye."

No one could stop him, and Kouenji left. After that, Mikitani muttered to himself in a broken spirit.

"What the hell is that guy? Is he really in high school?"

"There is always someone who does not agree with your calculations. Like Nagumo."

"In the end, the only thing we can do is crawl on the ground like this forever?"

Mikitani hit the ground with his fist in frustration at his inability.

"That monster of youth! He even made me look like an idiot! He made me look like an idiot! Shit! Shit!"

Our fight is not over yet. He glanced back at Kouenji's missing figure and grabbed his walkie-talkie.

"Are you going to report my failure to Nagumo?"

"What do I win? I'm someone who has already decided to win. Don't worry, Miki, I've already assumed from the beginning that Kouenji is out of this world. But there is always one weakness in every opponent. You know what they say, big is better than small. "

Mikitani nodded silently, feeling somewhat grateful for Kiriyama's words.
Kiriyama, for his part, was not the least bit upset because he had expected this to happen from the beginning.
A strategy to give a blow to Kouenji, who is sure to have removed the obstacle.
Despite the large number of people who interfered, almost no real damage occurred. As a result, Kouenji must have gotten the strong impression that third-year students were no big deal. That was exactly what Kiriyama wanted.

Part 5

Day 11, just before 5:00 p.m. I had barely reached the last designated zone, J10, when I was startled by the sight. It is important to collect scores and homework objects, but even more important is to be careful with scoring. It's surprisingly difficult to keep 11th place at all times. You have to make sure you don't step on the designated area and get penalized, and you also have to keep up with those who score in 10th place.

Yesterday, on the 10th day of the test, the third designated area was announced as F4 followed by a random area in B9, and I gave up soon. I couldn't even get to C9, the fourth designated area, and had to pass twice in a row. I managed to get to the first designated area in the morning, C8, and avoided the penalty, but this time I couldn't get to the random area of H9, and had to get to I9, which was a tough day.
Once an area is designated as a long-distance destination, the next area continues to refer to it. I realized once again the main reason why my overall score was not increasing.
As I reached the end of the steep and rocky road I could hear a man and a woman talking to each other in front of me.
Maybe it's because the wind was blowing, but the voice was vaguely familiar.
I thought I might know them, so I decided to take a look. The voice comes from the west, the direction of the ocean. There, I caught sight of a group of three girls from 2nd year class B, consisting of Isoyama Nagisa, Morofuji Rika, and Shiina Hiyori.
... And there were three more from another group of sophomores. I haven't seen them since the first day of the exam.
It was Ishizaki Daichi, Takeko Nishino, and Hitomi Tsutsube.
I'm sure I've heard of them. The squares were supposed to be different at first, but did the designated zones overlap this time?

"What? Isn't it Ayanokouji-kun? "

The five of them were still talking and had not yet noticed my presence, but only Hiyori, who was in front of me, perceived my presence and noticed me. As soon as our eyes met, she waved at me.

"You look better than I thought."

"Everyone has worked very hard. We have expanded our group to a maximum of six people."



This is how they met Ishizaki and the others. Truth be told, it seems that many of the students of the group lack ability, but Hiyori can bring a lot in terms of brains. That's what she is for. However, her physical capacity is not as high as it should be. Taking into account the members of the group, I would say that they function in a balanced way.

"Did you plan to join Ishizaki and the others from the beginning?"

"That's right. We have several priorities for the merger, and this is one of those groups."

Without denying it, I turned my gaze to where Ishizaki and the others were chatting as they gazed at the soon-to-set sun, as if to ease their fatigue.
They seem to get along well with each other as they are basically a group made up of 2nd year class B. Tsutsube, the only one of a different class, integrated very well.

"Ayanokouji-kun, how do you feel?"

Hiyori didn't seem especially bothered by the fact that no one was coming after her.

"Yes. So far, so good."

“I don't think there is anything to worry about, but you have to be careful."

"I know."

She motioned for me to sit next to her and I did.

"There are three days left."

"That's how it is".

I don't think she asked me for any particular reason. After that, we silently stare at the sea and feed our spirits. In most cases, when I meet a friend or someone close to a friend, they ask me how I am doing.
As it is a battle for survival, curiosity cannot be avoided. Hiyori, however, showed no sign of asking me what my score was. It is not so much that she is not interested, but that she is convinced that they will not expel me.

"Hey, Ayanokouji!"

I'm not sure if he finally noticed my presence or not, but for some reason, Ishizaki

smiled at me in a very happy way. The rest of the group seemed to notice immediately and grabbed Ishizaki by the shoulders as he tried to approach us.

"What the hell? Don't get in my way. "

"What? It's not that Ayanokouji doesn't like it, right?"

"Do not..."

"Nothing happens. That is one of the good things about you, Ishizaki-kun. "

"No. Good point? I'd say you just can't read the air."

"Well ..... yes, that could be undeniable."

Nishino and Tsutsube have become good friends with each other. This would be a common sight for many groups in a prolonged battle on an uninhabited island.
If we work together as much as we can to avoid being kicked out, we can easily overcome the smallest of barriers. But at the same time, it is also cruel. After this special exam is over, the class war will resume again, and the future awaits us as we kick each other out.
At that time, there will be few students who will not be able to make normal decisions.

"Sorry to interrupt."

I was about to leave when Ishizaki came running up and grabbed me by the shoulder.

"Anyway, you don't have any more tests today, and you were planning to camp near I9, right?"

The designated area, J10, was not suitable for pitching a tent due to the strong wind and rocky ground. In that sense, I was going to avoid the seashore, as Ishizaki said, and I would go by I9 .....

"It's a great idea!"

Hiyori, who had just got up, approached me in agreement. These two people are relatively close to me and don’t have problems, but what about the others?

"Isn't it good? Ayanokouji-kun seems quite harmless."

"I know."

And apparently, there was not a single objection. What can I say; I found the group to have such a comfortable and friendly atmosphere that I almost forgot that we were doing a very tough special exam.
This kind of environment is often seen in Ichinose's class, but it seems that Ryuuen's class is also starting to change little by little.

Part 6

"Ayanokouji-senpai, Ayanokouji-senpai ...!"

In the middle of the night, while falling asleep, I woke up to a voice calling out to me. The voice was a silent whisper that could not be heard, and it came from right next to my tent. I checked my watch and it was around 2:30 in the morning.

"It's me, Nanase."

She comes over quickly and peers into my tent. The light from the tablet in the dark shows Nanase's terrified figure.

"What are you doing here at this time...?"

"I'm fine; I was in I9 like you. In fact, I even saw you from afar at night, but since I was working with Housen-kun, so I decided to avoid contact. "

"... Y?"

"There is something I need to tell you as soon as possible ...Today... well, the date has already changed, so it was yesterday to be exact, but Housen-kun told me that on the twelfth day, the first years will make a great play on Ayanokouji-senpai. "

"A great play? It sure isn't the only thing."

"No, no, let me tell you in order."

Nanase calmed her breathing and began to explain.
I'm not sure how many days passed, but Housen was summoned by Takahashi, Yagami, Tsubaki, and Utomiya, but he ignored them. However, on the ninth day, a student who appeared to be an errand boy for one of the group members showed up with a walkie-talkie and again asked for Housen's help. This is what he said. He wanted to force me to withdraw at the end of the uninhabited island exam. He also said that he intended to hunt down and remove seniors who were performing alone as well.
He said that specific details would be communicated on the day of the event, and that the walkie-talkie was still in Housen's possession, but Housen has no intention of cooperating with them. It seems that Nanase has been told that the plan is to use them by pretending that they will cooperate.
I knew he would try to make a move at the end of the exam. It is worth having a move in advance.

"It's good that you told us the date and the details until the last moment."

If the date and details were leaked to us, it would be easier for us to deal with it.
In fact, Housen, who could betray them, has not yet received the details of the plan.

"Who is in charge?"

"I don't know, but Tsubaki was the main person I spoke to on the walkie-talkie. "

"She didn't seem like the type that has long been outdoors."

“I agree with you, because I had the impression that Class C was more focused on Utomiya. But Utomiya and Housen don't get along, and when it comes to arguing, they quickly get into quarrels, so Tsubaki may have been deliberately chosen to act as an intermediary. "

There is also the possibility that someone like Yagami or Takahashi is pulling the strings behind the scenes.

- “I appreciate knowing the date of the meeting. It is best not to stay too long, even late at night. It's good to know what's going on. "

For better or for worse, Housen and Nanase will have to stay in the same freshman class D. I'll tell her to go before Housen finds out.

"Yes, I'll let you know if there is more important news."

"Oh no, thanks for that, but that's enough for this uninhabited island exam. If you see a freshman moving around, you don't have to come tell me, and you don't have to help me."

"Nevertheless..."

"Nanase, you have given me enough information. Now you must do what you have to do as one of the group of Housen and Amasawa."

If Nanase loses all credibility here, there will be no more information. I'm sure you can find something that works.

"If Ayanokouji senpai says so, I understand ..."

I bowed my head deeply and decide to do so, and Nanase walks away into the dark.
When I could no longer see her, I took out my tablet and thought for a while.
My drowsiness disappeared and I start looking at the screen. The details of first-year D-class are unknown, but Housen is a person who uses a type of power similar to Ryuuen's to control the class and act. However, the difference is that Housen tends to take the initiative to try to overcome obstacles.
In this situation, Housen has kept Nanase close to him since the beginning of school.
It is true that Nanase has a strong and tough mindset that most high school freshmen do not have, and with her academic ability and physical prowess, there is no question that she is a valuable asset.
However, Housen's level of trust in Nanase remains completely unknown.
If you didn't trust her, would you let her know about the surprise attack from the first year?
I don't think Housen alone can sustain the idea that Nanase is on my side, but I wouldn't be surprised if he felt some kind of discomfort. If Amasawa is advising him, there is a chance that he may see the truth .....
Either way, the first year's plan of attack isn't surprising. I'm not sure what to make of this. It was nice that Nanase came to inform me, but she did not change our plans in any way.

Part 7

After a brief sleep, I turn on the GPS search just as 6:00 AM arrives. If I do this today I should see some unusual activity among top freshmen, including Housen.

There is nothing unusual about the positioning. The only one at the same table, Housen, is in a close position, but everyone else is at least three squares away. There is no indication that they are preparing anything at this time. It's hard to imagine being attacked in a public place, so as long as Ishizaki and the others are around, we can assume we're safe.

Hiyori, Ishizaki and the others began to wake up and prepare for the 12th day of the exam. When everyone was ready, we started walking together.
Ishizaki complained, still groggy from sleep.
It can not be helped. We will lose points if we suddenly step on the designated area.

Ishizaki and Nishino started talking. They must have been talking like this for more than ten days. The rest of the group concentrated on walking, as if they weren't listening.

"Ayanokouji-kun, do you ever feel lonely being in the exam?"

Hiyori, who was walking beside me, asked me.

"Not especially. I feel more comfortable. "

"I think ..... It's a bit lonely and scary."

“Scared, huh? I can't imagine Hiyori being scared. "

Since she is always so relaxed, she seems to be insensitive to these issues. Even when psychic phenomena occur, she seems to just clap her hands and say, "This is amazing!"

“But I'm still pretty scared, you know. That is why I am sincerely impressed with Ayanokouji-kun. "

I think Horikita and Ibuki are doing better than me.
The longer you struggled with loneliness, the weaker your mental state became, and the more you began to think about things you didn't need to think about.
You begin to feel things that are not there in the sound of the wind or the swaying of the trees.

"Surely ... living on an uninhabited island alone is ... impossible for me."

Hiyori looked a bit scared when imagining it.

Only through this test of the uninhabited island was I able to see an unusual side of her.

“They are very close. Don’t they?"

I'm not sure how long he had been walking in front of everyone, but Ishizaki turned around, looked at us, and said so. (You don't need to get involved in anything else)

"Why don't they go out? They can be couples and that's how Ayanokoji comes to our class, right?”

“You’re thinking about it a lot."
Nishino throws a strong punch and Ishizaki yells holding his head.

"It's funny, isn't it, Ishizaki-kun?"

With a giggle, Hiyori replies without seeming to care. If I took Ishizaki's words at face value every time, I'd be in trouble. I will let it pass.

"Ouch, that hurts. If you want to put Ayanokouji in your class, don't you think it's necessary?"

"I do not think so at all. You are the one who is so obsessed with Ayanokouji-kun. "

For those of other classes, who do not know the details of the situation, that would be more mysterious. Getting a perfect score on an exam can seem like too demanding.

"Well, what can I say? ... We are on the same wavelength."

“I don't think you are on the same wavelength. I don't think anyone is on the same wavelength as you. "

Faced with Nishino's harsh response, Ishizaki sought help without hesitation.

"That's not true. Ishizaki-kun has a determined look."

Hiyori says as if to continue, but they all bow their heads in unison.

"What do you mean?"

"It is what it is. I can't answer any more questions."

"...So yes. In any case, it's good that Shiina-san praises you. "

"Oh yeah! I don't know what it is, but I don't feel bad about being praised! "

I guess I couldn't think of anything specific to say. There was no way to say something so cruel, so I listened silently.
Later, at seven in the morning, it was announced that the first designated zone was H10. Hiyori and her friends seemed to be in a different designated zone than J9, so it seemed like we weren't going to compete with each other. I appreciate it, because it is not good to compete with other students in the same course.

"That's all for now, Ayanokouji. See you later."

“Ah. There are only a few days left, so don't lose your temper. "

Ishizaki offered me his fist, which I accepted, and then we started going our separate ways. After a short walk, I thought I heard a voice behind me. I turned around and saw Ishizaki and Hiyori waving at me. I waved goodbye to them and headed for H10.
I spared no effort to repeat the GPS search every hour this day, but there were no signs of any change in the movements of the freshmen.
The information Nanase had risked so much to tell me about the trick of the 12th was empty. Either Amasawa, who knew of Nanase's betrayal, pointed out the information leak. Or the plan was going to go ahead today but was postponed or canceled due to some accident.
In any case, I can't let my guard down tomorrow, the 13th and last day. The third and fourth designated zones of the day had to pass twice due to random zones.
I didn't lose much ground in the rankings, but the searches took a toll on me and I dropped to 16th place.
Tomorrow, I have to step on the designated area at all costs.

Chapter 5: Each And Everyone’s Opinion

Intro

The timeline goes back to the ninth day of the uninhabited island trial, the day after Nanase left Ayanokouji.
Although he was in a group of three, Housen, who had been alone since day one, was still lying in his tent when the designated zone was announced at 7 a.m. Shortly after 8 a.m., a shadow approached Housen and called out to him.

"Good morning, Housen-kun."

"Oh?"

"It's me, Nanase."

“I know from your voice. What are you doing here?"

"What do you mean? We are a group and it is not unnatural for us to make contact."

It was a serious answer, but Housen laughed when he heard it.

“I don't know if you can say that. You seem to have had a lot of fun with Ayanokouji, how have you been? "

"There is no .....I was no match for him."

"Ha, you didn't even use your woman's weapon to challenge him head on, did you?"

"A woman's weapon.....?"

"I do not know what you're talking about",

Housen continued in disgust.

"You have big breasts, but you don't have any brain.

"Well, I really don't understand the relationship between the size of my breasts and my head."
"It's enough. And that? Did you come here just to make that report? "

Pulling out his tablet, Housen didn't hesitate to run a GPS search. Not knowing who Nanase was following, he decided that he should keep an eye on the surroundings. However, there were no shadows of the people Housen had marked in the vicinity.

“It was a mistake for me to try to expel Ayanokouji-kun by myself. So I have come to ask for Housen-kun's help. If you have a plan, let me hear it. "

Housen does not easily trust Nanase, who has been acting on his own and now wants to join him. Not sure what to do.

"Leave it, I'll do it myself."

"..... I'll wait until you change your mind."

“Go to the designated area, for God's sake. The only thing you can do is avoid a penalty. "

He tried to get rid of her, but Nanase showed no signs of leaving.
Housen ignored her and closed his eyes, trying to get over it. About ten minutes later, Nanase calls him again.

"Housen-kun."

"Still no luck, huh? Why are we wasting time?"

"It seems we have a visitor."

When Housen opened his eyes, he saw that there was another silhouette besides Nanase.

"Oh, it's me, Housen-kun ....."

“Who are you? I don't know you."

He intimidatingly told the person who approached him without giving his name.

"Huh, ... from class C. I'm Katagiri."

"I do not know you."

"I'll talk to him for you. What happens?"

"I have brought something that I have to give to Housen-kun."

"Do you have to give him something? What is it?"

"Well, they told me to just tell Housen-kun. ..... "

Housen, who was listening without interest, left the tent to see what was happening. And when he stood up, the giant looked down at little Katagiri.

"I'll punch you in the face if you bore me."

"...East!”

He closed his eyes and trembled, and handed the walkie-talkie into his hand.

"It looks like a walkie-talkie."

"Here, take this. You can talk to Utomiya-kun."

Katagiri speaks, a little scared by Housen.

"Hah. You want to contact me through a little boy."

He picked up the walkie-talkie with annoyance.

"What the hell are you doing contacting me? Do you want us to play? Utomiya..." Housen says but without any response.Meanwhile, Housen operates the tablet to check Utomiya's location on the map.

"I don't know if you are not aware of it or if you are ignoring it, but this is your first and last chance, okay?"

A reaction appears on the other side.

“..... I didn't want to contact you. But I can't help but do it to carry out my plan. "

"Plan?" What the hell are you talking about?"

"Have you forgotten the sixth day?"

"If you mentioned something about talking in secret, I think I forgot."

Looking sideways, Housen listened to the walkie-talkie without turning away.

"I took that fact into account"

"I see. And?"

"We should have a strategy to rescue the freshmen (1st year) soon."

"Will you save the first years?"

After answering like this, Housen interrupts Utomiya's voice.
In a hurry, Nanase takes the tablet out of her backpack and displays the last 10 groups.
Currently, a total of four groups of freshmen are at risk of dropping out of school.

"We also have two first-year D class groups." Says Nanase.

"Ha, I don't care if those garbages disappear. Don't tell me that this guy thinks I'm going to make a move to save my classmates?

"Be on your guard. I'm afraid they are up to something."

"Shut up."

Housen turns the transmission back on, knowing full well that this is so.

"I don't know what you're talking about, but what does it have to do with me?"

Nanase only feels firsthand that some kind of negotiation has already started. She listens quietly, but her location is obvious from the GPS search. They have certainly done some research on the Housen area before speaking.
I have the impression that the other party did not dare to mention it either.

"It's ..... because we need you to save us."

Due to the walkie-talkie, we cannot see Utomiya's expression. But Housen senses that there is a hidden part in him that does not mean it. Housen is not foolish enough not to see that.

“Has someone told you? How funny you are."

“If you want to say no, say no. I'm only discussing this to make sense, and I originally thought we could do this without you. "

“Then that's it. I will reject it. "

Housen said so and finished sending a short reply. He waits patiently for an answer, clutching the walkie talkie as if to immediately drop it.

"...Housen".

Utomiya calls out Housen's name in frustration. But Housen's answer to that is silence.

"I'm not going to get any help from you, am I?"

Due to Utomiya's personality, it is likely that he will be cornered once Housen refuses. Housen read that the reason he didn't do it was because someone else was involved in the plan.

"Wait a minute. No one said anything about not cooperating. "

“What the hell is .....?"

On the other end of the walkie-talkie, Utomiya was a bit nervous. It is seen that he was prepared for the fact that his call was no longer received.

"If you come here and beg me on your knees, I'll give you a hand, okay?"

" Do not be silly. Who is going to bow down to you? "

“Then we don't have to talk about it. Do you think it's OK? Tsubaki "

Housen tells Tsubaki, who is probably listening to the conversation on the other side of Utomiya.

“You realized? Or did you do a GPS search? "

“I didn't spend a point on something so obvious. I've always known that you are a stinky bitch. "

It was a lie. Housen had realized that Utomiya and Tsubaki were in the same place thanks to the GPS search he had just used, so he told her as if it were his own intuition.

"I guess, after all, I can't leave it to Utomiya-kun."

Housen laughs a little when hearing the exchange between Utomiya and Tsubaki.

"Are you saying you don't trust Utomiya?"

"No, only with Housen-kun. It is a known fact that the two of you are on bad terms, and I am not willing to let the negotiations break out of unnecessary emotion."

"So, what about the rescue of the first years?"

“You already know that, right? Four of the last ten groups are freshmen. Also, the second group is first-year D class. If the special exams end like this, the damage done to us freshmen and to Housen-kun's class will be great. "

For the person in charge of the 1st year D class, this is a situation that should be very serious. It would be strange if they weren't in a rush to do something about it. However, Housen not only didn't flinch, he didn't even care

"Well, aren't you trying to rescue all the first years that are in the lower rank?"

“One thing before answering. You're sure Nanase is on our side, right? "

Tsubaki comes into contact with Nanase's existence for the first time here. She was trying to gather information from a lot of bad language and silence.

"Just so you know in a class D full of garbage, I am someone who could be useful."

"Yes. So don't worry, but it's the right thing to do. I'm going to bail out the last four current groups, as well as all the groups that are about to sink into the last five. ”

“You talk a lot, but can you do it? You haven't even done anything noteworthy up to this point. If my valuable time is taken from me for no reason, I will not tolerate it."

"You seem to take your time, although it is precious time."

Tsubaki's words indicate that he had been monitoring Housen with the GPS from the beginning.

“Just for fun, do I send errand boy ‘Katagiri’ back half dead? "

When his face stiffened, the Katagiri in front of him started to shrink. The slightest change in mood can make most students flinch and scare.

“Don't get carried away, Housen. If you put a hand on Katagiri, you will see it with me."

"Utomiya, don't interrupt me now."

"But...".

They start arguing on the other side and the communication is cut off.

"What are they doing?

"Whoa!"

Housen's smile looked creepy, and Katagiri wanted to run away.

“Damn, you're boring. You should leave."

"But the walkie-talkie ..."

“I'm going to keep this for you, okay?

"But ……”

"Katagiri-kun, nothing's wrong. I think you should leave this place to Housen-kun.”

Nanase intervenes and convinces him to do so. While he send a look, he didn't knew what will happen if it doesn't work out. Housen's eyes looking at him from behind crushed Katagiri's heart. He was about to fall on the road, but he ran away.

"Moron."

- "That was a bit insistent."

"That's how I do it. Now you know".

After that exchange between the two, a reply comes from Tsubaki.

"I'm sorry I made you wait .. Can we resume our discussion?"

"That's fine, but that Katagiri put down his walkie talkie and left."

"You threatened him, right?"

Tsubaki answers briefly, without needing to guess.

“It is difficult to be weak in a fight, because it is resolved before it begins. The same thing happens to you, you know? Tsubaki. "

“'It's true that I can't win a fight if I go face to face. But not here."

"Here?"

"The head, the brain."

This was not a joke, but a serious response, and Housen laughs inadvertently.

"Ha …… if you really are more pissed off than me, it would be a big problem."

“There is a way to forcibly rescue groups from their situation. To do this, you will need as many helpers as possible. Since it seems that those above are already using the same strategy, and we also need the help of the first year D-class. ”

That's why Tsubaki asks Housen for help, since he has done what he has wanted until now.

"I would love to help, but I have things to do. I'm very busy."

Tsubaki and the others knew that Housen's time was running out since he hadn't moved even after lifting the designated area, but they dared to tell him to see his reaction.

"Busy is ..... you are trying to expel Ayanokouji-senpai?

"That's what I mean. I don't care if the trash from my class disappears "

“But how do you plan to expel him? Even on the morning of the eighth day, Ayanokouji-senpai continues to work alone. And yet it is not in the last 10 groups. The only conditions for being expelled from school are, according to the regulations, the only two options for this special exam: withdraw with the group or sink to the bottom of the score. "

And the situation where the lowest rank for the score cannot be clearly expected.

“There have been some students who have withdrawn so far this week, but so far there has been no group elimination, so it will be a difficult scenario for the rest of the week, and there could be an elimination of group somewhere.”

“It’s true. Some of them are already running out of food. "

Utomiya's voice also entered, who is next to Tsubaki. Utomiya and the others have already helped a group of first-year students in need of food several times.

“If the first five groups are defeated, it will be practically impossible to get Ayanokouji-senpai out of the school, right? You may think that rescuing the first years will also help Ayanokouji-senpai get expelled, right? "

Only here does Housen's smile fade and he begins to contain something serious.

"So saving the first years. Well, that doesn't sound so bad. ..... Let's hear how you do it."

“As I said before, we are going to stay together as one in our grade, like all the other students in the upper grades. We will absorb the sinking groups to the bottom and pick up where we left off with the groups we can afford. If need be, I could even use my hands to take homework from the group of sophomores and juniors sinking below. "

“If it were so easy to assemble, we wouldn't have any problem, right? We have Class A and Class B. I don't think they will help Class D and Class C. "

“I don't think we should worry about that. We have already decided to cooperate with each other. I'm just waiting for Housen's approval”

She says she's fit to move if freshman D class agrees to join.

“It is not a bad idea, but there is no guarantee that you will win with it. After all, even if you use the same strategy, the scenario will be the same. The difference in experience, the result of losing the freshmen is unshakable. "

While he seemed to listen to the conversation on the sidelines, Housen developed Tsubaki's plan in his mind. And although the probability of a first-year bailout increases, it can be concluded that the handicap cannot be eliminated.

"So is. At this rate, we may not be able to reduce the first year's sacrifice to zero. ”

"That's not what you were saying. Didn't you think we were going to get all the first years out?"

“If all grades use the same strategy, freshmen will be at a disadvantage. That's what Housen-kun read. So why don't we withdraw some groups before the end of the last day? "

This is where Tsubaki's true nature and her goals come to light.

"There are still a couple of people in the upper class who are working alone, so we have to sink them."

"'I see, if five individual groups fall, surely we can save the whole year."

“I thought that the moment to make a move was when everyone started to get tired. We originally planned to do it between the eighth and the tenth day of the second half of the test, but something happened that we did not expect. ”

The fact that Housen didn't show up on the sixth day. The fact that almost the entire seventh day was destroyed by bad weather and he had to regain his strength. That thought immediately crossed Housen's mind

"And good? Be specific about what you want me to do for you. "

“The organizers of this test have made a proposal. They said they wouldn't mind bringing you down with an act of violence. Housen-kun, you are planning to forcibly defeat Ayanokouji-senpai, right? "

"Well, it's the only way."

That's what Housen replied, but his true intentions were different. He can find other strategies, but when it comes to crushing Ayanokouji, he decides to do it directly with his own hands.

"But it is difficult to keep Ayanokoji-senpai, who is always on the move in a solitary way. Until now, Housen-kun has not been able to fulfill that opportunity. But it is different if there is a wide siege network. Tsubaki mentioned that she would take on that role.

“I have been investigating how many of the first-year students, including Utomiya and Housen, trust their ability to fight or use violence and have no resistance. If you surround him well, you can block his escape routes. "

"Do you want me to help you prepare the place?"

"Yes."

"Would they cross such a dangerous bridge? I don't think they work for free, much less Utomiya"

"Of course. People who cooperate agree to do so for 500,000 points as a reward for success. I think it is a necessary expense to reduce Housen-kun's participation. "

A proposal to share the private points obtained by expelling Ayanokouji from the school.

"Wait, Tsubaki, Violence is forbidden as a general rule, would you act accordingly just to pay them 500,000? "

It seems that this is the first time that Utomiya has learned the details of the mission. That voice came from the other side of the walkie-talkie. There, Housen realized that Tsubaki was intentionally leaking something that Utomiya didn't know. Normally, the walkie-talkie can send voice to the other person only when the button is pressed. If Utomiya talks about something inconvenient, release the button. Indirectly conveys that it is confidential

“Of course, you can't ask me to do this the first day. The second half of the test has been tough, both physically and mentally. Student stress is considerable. We are all in a state of conflict between our desire to be comfortable and our desire to be radical. Of course, I think they feel a strong resistance to taking the first blow. That is why I want to leave the leadership to you, Housen-kun. "

Tsubaki calmly analyzes the situation and says that it is easy to notice.

“There are many people who want to ignore a red light in front of them. However, it is difficult to take the first step when there are other people's eyes. But if a person starts to cross, the situation changes. "

Tsubaki says she wants to leave that role to Housen.

"Well, I don't like how they do it, but schools aren't stupid."

“At that moment, it is either fight or lose both. I will take responsibility for expelling him as the brain that gave instructions to the first graders... "

"Ah?"

"I don't regret this school. So I feel like I can quit right away. I've made sure all the guys in my group have private points and half-price cards..."

Tsubaki replies that it's okay if the fault lies with the group, not just Tsubaki, who was the one who came up with the plan.

“People who can self-destruct are scary. I have changed my mind. "

Housen dedicates a few words of admiration to Tsubaki, who has come with a powerful weapon.

"I hadn't told Utomiya, but are you against the plan?"

“..... No. Rather, I thought that making bad plays was pointless... I have been observing Ayanokouji in my own way, and it is not just a coincidence that he has been the subject of 20 million. I think it's because it's clearly a rarity that he was the goal. Even if you try to catch him within the rules, he will surely evade you. I have no right to stop you if you are willing to. "

Utomiya was not opposed to violence, but was concerned about the lack of expectations. If Tsubaki took full responsibility, the situation would be different. If Housen, Utomiya and the others were just the ones used, the story would be different. The school is unlikely to have dozens of expulsions, although they can be sanctioned in some way.

“I'm sure it's difficult to get Ayanokouji-senpai to drop out of school suddenly. I think that is why it was prepared on this uninhabited island, where the eyes of surveillance do not reach, as a setting. "

"I see. So it is not a coincidence. "

Housen closed the map screen on his tablet once and switched to recording mode.

"Do you mean that only you came up with the plan to violently withdraw Ayanokouji? Tsubaki. "

"That is a question?"

"If we follow you, no one will be expelled from our first year. Can you guarantee it?"

“I promise. And if something happens, I'll take the blame. "

When he hears this, Housen is satisfied and ends the recording.

"Did you take the recording correctly? Is it not safe to have my testimony?"

Housen smirks at Tsubaki's words, who sees right through him.

“And that? When are you going to do it?

“I can't tell you yet. I cannot easily divulge that information. "

"Can't you trust me? I appreciate your secrecy, but I won't be able to help you."

"That's what walkie-talkies are for."

The walkie-talkie that was taken from Katagiri was prepared for Housen from the beginning. The result does not change even if it was stolen.

"That's what I mean."

"I'll get in touch when the time comes, thank you."

With that, Tsubaki ends the communication.

"Sounds like a woman who can't eat." Laughing, Housen put the walkie-talkie in his pocket.

"What will we do?"

“I'm not sure what to think, but I'm sure there's nothing wrong with following Tsubaki's strategy. In any case, she intended to crush Ayanokouji even if he was alone. "

This would require repeated GPS searches. He decided that if Tsubaki was going to provide him with all these things, it would be in her best interest to do so.

“We can do whatever we want, and the blame falls entirely on Tsubaki, the ringleader. It's too good to be true. "

“On the other hand, doesn't it seem suspicious that she sacrifices..... ?”

"Well, it's welcome. Anyway, that's it."

"..... I'm willing to help"

"Ah?"

"Because I want to protect the first year D-class group too. Please let me be by your side until I get more information from Tsubaki-san.”

In response to Nanasese's offer, Housen simply replied: "Do whatever you want."

Part 1

And the time shifts to day 13 of the special exam, at 6:51 in the morning, now in progress.
Utomiya finds Tsubaki looking up at the sky near the store.

"What are you thinking? Tsubaki"

“'I was doing a final review in my head. What do you want?"

" No, I just wanted to talk to you before the operation took place. It may be the last conversation with Tsubaki so far. "

This could be the last conversation they have between them, so they relay their thoughts.

"Why didn't you use a walkie-talkie to communicate with me?"

“You can't know what they really think if you don't talk to them face to face. You already heard my exchange with Housen so you know exactly what I mean. "

"I guess so. I didn't even know what he was thinking, but I don't trust him at all. "

"You can't trust him because he's Housen-kun, right?"

Utomiya turned his face away, looking unhappy at the fact that she had been pointed out that way.

“Utomiya-kun is the only one I can trust among the first-year students. I wanted to ask you directly about the plan and for you to say what you thought "

After smiling a bit teasingly, Tsubaki became expressionless again. She told Utomiya that it was trustworthy, but remembered that there was something she had to check.

"How's the preparation going?"

"Do you want to see the screenshot I took of one when I ran the GPS search earlier?"

Tsubaki then turns on his tablet and displays the image searched by the GPS. Ayanokouji's camp is on E5; the first years are camped in D4 and E6.

"The arrangement is perfect, just as Tsubaki planned."

“Well, we have carefully prepared up to this point. The land is on our side. "

Tsubaki slowly looked at Utomiya, who was watching the screen intently. A person approaches those two people.

"Tsubaki-san, can we talk?"

It is Yagami, the leader of freshman class B from the same group as Utomiya.

“Everything is ready, so at least we have time to talk. ..... "

Yagami who has a suspicious look, addresses Tsubaki

"I have something I need you to hear."

"Sorry, but wait, there is something I have to talk to Yagami first."

Utomiya stops Yagami, who was about to speak to Tsubaki, with a strong tone.

"What happens?."

"Yesterday you suddenly disappeared, and where were you?"

"Sorry, my watch broke and I had to run back to the starting point"

Then he shows him the watch on his left hand.

"A malfunction? It is the second time."

As if suspecting something, Utomiya raises his guard.

" What do you think you're doing?"

“It is outrageous to be suspected of conspiring just because your watch malfunctions. Utomiya-kun also had a clock failure a few days ago, right? Doesn't that mean that you're also a suspect? "

"In my case it was just a mistake."

" The same happens to me."

Utomiya stares at Yagami, who smiles from start to finish.

“Hey you two, could you please not get in trouble at a time like this? After all, we are friends, right? "

"I'm sorry ..... Maybe I was too nervous before the mission"

"I too have stepped out of line and I apologize."

"Have you spent the day changing the clock? Or if there is another reason, can I hear it?

"I had prepared a gift for Tsubaki-san regarding today's operation."

" A gift?"

"The strategy to hunt down Ayanokouji-senpai hasn't always worked, right?"

Before the execution of the important mission, Yagami says something disturbing. It wasn't Tsubaki who showed a sensitive reaction to it, but Utomiya who was by his side.

"What are you talking about, Yagami? You think this operation will fail ... "

"I am not going to run an operation with the intention of failing."

As if to cover Utomiya's denial, Tsubaki also responded with a slightly stronger tone.

“Of course, Tsubaki's strategy is perfect. It's an alignment that leaves no room for ants to crawl out of bounds. We are challenging with the greatest strength that we can prepare freshmen. So I don't doubt our success. But don't you think it's better to take the preventive measures you can? "

"As for me, I don't want to do anything irregular, but let me tell you something."

Tsubaki muttered in her mind that she could make a decision after hearing whether or not she really accepted Yagami's proposal.

“'From now on, Tsubaki-san is going to corner Ayanokouji-senpai while repeatedly using GPS search to find out his position, but it is inevitable that she will consume a lot of points to do so, right? "

"That's why we have a group of reserve tablets."

Utomiya added, Yagami said calmly that he understood.

“But it is not very favorable that it is efficient. You know why?"

"We do not know where the designated area of Ayanokouji-senpai is, so we cannot predict his movements."

Yagami nodded once, as if satisfied with Tsubaki's answer.

"That's right. If you are able to read through Ayanokouji-senpai's movements if he went to a designated area, if he pursues a task or just escapes, what is the priority and what needs to be blocked, your efficiency will increase drastically. . "

“If it were easy to understand, it wouldn't be difficult. So you have multiple tablets so you can do GPS searches over and over again. "

“In my own way, I spent a lot of time researching to see if there was anything I could do to help. So, among the 12 squares, which squares does Ayanokouji-senpai belong to? "

The hand that played with Tsubaki's hair, which seemed uninteresting, stopped. At the same time, Utomiya's rebuttals stopped.

"You mean you know?"

"Yes, well, technically, it's not me, it's just this 'tablet' that tells me."

Saying this, Yagami extends one of the tablets.

"What is this?"

“I borrowed it from a group of my friends from class B, first year. Because the owner of this table is in the same square as Ayanokouji-senpai. "

"In other words, if you have this, you can find out Ayanokouji-senpai's movements today without any delay."

Yagami nodded slowly. If Ayanokouji's designated zone turns out to be at the same time, it will be easier to get ahead of him.

"How can you be sure that this tablet really is from the same box as Ayanokouji?"

Yagami continued his conversation with Tsubaki, and Utomiya calls him unexpectedly

"I mean, how did you find out ..."

"You say they used repeated GPS searches to identify the box"

Without even thinking about it, Tsubaki found a way to find out.

"... Indeed, was it an unnecessary action"

Yagami, who thought he might surprise Tsubaki a bit, ends up surprising her in the opposite direction

“I would appreciate it if you could lend me that tablet. Considering the points that I am going to consume, I would like to refrain from wasting as much as possible. Do you think it's OK?"

"We are all in this together. Tsubaki's success will lead to my success as well. Also, Utomiya and I have been fighting on behalf of the freshmen, but it has been difficult for us to get into the top three positions. In this situation, we have no choice but to work hard elsewhere. "

The reason he was here today is because it doesn't make much sense of the scores you earn anymore. If you are in a position to contest first place, you cannot afford to meet quietly.
After that, Yagami continues.

"Also if you do not accept this proposal, we will not be able to provide you with insurance."

"Sure? What the hell are you talking about?"

“'Our first priority is to use Tsubaki's strategy to pursue Ayanokouji-senpai and force him to retreat. However, that can end in failure for some reason. For example, if Ayanokouji-senpai works with a third party for the entire day. Because you can't attack someone where there are other people's eyes. "

“We don't have to worry about that; he's been basically on his own since the eighth day. "

Utomiya argues that she has done her research, but Yagami shakes his head.

"But that doesn't mean that he is alone on 13th either."

"Yes it's correct. And that?"

“If something unexpected goes wrong, we switch to the method of letting them pass through the entire designated area to score points. And tomorrow, the last day, the 14th, we have three more movements, and we seal it. "

"In other words, do you mean stepping on the penalty 5 times?"

“No, you can make them step on it up to 7 times. Ayanokouji-senpai's box passed a total of two times yesterday on the day 12, the third area being randomly designated D4 that went far, and then the fourth area designated D2, which they also did not step on. We have already confirmed that we have changed our focus to accept the challenge. "

"Let's say seven times, that's less than 28 points, an exaggerated score."

There are only two days of season left. Losing 28 points in that time is quite a blow. Utomiya realizes the magnitude of the insurance strategy Yagami had in mind.

“Ayanokouji-senpai is still alone right now. We do not know how many points he has, but since he is alone, it will not be many. Also, you can use GPS search on our forays. If we get ahead of that and seal their assignments as well, there is more than enough chance that he will sink into the bottom five groups. ”

"Well, it certainly is."

“If I manage to get Ayanokouji-senpai out with this insurance, what if I get 5 million points and Tsubaki-san and the others get 10 million points as their share? I'm sure you will agree to share the remaining 5 million points with the group that failed. "

"Not a bad idea, don't you think, Tsubaki?"

In contrast to Utomiya, who was really surprised by Yagami's proposal, Tsubaki only gave a silent reply.

"Tsubaki, I think you should have insurance."

He advises Tsubaki again to take Yagami's proposal.

"'Well, if you even have a tablet in the same box, there's no way he won't."

Nevertheless. Choking on his words for the second time, Tsubaki pulls out another tablet.Tsubaki shows her tablet, a spare tablet, and a third.

"What is that tablet?"

"The tablet from Ayanokouji-senpai's box."

" What? When did you..... "

Before Yagami could identify the box Tsubaki already had everything she needed.

"Tsubaki-san you are beyond my imagination. You even came up with this insurance strategy. ..... "

"Then why didn't you say it?"

“I don't like him for a moment. Yagami-kun had also devised the strategy of letting us pass through the designated area. I was going to pretend I didn't know what was going on, but it was so obvious. "

It was a somewhat childish story, Yagami and Utomiya looked at each other once

“If so, I cannot accept the reward, I reject the 5 million points. Then I'll be watching from a distance. "

"'Thanks, it's honestly hard to do it when you're around people you don't trust, so I guess that helps."

Yagami accepted without question the direct statement that he didn't even try to hide. After Yagami kept his distance, Utomiya spoke to him.

“Tsubaki. If we could defeat Ayanokouji by physical means, would they really expel us?"

“It is a method of force, so it cannot be without problems. Assuming the worst, there is also the possibility that only freshmen who have set you up will be expelled. "

"If the group I helped joined, many people would leave."

Utomiya's expression hardens as he imagines expulsion from only the freshman part.

“But the chances of that happening are almost nil. The only person who would have to bear the greatest punishment would be me, the ringleader. The school cannot expel ten or twenty freshmen. "

"That's the problem. Are you really going to take the blame yourself? "

“Originally, when the special test was disclosed. I was the one who suggested that Ayanokouji-senpai be kicked out. You just went along with me, didn't you, Utomiyakun?

“It’s true, but ..... "

Utomiya remembers the special exam for which he was paired with a sophomore earlier in the school year.That special exam was designed to earn 20 million points if Ayanokouji Kiyotaka was expelled from school. At first, Utomiya showed his dislike for this special exam and proposed to sit on the sidelines of the 1st year class C.. However, Tsubaki repeatedly convinced Utomiya and recruited him to the team. She said that the 20 million points would be a huge advantage if the C-class was to aim for a higher class for next year.
When Utomiya asked her what kind of trick she would use to get him expelled, Tsubaki responded immediately. She said that she would pair up with Ayanokouji for the test and that she would deliberately let the test pass and sacrifice herself and the reward of 20 million points would be given to his collaborator Utomiya. She told him that she wanted him to use those points for the future of C-class first-class.

"When you first raised this plan to me, you said you didn't want to dwelve too deeply into it."

"Are you curious? Why do you think he should be expelled. "

“I would be lying if I said I don't care. It's not natural to want to drop out of school as soon as you enter school. "

“I admit that the first year of class C is more comfortable than I thought. So I decided that if I am going to drop out anyway, I will do my best for the class and quit. "

That was all Tsubaki said, but she still didn't want to talk about the situation. Utomiya also changed his attitude, saying that it was against the rules to ask more questions, and turned his gaze towards the forest beyond. "

“Shouldn't he be there after all? I'm sure I can go one-on-one with Ayanokouji and win."

"That's not good. Utomiya-kun is an indispensable member of the first-year C-Class. Also, there is the possibility that I will be judged in the same way when taking responsibility. Leave Ayanokouji-senpai for the other children.”

" That is enough for a normal opponent. But Ayanokouji is a 20 million point opponent, so he is not an ordinary player. As long as Housen made the first move, he could not gain an advantage, he must make the moves he can. "

" That's right. It's better to assume it's Housen-kun's class. "

Even so, Tsubaki did not give Utomiya the go-ahead, but instructed him to stay here.

"..... Very good. I'll stay close and see how you fight. "

"Hey Utomiya-kun"

Tsubaki calls out to Utomiya, who tries to keep her distance so as not to interfere.

"What happens?"

“You seem very strong, where did you learn to fight? You are not a criminal, are you "

"It is not a big thing. You don't need to meddle unnecessarily either. "

- "Yes. But let me ask you something. You're not hiding anything from me, are you? "

"What am I hiding? Nothing. I'm just a guy whose only job is to fight. "

"Nothing happens."

And then at 7:00 in the morning, the test begins. Holding the walkie-talkie in one hand and the tablet in the other, Tsubaki opens her mouth. Ayanokouji's destination that appears on the tablet is the C3.

“Attention all groups, the designated area where the enemy is heading is C3, the group in D4 will stay where it is, and the group in E6 will start heading north and immobilize them. If they find it, no contact until I give the go-ahead ”.

Tsubaki gives instructions and calmly finishes transmitting the walkie-talkie.

"Once Ayanokouji-senpai's elimination is over, Before the school finds out I'm here, I'll defeat some independent 2nd and 3rd grade groups and let's go who I can target."

Tsubaki was in the process of sorting out her final thoughts on who to target.



Part 2

I noticed something unusual when designated area C3 was announced at 7:00 in the morning.
The GPS search, which has been common for the last few days, is done first to find competing rivals on the order of arrival. Among them, I noticed that the three main members of the first grade, "Utomiya", "Tsubaki" and "Yagami" solidified. Utomiya and Yagami are in the same group so it's not surprising, but the fact that there is a camellia is a trap. Also, I can't see the other members of the main group.
Remembering what was heard from Nanase the other day, instinctively. Today is when the first graders are installed. The group of first graders is naturally scattered across the island, but the position has changed significantly since I confirmed it last night. There are quite a few groups in D4 and E6 that surround me.

"On the move, huh?"

It's difficult to avoid a head-on collision if the enemy plans to use GPS search to the limit, even on a large uninhabited island. In case you have a few days, I can be sure that you know that Nanase and I are in the same box, and that you know the designated area to which I should go.
If so, it is necessary to avoid simply going to C3 as it is, but it is a great risk to reach the end of this stage and take a penalty.
Since yesterday, I had passed through the designated area twice in a row. If you don't step on the remaining seven designated areas, how far will the ranking drop ..? I don't know if it was a coincidence or not, but it was the perfect time to do a trick.

"It seems that at least they know how to fight."

They are right about not forcing me to settle in the middle of the night or in the early morning. If I put it in the middle of the night, when visibility is poor, it would be impossible to catch me by many GPS searches I have. On the other hand, if it is early in the morning, it is difficult to know my designated area and make a strategy.
However, it is quite a large number. I had in mind the possibility that a very small number of talented people like Housen would start something, but it is beyond the scale of my expectations.
Housen's location remains the same as last night, on D4. If we go to the designated area, we can coincide.
If I am attacked by freshmen, the school is most likely trying to protect them. Yet at the same time, my existence is established as haunting and strange throughout the school. The goal of having a normal school life can be lost at the same time.
Even many teachers who know nothing about me will change the perception that I am a rare student.
There is a teacher at the task point, so safety is guaranteed, but it is not a wise choice to be followed by many. There is a way to work with the other students, but I must

consider that not only the first-year students, but also the third-year students, who are under Nagumo's control, are the enemy.
The only option now is to flee until the freshmen run out of energy and give up the chase.
Ten minutes later, when the camp were clean and ready to go, I ran the search again and saw the GPS responses from the beleaguered freshmen coming in fast and furious.
Nanase's words, "If they find you, you will become a victim of violence," will come true.
Whoever runs this strategy is not afraid to withdraw; maybe you are a mastermind and fully prepared to take the blame if it happens.
Then you should avoid any involuntary commitment at all costs. Even if that means ignoring a total of six designated areas, including yesterday's.
Surrounded by the river and the mountains, it is tempting to escape across the mountains, but it is not a wise option due to the layout. It is better to go on the south side even if it is a little dangerous.

If I decide to move away from the designated area, the enemy will probably not pursue me too much. I took something out of my backpack and started walking.

Part 3

"How are you Tsubaki-san?"

It's 8 a.m. and if all goes well, it's about the time a group of first-year students get in touch with Ayanokouji.
Yagami, who is concerned that the report has not yet come out of the walkie-talkie, asks.

“'Don't be scared, everything is going according to plan so far. Things are going very well. "

"Good to Know."

Ayanokouji is swerving orderly so as not to get caught by the first grade group who are closing the distance. I don't know how long it will be, but it is clear that I am using GPS search on a regular basis. If you can spit to a point, it's better than that. I intend to commit violence, but I think it would be ideal if I could crush him without doing so.

If you can keep up with the movements, you will find a way to win with no contact.

If they can't stand it and plan to force their way, they can crush him there.
We were in a situation where we could push him, but we didn't, and we did it in a way that made it easier for him to escape.

Tsubaki drops the scores she has accumulated without hesitation and activates the GPS search in 10-minute intervals. She has not been saving her test scores for the past 12 days as of yesterday. To drop all scores right now.
9 a.m. passes and Ayanokouji's third step is confirmed.
The tablet then indicated that Ayanokouji's destination was D2; Ayanokouji, who was fleeing towards C6 at the time, would have a hard time stepping on the designated area, even if he hadn't been disturbed. Two groups continue to move to hunt down Kiyotaka Ayanokouji. Even with updates every 0 minutes, you can see the movement so clearly. If she continued, Ayanokouji could go north on the B4 and C5.

Therefore, she ordered the three remaining groups to meet at C4. Deciding that they could wait and see for a while, Tsubaki stopped the search for an hour and took a break. After 10 p.m., she checks everyone's position to confirm the situation. Ayanokouji was about to go between B4 and C5 as Tsubaki had read. The two groups that were chasing him were also about to enter B5.

"Don't let him go out."

She instructed the group in C4 to target Ayanokouji going down the mountain. The objective was to get ahead of him and lead him towards B4 and B3. From here, Tsubaki checks again every ten minutes to get an idea of the general position. As she had read, Ayanokouji is heading north on the B4 to escape the first-year students who were ahead of him. Seeing this, she sends the three groups north of C4 to hunt him down so he can't escape.

"Can I talk to you, Tsubaki-san?

"..... what?"

In the distance, Yagami, who is also handling a tablet, looks back.

“'Wouldn't it be possible to corner Ayakoji-senpai with more detailed instructions? It seems like a bit of a tedious progression. "

"It's so depressing." Tsubaki decideded to ignore it, saying it in a whisper that Yagami couldn't hear.

After another 30 minutes or so, the problems appeared. Because the three groups that ordered to advance north from C4 had barely moved.
If there were some kind of displacement problem, why would three groups stop?
Now she updates the GPS position in 5 minutes, which is even shorter than 10 minutes.

"I knew it didn't work ....."

Ayanokouji tries to get out of B3, but 3 groups haven't got out of C4. If nothing is done, there is a risk of him escaping to C3.

"What's happening? What's going on?"

She called on her walkie-talkie, but there was no answer.

"How weird."

Tsubaki senses that this is not a simple accident within the group.

"What's wrong, Tsubaki-san?

Yagami, who saw a shadow in her facial expression, looked into the tablet without realizing it.

"What happened?"

"Three of the five first-year groups we sent have stopped moving. The three groups that stopped moving had one thing in common: they were all in the same position crossing paths with the sophomores. "

In a test on an uninhabited island with more than 400 people, it is not uncommon for several groups to pass. That's why Tsubaki hadn't paid attention to them until now.

"Reply".

Tsubaki called again with her walkie-talkie, but got no answer no matter how long she waited.

"Is it not possible that it is an accidental problem? On this uninhabited island, many groups are constantly on the move in search of designated areas and tasks, and I think it

would be dangerous to assume otherwise. "

- "Even if that's true...there are three groups blocked for second years?

"It's true, but ....."

For another 5 minutes, Tsubaki, who held on while suppressing her anger, updates the GPS.

"They are starting to move, but they seem pretty slow.

"There is a group of second year students who stayed."

Meanwhile, Ayanokouji had left B4, down to B3, and was about to head to C3. When this happens, she had no choice but to leave it to the two groups that are following him. The two groups that were chasing Ayanokoji also stopped moving when they realized it. And likewise, a group of sophomores is stagnant. And besides, a group of second graders stay around there.

"It certainly seems like a second year student is sabotaging them, but if it is ..... who ... will it be."

Yagami took the liberty of touching the tablet and trying to check the details.

- "Hey, get out of my way."

"What?"

"I allow you to be here because you are one of us, but I don't remember allowing you to take it without permission."

Yagami takes a step back, while looking into her eyes full of intensity. .....

"I get it. But I would like to give my opinion. Shouldn't we check who the second-year students are obstructing us? "

"I already know it".

Tsubaki, who intended to confirm it without being told, starts the operation. Second year students who appear to be interfering.
However, there are no students of mixed interest in the five groups.

"It seems that the person who is leading the second year students is not participating"

"And there is a great variety of students from class A to D, there is no perceptible trait."

"So you are saying that it is not just one particular class, but the entire second year that is doing the movement?

"So you're saying that it's not just one particular class that is doing this, but the entire second-year class?"

It was as Yagami had said, but Tsubaki felt stuck. Why didn't she think that all the classes would unite to protect Ayanokouji.

"..... so to speak."

An answer that arises from the situation.

"These five groups do not understand why they have been ordered to stop us."

"Do you think they are cooperating without being informed?"

“It could be for any reason, I suppose; Perhaps this is a light assignment in which they were asked to interfere with the movements and tasks of the freshmen to protect a sophomore? "

“Take a look at today's GPS search logs. Swipe the screen to track where the sophomores were. He's too good at what he does. We can only assume that he knew all along that we were going to attack him today.

"There are only two days left until the exam is finished. It's not strange that the other party is very attentive. I'm sure you know that there is a bounty on your head, so they have probably been preparing the ground beforehand."

Yagami says it's not surprising because the closer the exam ends date, the more they get on their guard.

"We just have to spend time attacking now, but second-year students can't protect Ayanokouji-senpai all the time, right? There are special tests."

With two days to go, it is time to score as many points as possible.

"That is sure ....."

"The other thing that worries me is that this group here is being easily mocked. Although they move separately, it is not easy to capture the five groups."

Yagami couldn't respond to that concern, so he puts his hand on his mouth and thought about it.

"Don't you know why? That shows that there is a hidden commander there. "

"Do you think someone like Tsubaki, who is in charge, is hiding behind all this?" Tsubaki nods and unfolds a map of the entire island.

Somewhere in this GPS answer there is a person who is viewing the battlefield the same way she is.

He is giving the proper instructions and kept the freshmen group at bay

"I think we should consider suspending the operation."

"Why?"

"Are you trying to force yourself to continue with this? It is dangerous."

“No, I won't. The five groups of students I'm capturing right now can't do that. "

"Then, why don't you suspend them?"

"Because it's the same anyway

"Is the same .....?"

This situation was something Tsubaki had foreseen from the beginning. In fact, she was even grateful that a group had appeared to interfere.

"I don't know who is directing everything, but I am here to show you that visual information is not everything."

What the hell are you doing?

"Perhaps your commander has noticed the five first-year groups we moved last night."

"I see. So you've been doing nightly searches without fail. "

"As I said before, there is a second-year exam for second-year students. As we have five groups, they will try to have five groups as well and they will try to take advantage, and if they had six or seven groups, they would be neglecting the exam . "

"But they may have one or two more groups just in case, right?"

"Can be. But from what I can see now, there are only five groups of sophomores who showed irregular movements. Maybe they are confident enough to decide that they can deal with the same number? But that's what kills them. "

Tsubaki picked up the walkie-talkie and sent out new instructions.

“Now there is no one who can interfere. Now you can do whatever you want ”.

"What do you want to come up with? There are no longer any groups in the vicinity that can move. ..... "

"I told you. I told you that the information you see is not all there is. "

After giving the instructions, Tsubaki thinks about who is involved in this war.

“Ayanokouji is running away? No, that's not possible. I don't have the full strength to be able to manipulate and direct the other classes, I can't afford that now. "

A murmur that was really just the movement of her mouth, inaudible even to Yagami who was next to him.
When Tsubaki thinks, she tends to reason with words to the point that her surroundings

cannot hear her. No matter how low the sound is, speaking out loud clears the mind. If I had to use an analogy, it would be to take clothes out of a messy closet one at a time and put them back in, to put them in order.

“Presumably, Ayanokouji contacted the people involved in this situation and asked for their help. So he could have prepared for this moment from the beginning ... "

"What, did you say something?"

"It's nothing, don't worry."

I'm not sure if it's because she was whispering back and forth, but I think the words reached Yagami's ears as well. Tsubaki replied a bit dejected, and looked at the tablet again.

Part 4

Gazing at the dazzling diamond-shining sea, Sakayanagi took a sip of water. Not so much to hydrate, but rather to bring moisture back her lips.
It was 7:05 in the morning. Just when Tsubaki was starting to put his plan into action.

"It seems they are on the move."

Staring at her tablet, Sakayanagi launches the instructions with her walkie-talkie in hand. Sakayanagi continued to apply the GPS search on the night of the 10th, the night of the 11th and the night of the 12th, and the three days in the middle of the night. To surround Ayanokouji, it was necessary to work outside of exam hours.

"It seems that the waiting time is over, so let's get started."

"That is fine, but there is no guarantee that we will meet just because we have moved to the same area, right?"

An indifferent voice comes out of the walkie-talkie again. It belongs to Tsukasaki in the same class as Sakayanagi. He explained that he would interfere with the first graders and finish today's assignment, and send them there.

"In the last 12 days, the interior of the uninhabited island has undergone a gradual change in terrain. Do you know what that is?”

“Change of terrain? .... In summary, is it what happens after a lot of people move?

"So is. Students and teachers commute around the uninhabited island on a daily basis. In fact, don't you think Tsukasaki-kun uses it naturally to choose a safe and fast route? "

Although the changes are slight, there are many roads that clearly show signs of having been used by people because of the rain.

"Above all, it is not difficult to guess the route if you know where you are going."

"I know you are not looking directly at it, but it is as if you can see the road."

Although it is only on a tablet, Sakayanagi can see the uninhabited island in three dimensions. She has a realistic simulation in his mind of who they are and what they are like. And beyond that, it goes and captures the shadow of the person who is painting this whole picture.
Sakayanagi then spent a while looking at the sea, and after half an hour, she looked at her tablet again.

"Well, there are very few people who do not move at all during this time in which they try to get to their assigned areas and tasks ..."

And from there, if we cut the grade down to just freshmen, we can cut it down to its lowest point in an instant. And on the third, we find a GPS signature that hasn't moved since the test started at 7:00.

"Takuya Yagami-kun? Riku Utomiya-kun? and Sakurako Tsubaki-san? I wonder who my adversary is. Or is it the three of them? "

She laughed and narrowed her eyes with joy. Sakayanagi began to think about the person who had brought her this interesting fight.

That was three days ago. Returning at midnight on the 10th day of the special exam. Takemoto's group, who had a walkie-talkie with Sakayanagi, contacted her.

“What happened at this time? Are you in trouble? "

Sakayanagi thought it was some kind of accident, but it seems like it isn't.

“No, is not that. Actually, Ayanokouji wants to talk to you. "

"Ayanokouji-kun?"

The unexpected name cleared the consciousness of Sakayanagi, who had numbed a bit.

"I am in debt, I would appreciate it if you would let him talk to you."

"Of course...of course. Please take charge. "

"Wait a minute."

After a time of silence...

"Sakayanagi".

"Good night, Ayanokouji-kun".

Sakayanagi begins with an elegant greeting that makes it hard to believe she's in the middle of an exam on an uninhabited island.

"It seems that the classes are working well together."

"Yes. I was able to contact Ryuuen-kun and Horikita-san. We are progressing smoothly. I haven't heard the details, but it seems that Takemoto-kun and the others were taken care of. "

"Your group is also making great strides, now you are in fifth place. You are in a position where you can aim high enough."

"Not that there are no worries at all."

"Is that so?"

"Have you seen Ichinose-san?"

“No, I have not seen her even once during this exam. What happened?"

“I got a call saying she was acting a little strange. She has been lost for several days and I am worried ... "

It is a long special exam it would not be unusual to get sick or depressed.

"So, what do you want from me?"

"There is one thing I want to ask you Sakayanagi."

"Please, do not hesitate to ask me. I will pay you back for saving my classmates."

"About the White Room."

"It also sounds like a very interesting story"

Ayanokouji explains that Nanase was one of the assassins sent by Tsukishiro, since Sakayanagi knows the story of the Acting Director. However, other than that, there are White Room students lurking. He explains that it is most likely Ichika Amasawa

"It would have been better if you had told me before."

Sakayanagi felt disappointed, as if she had missed an opportunity to have fun.

"Because none of it was safe."

"So you want me to destroy that person named Amasawa Ichika?"

“Huh?..”

Ayanokouji feels puzzled by Sakayanagi, for saying surprising things

"Actually there is one more thing, I have another big problem."

Ayanokouji reveals to Sakayanagi about the main topic, Miyabi Nagumo's reward for Tsukishiro. Sakayanagi is the only one of the second-year students who has known Ayanokouji since childhood, and she is the only one who knows him thoroughly.
But the reason they have talked about this kind of thing before is largely because it is a problem that Ayanokouji has naturally, and because he did not have Sakayanagi as an "ally".
Originally, in this school, when you are in a different class, the scheme of being enemies will not change until you graduate.

To win, there is a chance for Sakayanagi to use the White Room part.
However, she knew that the risk was not that high since he was in contact with her. And this time, as a result of putting that lower risk and the new risk on the balance sheet, there may be a sudden change in which you can benefit.

"I mean, in the near future, the first-year students will take action against Ayanokouji-kun, right?"

"That's what I mean. I want to ask Sakayanagi to take care of it. "

"But if it's the same White Room student, I don't think it's possible for someone else to chase Ayanokouji-kun."

"The first years will probably try to force their entry. The most effective way to get rid of me is to exploit the fact that I am in a group completely alone. If they are in a position to do so, they will be able to block by force the assignment and, if they want to go further, obstruct movement to the designated area. "

Regardless of the number of people who come, Sakayanagi thinks that it will not be difficult for Ayanokouji to get rid of them if he adopts a forceful method. But that's not exactly the way he likes to handle things.

“If it's an opponent that the first years couldn't defeat with all their might, Ayanokouji-kun's name would spread throughout the school immediately. As for me ... whether I should be happy or sad is a complicated matter. "

“I'm sure you would be glad to hear it. Besides, Tsukishiro may be planning something .. If possible, I want to focus on that. "

"I understand the situation very well

"It is inevitable that Sakayanagi's workload will increase.

"I get it. If you want to keep a constant watch, you inevitably run the risk of having to use a GPS search on a frequent basis. "

Inevitably, there will be a point where you have to trust Sakayanagi's side.

"Don't worry. We already know all the scores for the group to which Class A belongs."

"So ... you've had very close contact with them."

“It is very important to know which groups have problems and which groups have plenty of space. There are a number of groups that have some room for growth, but not enough to make it to the top 10. So even if you use GPS search a few times per group, you can still get to the last day in plenty of time. "

It was a strategy that could only be accomplished by joining forces with Sakayanagi's class A, who had perfect control, and Ichinose's C-class, who would never betray her. The cost of insuring a walkie-talkie was not a silly thing to do.

"All I have to do is stop the first years who are heading to Ayanokouji-kun, right?"

"Are you sure you can help me?

"It would have been a bit boring exam just to help you complete the task, and besides, this story seems like something that could benefit me."

"What do you mean?"

"It means that it is too big a commission for me to pay Takemoto-kun's debt .. In other words, it will be a new" favor ", right?"

"I know it hurts to hear this, but if you get rid of them, I'll owe you a" favor "

"It's decided. Well, then I'll get to work on my preparations."

"Oh, and if you don't mind, can I keep this walkie talkie as a loan?"

“Of course I was going to do it anyway. It's easier to get things done if we can get in touch. Then, could you return the walkie-talkie to Takemoto-kun? I will tell the situation and tell him to give it to Ayanokouji-kun "

Sakayanagi remembers such a night on the tenth day, and smiles like a wonderful memory.
On the tablet, the five groups that Sakayanagi had sent towards the freshmen are in detention.

“Well, now we have arrested the five suspicious groups. Are we trying to identify the person who planned this attack? "

With a walkie-talkie in hand, Sakayanagi contacts the students in Class A.

Part 5

"Hey, Tsubaki ..."

"Anything else?"

“I don't know what kind of movements you have left, but I think you should have given detailed instructions to the five groups in case something like this happened; It wouldn't have been too difficult to get the five groups out of the way before the sophomores surrounded them, right? ”

There were a total of five groups of freshmen sent to the island, and even if someone had marked all five, it would not have been easy to catch them on the large uninhabited island.

Yagami said that it was a strategic mistake that the five groups were caught so easily.

“Even if you force yourself to flee, you can always make up an excuse later, like you got scared because you got tangled up with the grown-ups. If you had consulted me before "

"So, you say this happened because I was negligent?"

"If you want to be tough, that's what I would say."

Looking at the disgusted Yagami, Tsubaki responds.

"But now that it's over, I'll tell you ..... it's actually the other way around."

"Upside down?"

"It is not that my group has been caught, it is that I have caught the other group."

" Well I'm ... sorry, I'm a little out of my league here. "

“The five groups sent to expel Ayanokouji-senpai. Even if you can hunt him down to a position where you can see him, if there is a big difference in his physical abilities, he will be able to escape, right? Rumor has it that he has the ability similar to Housen-kun's. It means that he didn't want to face the current group from the beginning.
As Tsubaki speaks, Yagami bows his head.

“If you put it like this, it's like saying that the five groups that we sent from the beginning will not be able to beat Ayanokouji. This strategy doesn't make sense. "

“The first is to find out what Ayanokouji-senpai is thinking. What do you like and what don't you like? "

She hit the tablet with her index finger and explained.

“He disliked contact with the early years more than going to his assigned area. He also avoided homework with the teachers and the second and third graders. What I get clear is that he has an extreme aversion to highlighting, and is willing to take a penalty to avoid it.

"Even if it's to learn about behavior patterns, it doesn't mean that you have to catch the group."

“There is a more important meaning. Because this is how we caught the group that was trying to protect Ayanokouji-senpai. "

Hearing those words, Yagami exclaims.

“The only thing we should avoid is getting in the way of our efforts to eliminate Ayanokouji-senpai. And the only person capable of eliminating Ayanokouji-Senpai, apart from Utomiya-kun, is Housen-kun ... "

Finally understanding Tsubaki's goal, Yagami tries to find Housen via GPS.

However, there is no trace of him anywhere.

“What you see is not everything ..... Is that what you mean?"

After finishing her explanation, Tsubaki once again dispels any unnecessary distractions.

“Let me ask you one last question. If Housen-kun had not accepted this case, do you think this operation would not have been possible? "

“Hmm, not exactly. It is correct to say that we decided to carry out this operation because we were absolutely sure that Housen-kun would come on board. It seems that he was always willing to fight alone. Still, if they didn't accept the case, I would just let Utomiya-kun go. Either way, I made sure the atmosphere was perfect for one-on-one. Now it only remains for the two to face each other, win or lose, and everything will be fine."

Ayanokouji, acting alone, has no choice but to withdraw.

Part 6

A man with a great body, especially among the students, ran vigorously through the forest. With only one goal: defeat Ayanokouji Kiyotaka, 2nd year D class.

Violence is not recommended in this uninhabited island test, not even in common sense. However, unlike the school, which is surrounded by surveillance cameras, this desert island has no surveillance. It is impossible to verify a specific fact with just one watch.
The Siege of Ayanokouji was conceived by Sakurako Tsubaki.
He was never interested in such things, but there was a reason he followed the plan.
It is not easy to find a single person on a huge uninhabited island. It would take repeated GPS searches to achieve this, and if someone got in the way, they would be dead in the water.
Having one person in charge will help eliminate those distractions. Due to this thought, Housen decided to pretend to follow Tsubaki's instructions.
Find Ayanokouji without any effort, and finish him off one by one without anyone

getting in the way.
When the distance to Ayanokouji was almost within reach, Housen dropped the walkie-talkie.
This is a sign that he will not follow Tsubaki from now on. He takes out his own tablet and performs a GPS search to do the final fill. He checks on the GPS Ayanokouji Kiyotaka in front of him, about 300 meters away. He's closer than any of the other rookies. Just a few more minutes.
Housen was already chewing on the joy of being able to participate in a serious fist fight.
But... As if to block Housen's route, a single response from the GPS blocked his view.
Thinking it was a mere coincidence, Housen didn't even try to see who it belonged to.
He managed to catch Ayanokouji out of the corner of his eye.

"I found you, Ayanokouji-senpai!"

Ayanokouji noticed that Housen was screaming excitedly and turned around.

"Housen."

Ayanokouji calmly looked at Housen and stopped walking.

"I've been waiting for this moment!"

“I thought you would come to see me before. You are much calmer than I thought. "

"I don't like it when they get in a fight."

"I know Nanase came to see you to gently warn you."

"I see. You made an effort to get Nanase to warn of the attack a day before to have time to prepare."

“I knew it was a tactic that I didn't like, but it also worked for me. I decided to use it to my advantage. "

Housen screamed as his left and right fists clenched and slammed into each other. He had no doubt that in less than ten seconds a real fist fight would begin.

“It's a difficult task, isn't it? Housen. "

"Oh?"

In this place where a one-to-one place was supposed to be expected, a man was standing without a shadow.

"Get out of here. You're on my way."

The man waited as if he had anticipated Housen's appearance. Ayanokouji made light eye contact with the man and disappeared deep into the forest. Housen wanted to go after him immediately, but the man in front of him was hard to ignore.

"Why are you here? Ryuuen. "

"That's my line, Housen. You have nothing to do here, do you? "

With that comment from Ryuuen, Housen immediately understood what was going on.

"Eh? ..... Ha, so apparently what I'm thinking comes from somewhere else."

Housen, who immediately understood the situation, smiled in amusement.

"So it was not a coincidence that the other first years were retained by the second years."

The boys who had been sent to Tsubaki to hunt Ayanokouji did not move from their site so that they would overlap by the GPS with the second years. Everything showed that, just as Tsubaki controlled the first year, there was someone in the second year who also controlled the grade.

"It's you? No, it is not like that. "

If Ryuuen is in command, tablets and walkie-talkies are essential.
However, from what he could see, Ryuuen didn't appear to be carrying a backpack.
Also, it would be difficult for someone fighting on the front lines to lead more than one group.

"Have you already understood everything?"

"Do not care. It is none of your business what I do. "

He understood what was happening, but he didn't understand why Ryuuen was part of the effort to stop Ayanokouji from leaving school.

"I'm afraid I have something to do with it."

With a thin smile, Ryuuen began to walk slowly towards Housen.

“I have a lot to do and my pockets are empty. If necessary, I will act as a mercenary soldier. "

“You mean money. But what makes you think you can stop me? "

"Why do you think I can't do it?"

Short distance. The two of them smile hauntingly at each other's fingertips. It was Ryuuen who made the first move. Without taking his gaze off Housen, he aimed his clenched left fist at Housen. The difference in power and stamina due to the difference in physique is obvious, so aim for the chin.

"Whoa ....., that's a pretty daring left hand you have there."

Although he had taken the initiative, Housen, already in combat position, did not lower his guard. He lightly caught Ryuuen's left fist in front of his chest and opened his mouth to smile.

"Don't give me that stinky breath, gorilla."

"You're a good talker. Show me your pride and skill as a sophomore, will you? Hey!"

As soon as he released his left fist, he immediately grabbed his arm and pulled him back. Housen then slams his own forehead against Ryuuen's.

"Aah!"

Ryuuen staggered violently at the unexpected blow that violently shook his brain. Not that Ryuuen hasn't been through much. In fact, he has a history of always being up front in fights and fighting a lot more than the average criminal.
However, the Housen number, on the other hand, is several times higher.

"Oraa!"

Unable to maintain his evasive stance, Ryuuen was hit by Housen's front kick to the abdomen. He fell to the ground with great force and showed a large gap, but Housen smiled widely and did not move from the spot.

"You've been barking and howling for less than ten seconds, haven't you? Don't make me laugh."

"Ha ..... you're a hard stone head fucking. Aren't you made of a real stone there? Damn gorilla."

Immediately after getting up, Ryuuen said something that provoked Housen again. Hearing this, Housen lightly scratched the back of his neck, as if somewhat surprised.

"I guess I was expecting too much. You're not that good to me after all."

"I don't think you will find anyone with whom you are happy."

“I know you are here, because of Ayanokouji, who was walking carefree behind you. Let me take care of it."

"Yes?"

Hearing Housen's words, Ryuuen's smile, which had been on his face all this time, disappeared.

"What, do you also know something, Housen?"

"Know what? So you're really trying to act like nothing's wrong? "

"I thought that not many people knew what it was like between us, but I didn't know that we had that in common."

They spoke conversational, trying to convince each other in a Series of monologues.

"For the first time, I am interested in you, Housen. When and where did you fight, and what was the result?"

"So you're obsessed with Ayanokouji too, huh, Ryuuen?"

The main reason Ryuuen is still in this school is to get revenge on Ayanokouji. As long as he had that, he would not allow Ayanokouji to lose, no matter if it was a fight or not.

Although the Housen in front of him is a brawler who does not fit in the frame of a high school student. Housen sniffed at the heat mixed with a hint of killing intent.

"Don't worry. I haven't finished with him, or should I say I haven't even started."

He shook his head left and right, his bones creaking as he approached Ryuuen.

“I have never seen anyone stop my fist calmly. First of all, I don't think I'll ever see anyone who doesn't seem to be in pain while being stabbed with a knife. "

The words "knife" and "stabbed" immediately triggered a memory in Ryuuen's mind.
‘That Ayanokouji had bandaged his hand for a while, and that he had a scar.’

"Hey, it looks like you've been having a lot of fun without me."

Ryuuen was hit by two fists, but the color of his eyes didn't change at all as he looked at Housen. Not wanting to raise his guard in the face of such an eerie situation, Housen kept pressing. He has always been in a fighting stance, without any pride or carelessness in the fight.

He is always ready for a fight, especially if the enemy in front of him is Ryuuen, who was notorious at school. He kicked the ground and, with a speed not expected of a man of his stature, approached him. He turned around Ryuuen's guard, who was preparing to defend his face, and twisted his fist in his face.
The arm swung so hard that the nose would have been broken had it not been for the arm guard. As soon as he got up, Ryuuen crashed back to the ground.
Anyone would be convinced that from the coup they just saw, the difference between Ryuuen and Housen is obvious.
Ryuuen immediately raised his upper body, but as if he was aiming for that moment, he was surprised by a powerful kick to the face and fell backwards with great force.

"You've been busy falling asleep and getting up right?"

Less than a minute into the fight, it seemed obvious to everyone who was going to be the winner.

"Screw you..."

"Ha ha! That's what I thought, Ryuuen! That's all you are!"

Housen screamed with joy, but at the same time he was forced to scream. There is an irreversible difference in the ability to fight right from the start. And, despite this, Ryuuen's will to fight showed no sign of breaking. Eighty percent of the people Housen fought broke his spirits after a single hit. The remaining 10% would make a show of bravery. And the remaining 10% would despair as soon as the second or third hit was struck.
However, the Ryuuen in front of him was damaged, but no change in the color of his eyes could be seen. In that mental exchange, Ryuuen was one step ahead of Housen.

"It seems like you're having fun, but do you think you've already won?"

Despite the pain, Ryuuen raised his upper body again without losing his smile.

"Don't make me laugh. Do you think you are at my level?"

Housen, who is under his eyes, grabs Ryuen's chest and lifts it up.

"At the end of the day, you are a man who can only get ahead with the help of the little ones."

" Winning one-on-one isn't everything today, is it? In fact, in high school, the public's opinion of you and me was the same. "

Facing the facts, Ryuuen tries to convince Housen.

“It seems that you have been sneaking around and avoiding direct confrontation. It is n effort that makes you cry. "

The jolt wasn't completely useless, but it wasn't effective enough to do any damage. Housen, who has an overwhelming punching advantage, has nothing to change at that position. And Ryuuen, who was still holding on to him, turned his left hand.
He spread his hand next to Housen and squirted a handful of dirt into his eyes.

"Ah!"

He showed a surprise attack, but Housen blocked the dirt with his free opposite hand.

"Is so sweet!"

"Really!"

This time, he waved his right hand again and shot the sand in his hand towards Housen

"That's why it's so sweet!"

Housen used his arm to avoid the sand again that came out of his right hand. He had felt the fists from the moment he grabbed the fallen Ryuuen and lifted him up.

“It has always been a common practice for the weak to fall in a fight."

This time, Housen's fist quickly struck Ryuuen on the right side of his face. A jab-type hit that focuses on speed rather than power. He shot him alternately, this time on the left side and then the right. He attacked like a boxer repeatedly hitting his fists on a punching bag.
While receiving a powerful shock that nearly knocks him unconscious, the eyes of Ryuuen they crossed Housen's pupils momentarily. Immediately afterwards, Housen's vision wavered for a moment as he saw Ryuuen fall as if he were going to fly off.

"..."

Ryuuen, who twisted his body as he was nearly killed, unleashed a spinning kick just before collapsing. Only the shape of Housen's silhouette was visible, which is slightly blurred. Housen, who had no intention of taking a single hit, became frustrated and squeezed and grabbed Ryuuen's bangs with his left hand.

"Are you satisfied to die innocently? Hey!? I am going to kill you!"

Before the guard arm goes up, he repeatedly hits his right fist on Ryuuen's abdomen.

"There is no one who can beat me in a fight!"

When the seventh fist goes through, an alert sounds from Ryuuen's watch.

"Hahaha! Pretending to be calm, but yelling because your body is on edge? It seems that the wristwatch is more direct than you!"

A wristwatch that detects an abnormality, such as a heart rhythm, issues an alert.

"Seriously gorilla ... I'll just admit I'm proud of the fight ..."

Housen, who saw the compliment as a surrender, loosed his bangs with a triumphant smile. Unable to stand upright, Ryuuen collapses to the ground.The alert resounds throughout the forest.

"Isn't the emergency alert sounding? Is it about time you approached your limits? Is it okay to be honest without hiding it?"

"H ... let's put the joke aside. Isn't the clock broken?"

Ryuuen looks at his wristwatch and laughs, but it is evident to everyone that the damage is great. Seeing that awkward appearance, Housen spits on his feet in a bored manner.

"So Ryuuen. I feel like I didn't enjoy."

"Wait. You think you've won."

"Ah?"

"Did I say that I lost to you even once?"

It was Housen who went through the words, but squeezed his mind once. Although he was in a state of one-sided intimidation, Ryuuen's eyes weren't dead as he said.

"I'll admit that will power, but ... You can't keep it forever!"

Humans are vulnerable to pain.Even if it is strong, it will be equally painful if it is hit with a powerful force like Housen's fist.
It's just a matter of how many hits it can take.
Even if you bear it, the overwhelming difference is impossible to override.
Even if the second alert sounds, he won't lose his composure and inflict pain on Ryuuen with precision.
After being attacked by Housen many times, Ryuuen's wristwatch finally turns into an emergency alert. If left like this for 5 minutes or more, staff and medical equipment will come to the scene.

"Your body is sincere. It has had enough with this desperate situation."

"Oh ..... that's a pleasantly numbing pain ....."

However, he got up with a strange laugh without looking at his wristwatch at all. For the first time, Housen knew that Ryuuen's untamed spirit power was genuine.

"What the hell is wrong with you? . You can't even stand, why are you so persistent? There is not a single advantage to being dumb here.

He wears his watch to his ear so he can use it as an alarm clock for a strong emergency alert.

"Are you holding on to that? Hah, the idea itself is wrong."

At that moment, Housen thought that Ryuuen would immediately turn off the emergency alert.
But in the end, without turning off the emergency alert, Ryuuen lowered his arm and put his hands in both pockets.

"The game is not over yet."

"Are you sane? ... The teachers will come here, will you retire?"

"If so, will you quit after all?"

If the school sees this situation, Ryuuen asked how to judge it. Housen received a light kick to the chin, but his evidence was almost nil. The probability that the school interprets that unilateral violence has occurred cannot be ignored.

"You're going to play the victim just because you can't compete with your enemy, you're very pathetic. You're so pathetic, Ryuuen."

Depending on the conditions, it can be said that it has been reversed, but Housen will not be scared by that degree.As long as he has decided to succumb to Ayanokouji with violence in the first place, that point has passed.

"If you are afraid that I am the victim, why don't you go here?"

"Get me out of here."

Judging that Ryuuen's strategy is not to turn off the emergency alert, Housen advances again.

"My GPS is already off. There is nothing wrong with killing you before the teachers hurry up."

Even if the school side rushes to this place, it will last 30 minutes lightly.

"Kuku, I'll have to do that"

Ryuuen greets Housen, who is not intimidated by the threat and does not even try to remove his hand from his pocket.

"If you don't feel like protecting yourself, you can go to bed!"

Kazuomi clenched her right fist, not wanting to waste any more time. Ryuen takes both hands out of his pocket, but both hands are clenched too.

"I don't think the tricks will work for me!"

Housen knew instinctively that Ryuen was holding something, but he never stopped.
To break the spirit, he sent a full-body right straight to Ryuuen. Seeing that, Ryuuen catches him from the front without opening the two fists he was holding.
Housen's arm tries to break the guard, but immediately after that.

"Whoaahh!"

Two shadows emerged from the blind spot in the trees and stood behind the Housen.

"What —— !?"

No wonder Housen was surprised by the unexpected signal. When he did a GPS search a few minutes ago, there was no other reaction than Ayanokouji and Ryuuen around him. Even if immediately after the battle begins, they could never reach there even if they pointed to this place in a straight line. Despite this, two men grab Housen's left and right arms. His existence was like that of a ghost.

Not only Ishizaki, but also Albert, who has a body as strong as Housen, even the mighty Housen couldn't stay on the ground. Albert holds his right arm, which is his dominant arm, and Ishizaki holds his left arm on the other side.

"Shit!!"

He flailed desperately, but it wasn't easy to shake off both of them, even if Housen had a great physique!
The next moment, Housen burned Ryuen, who unprotected himself and laughed eerily.

"It's a simple story. If you break your watch, the GPS won't recognize it."

At an early stage, he disabled Ishizaki and Albert's GPS function and they accompanied Ryuen. When he assumed it was one-on-one, Housen discovered that Ryuuen's strategy had set him up.

"Are you going to do it 3 to 1? Ah !?"

"Don't bark so loud, Gorilla. Your execution is about to begin."

Both fists that had been grabbed again are repeatedly thrown at Housen's face without hesitation.

As he turns Housen's face from right to left, he repeats endlessly until his knees touch the ground.
Housen continued to bark as he supported his shaking knees, but continued to hit him without loosening either of his hands.
Due to the accumulated damage, Housen's knee broke and he falls to the ground.
When Housen's head was lowered into the correct position, Ryuen held Housen's head with both hands and kicked his knees towards his nose.

"Gut ...!"

With an inaudible voice, Housen fell to the ground on his back for the first time. Ryuuen made a sign with his eyes to both of them and made each of them grab his arms just like when they were standing.

Gorillas must always be handcuffed. Well, you've done a lot of good, haven't you, Housen? "

While brushing his hair, Ryuuen straddles Housen.

"You took me lightly, you piece of shit!"

"Light? Ha! What the hell are you talking about?"

"I'm telling you, you're a shitty little fish that can't even fight alone in a real fight!"

"Kuku, don't make me laugh. I'm not stupid enough to fight a gorilla"

With that said, Ryuen laughed and raised his fist.And without hesitation, he slams Housen's cheeks violently.

"Oh yeah, don't worry, Housen. I won't ask you to cry. Even if you apologize, nothing will change."

Despite being hit without protection, Housen was not weak enough to sink. Rather, he gets angry and wreaks havoc. Albert and Ishizaki worked hard to control him.

"Shit! Stand back, you little bastards! "

"Don't get out of control. We're just starting out, right? I'm going to beat you up and you're going to enjoy it."

He moves his fist down over and over again, but Housen continues to bark instead of whimpering.

"I'm sure you won't be bragging about your fight."

Both physically and mentally, Housen has shown that he has reached the top of the world with just one fight. If the fight had been 3-1 from the start.
Ryuuen would have judged his team to be in a bad position. It is also proof that Housen Kazuomi's human strength is recognized in front of him. However, in a battle, an impromptable decision can decide the outcome. Like a blow, a fall can make the difference between light and dark. With a moment of carelessness and pride, the position is reversed. After that, Ryuuen's one-sided lynchings were repeated, and even the mighty Housen lost the strength of his body.

“How difficult. My arm is starting to hurt. "

He exhales into the red fist while laughing.

"Ha, ha ..... damn ....."

Hosen tries to escape from Albert using his right arm, which is his dominant arm, but he is no match for the enemy.



"You had a guy like that as a subordinate ... I didn't expect it."

In a simple comparison of power, he looked at Albert, who would not be defeated by Housen.

"Hey, big man ... Why the hell are you following Ryuuen? Eh?"

In simple combat power, it is clear that Albert has more power than Ryuuen.

"It is true that I am a man that Ryuuen can’t defeat even if he faced me once or twice."

"Why then?"

"You don't understand, Housen. Not only the monstrously powerful rise to the top."

Even with that explanation, Housen, who had always fought alone, was far from being understood.

"Kuku. Well, in Albert's case, I'd say it's just camaraderie"

Albert doesn't like to get into unnecessary fights, and decides that the best way to keep the class together is to follow Ryuuen.

That is why he does not hesitate to lend a hand, although sometimes he has to act scandalously. He may temporarily harm his friends by following the instructions, but he believes that in the long run it will benefit his companions, so he has decided to follow Ryuuen. By nature, he is a kind-hearted man who does not like violence.

"Don't think you have won with this, Ryuuen!"

"I'm sure you're not happy with that. You never thought you'd lose like this. But for me, the process doesn't matter. The last man standing is the winner."

To Ryuuen, who didn't have the one-on-one vision from the beginning, Housen's provocation made no sense. Rather, he took it as the cry of pain from a defeated man, and plunged into pleasure.

"Oh shit. ......! "

After being hit dozens of times, no matter how many times Housen was hit, he would reach his limit. Even if there was no longer an existence that held the left and right hands, it would not be easy to defeat Ryuuen.

"Remember, even if you win here, the next time I see you, I will kill you immediately."

"I am not going to swallow your revenge of the gorilla, but if you are going to do it....do it well It is not as simple as winning. Winning is not as simple as it seems. If you go ahead, but you end up being expelled, you will you lose. "

"What is it ...!"

Ryuuen's direct blow hits Housen's cheek and ripped his consciousness away. Housen's consciousness flew and resolved, and Ryuen slowly rose to his feet.

“Huh. ..... it was a tough fight. "

While spilling blood from his fist, Ryuuen looks up at the sky and exhales wearily with a sigh.

"But he's a great guy. ..... I really thought he was a monster."

"You would be a fool if you faced him."

Albert agreed with those words and nodded.

"They have had to work a lot."

It is an example of how fierce this battle has been, the words of thanks for his work come from Ryuuen.

"No, no, no, no! We were just supporting you! Hey, Albert!"

Neither Ishizaki nor Albert had major external injuries.
It was that Ryuen had decided that he had to avoid involving them too much in this battle. If the number of suspicious people increases, this dispute will not end up as a simple brawl.

"You should get moving. The teachers could arrive at any moment."

It has been a certain amount of time since the emergency alert on Ryuen's wristwatch sounded.

"What about Ryuen-san ...?"

"Well, I'm in this state. Even if I wanted to continue, they wouldn't let me do it easily."

Along with Housen, the injuries inflicted on Ryuuen are quite serious.

"I'm going to retire together with Housen"

"Are you sure with that?"

"I have left everything they need in the hands of Katsuragi. Although the first three groups have become more difficult to win"

If he left Housen here, there was a possibility that he would head towards Ayanokouji. But if Ryuuen, the one who hurt him, disappears, that will be a problem. Here, Ryuen and Housen had a one-on-one fight and retired together.
From the beginning I decided that this was the only and most beautiful way to do it.

"... I'm sorry to hear that."

The Ryuuen and Katsuragi Group, who ranked 5th yesterday, had a slim chance to move on to the next spot. Ishizaki regretted it.

"That is not the case."

Ryuen laughs lightly as if he remembers something. Not knowing why, Ishizaki and Albert looked at each other.

"I'll tell you soon. Go anyway now."

To ensure that both Ishizaki and Albert survive as a group, they must avoid abandonment. To do this, they must exchange watches and join the group as soon as possible.
After they both ran towards the starting point, Ryuen sat down to use Housen's unconscious body as a bench.

Part 7

"—— Thank you for your report, you can go back to the exam."

Tsubaki, who received a report from the walkie-talkie, ended the call quietly.

"It didn't go very well, did it?"

Seeing her complexion and judging her like this, Yagami asks.

"When I went to see the point where Housen-kun would have come into contact, it seems that the teachers were meeting and were taking him back to the starting point. He got into a fight with a boy named Ryuuen from the 2nd class. grade B, and they both got very injured. Well, it was kind of suspicious because Ayanokouji-senpai kept moving."

If Housen had drawn him one-on-one, the GPS would have had to stop moving on the spot.

"I don't know much about that person, but he stopped Housen-kun."

Tsubaki, unconvinced, purses her lips and reflects on the failure of this plan. This is because Ayanokouji's designated areas were C3 and D2, the perfect place to surround him. However, this positive factor also gave the adversary time.

"This is not the end of Ayanokouji's expulsion, is it? For the first graders to be safely saved, we have to crush the other independent groups. If you have any other ideas, let me know."

Yagami presses her, but Tsubaki looks away and mutters with interest.

"I don't think we should cross more dangerous bridges. If we force ourselves to help a group of people who are falling here, sooner or later they are destined to disappear."

"..... So you're saying you're backing out here?"

“There is something I don't like. Perhaps it was decided early on that my plan would not work. "

"What do you mean?"

"The story of the bounty in his head is spinning on its own, and Ayanokouji-senpai's vigilance is strong. Most importantly, as long as I don't trust my first-year classmates, it means that this plan was reckless.”

Tsubaki disliked the interruption, which was more annoying than being dejected over failure.

"I regret having done it alone."

She was very sorry, saying she could have done a much better job. When she released the tablet screen, she noticed something.

"Eh?"

For here Tsubaki realized that Utomiya was not present.

"What happened?"

"Where is Utomiya?"

When she said that, Yagami also pretended to notice Utomiya's absence.

"I think it was close until about 30 minutes ago ..."

It was when Tsubaki was launching into battle with an enemy that she couldn't see on her tablet. Feeling disturbed, Tsubaki shows a map 10 minutes ago and searches for Utomiya's location.
It was about 400 meters southwest of where Tsubaki was standing.

"What are you doing……?"

There was only a GPS reaction near it, and the name was— Hayato Kitou second year from class A. The moment she saw the name, Tsubaki took the walkie talkie.

Part 8

A large man runs through the forest in poor visibility. The big man's goal is the camp where Sakurako Tsubaki, Hachi, Takuya Yagami and Utomiya Riku are.
He had been instructed by Sakayanagi and he was tasked with unmasking the person who was in charge of that plan. When Kitou runs and tries to keep the camp in sight, he finds a figure in front of his eyes. The man was standing on the road as if he was blocking the way, looking towards Kitou. Kitou did not recognize the face of that person, but immediately recognized that he was not an ally. He tried to change course while there was distance, but when he saw it, the other man also began to walk.
Recognizing that he is an enemy, Kitou stops running and turns to the man.

"What do you want on these roads?"

Utomiya asks the question in a severe tone of voice, forgetting to use honorifics even though he is dealing with an older student.

"I think you are Kitou Hayato-senpai ....., a second year student from class A"

He says it calmly and with a mixture of honorifics. He was originally alone, so he remembered Kito, but he was removed from the list because he joined the group. However, telling him that he knew from the beginning can be suspicious, so he pretended not to notice.

"I'm in a hurry now"

With a new rejection, Kitou tries to dodge Utomiya.However; Utomiya grabbed him by the shoulder and stopped him.

"……What is it"

Kitou, who was annoyed by his behavior, looked at him with contempt, but Utomiya also just shot him a sharp look.

"I'm sorry, but I'm not going to let you pass from here."

"What?"



Utomiya's fist approaches in front of Kitou, who frowns suspiciously, Kitou calmly avoids the fist and keeps his distance.

"What are you doing?"

And then Utomiya reached out, and grabbed him by the neck.

"I'll tell you. I'm not going to let you pass from here."

"What is your name?"

"1st year of class C, Utomiya"

'Utomiya', One of the objectives of the investigation, ordered by Sakayanagi At the stage where he was trapped here, he wasn't the main target And Utomiya also guessed that Kitou had received instructions from someone to come here.

"Who ordered you to come here?"

He tried to ask the name, but Kitou gave no sign of answering.

"I have no intention of showing any compassion even with a senpai."

At these words, Kitou's eyes shine brightly and his thick arms point to Utomiya's neck. Unhurriedly, Utomiya kept his distance and escaped Kitou's attack without difficulty. However, due to his quick evasive action, the walkie-talkie in his pocket falls at Kitou's feet.

"Oh crap……!"

He rushed closer, but Kitou's stance prevented him from launching himself without a fight. The dazzling stares continued for a while, but then the silence was broken by another.

"Utomiya-kun? What are you doing?"

Tsubaki's voice leaks from the walkie-talkie rolling under his feet.

"Shit..."

Utomiya clicks his tongue and looks at the walkie-talkie he has dropped.

"Didn't you follow my instructions?”

Tsubaki continues to do so, though she doubts she won't get an answer. Utomiya was looking for an opportunity to pounce, but Kitou signaled him to calm down with one of his hands.
He grabbed the walkie-talkie at his feet and gently tossed it towards Utomiya.

"What are you going to do ...?"

Utomiya asks as if the fury that had been drained from him by his unexpected action.

"The objective has been reached"

When there was no longer a need to fight, Kitou collects his luggage and turns around. He heard Tsubaki's voice over the walkie-talkie and decided that she was the commander. Kitou's back has started to drift away, leaving him defenseless.

"If you can hear Utomiya-kun, calm down. It's a bad idea to fight Kitou-senpai here now."

Kitou disappeared while staring at the walkie-talkie for a while without answering.

"... It's me. "

When he was alone, Utomiya answered with a walkie-talkie.

"Are you safe? What about Kitou-senpai?”

"He went right in front of me .."

"Why would you do something like that? If you do something like that, Utomiya will also be expelled. Right? Or were you just trying to keep second year students away from me?"

"No, it's not. ..... I'm sorry. If the strategy didn't work out this time, there was no need to give unnecessary information to a potential opponent. I wanted to prevent them from getting close to Tsubaki."

"I can't blame you for what happened, but is that what you thought, Utomiya-kun?"

After a short silence, says Utomiya.

"No. ..... Yes, yes. I moved on my own."

Perhaps it was an annoying reply, Tsubaki was silent for a moment behind the communication device.

"So. If you can move for now, come back."

"Very good."

After finishing the communication, Utomiya looks at the tablet. Then when he picks up the walkie-talkie again, He change the code and communication begins.

"I've gotten rid of that 2nd year weirdo. I should be pleased to see that Tsubaki is in charge."

"As expected, Utomiya-kun"

"So, how was Tsubaki's plan?"

"It failed as expected. Even though Ayanokouji-senpai didn't bother to give advance notice, I'm sure it was an old-fashioned strategy that was never going to be successful from the beginning."

"I have to go." Without inadvertently prolonging the matter, Utomiya turns off the walkie-talkie

Chapter 6: The Man Known As Tsukishiro

Intro

I woke up at the far right of E3 in the morning and tried to consult the map on my tablet.
As a consequence of preventing the advancement of first graders the previous day, the day ended without stepping on any designated area. Sakayanagi reported that she had left immediately in the afternoon, but I did not dare to go to the designated area. I have just participated in the race challenge and had achieved the minimum amount of points.
The randomly designated zone that was lifted yesterday at 1:00 p.m. was F3, and later at 3:00 p.m. it was G3.
I opened the map and loaded the image from yesterday's GPS search at 1pm. There were a total of five groups of freshmen stalking us. And all of them were with Housen who had turned off the GPS and had approached me. I'm sure of it. And after Housen went into a confrontation with the Ryuuen and was resolved, it was evident in the subsequent search that all the groups withdrew and returned to the special exam.
However.... While Sakayanagi and I were aware of those enemies, various groups of first-year students who had dispersed, gathered together and advanced towards the designated area. The reason I thought this group was suspicious was because as soon as 3pm came and G3, my fourth designated zone, was announced, they moved west and started heading towards F4.
The road here is narrow, and it is difficult to escape if the road is blocked, but if you avoid it, you will be forced to take many turns.

"I avoided the risk just in case, but that did a lot of damage on the last day."

I've had six in a row and I am in the middle of four consecutive penalties. I have to get out of this situation as soon as possible. If I commit three more penalties in a row, I will lose another 18 points from here.
Since I can't see the classification, I have to imagine my classification on this last day.
The classification for the night of the 12th is completely unreliable. There are 157 groups in total, so it seems fine, but in reality, many groups have finished merging. In other words, it is better to assume that the number of groups has already decreased considerably. Of course, on this final day, it is clear that some groups will move faster.
If a group with almost 200 points picks up the lower group, it will outperform me at that point.
The effect of doubling the score on this last day cannot be ignored. This means that the freshmen's strategy has gradually led them down the path of dropping out of school.

There is still a chance for freshmen to keep waiting ahead, but GPS search is no longer

available.
At 7 in the morning the ban was lifted on the designated area, H3, which is not a good place due to the mountains, but it cannot be avoided because it is impossible to interpret. Even if I took the shortest route from here, it would take us almost two hours. I can't afford to waste my time.
On a day when many students would be taking on a task that had been duplicated, I didn't know that I would be forced to fight a close battle to see if I could step on the designated area. By noon, I could have dropped further down the rankings. While packing and leaving, I got a call on my walkie-talkie from Sakayanagi

"Good morning, Ayanokouji-kun. You had a lot of problems yesterday. "

"Thank you Sakayanagi for saving me"

“Do you agree with the penalty? You seem to have moved a lot during the night. "

"I'm sure Sakayanagi is aware of my movements through the GPS."

“The first designated area is H3. There is not much time, but I think I can do it. "

"H3?"

Sakayanagi muttered the designated area with interest, as if she had something to think about. I keep talking to Sakayanagi as I move.

"Actually, I'm in trouble. At dawn, Ichinose-san disappeared."

That is a tricky problem for an event that occured on the last day.

“What do you mean that she had disappeared? Was it an accident?"

“No, it seems to be an involuntary action. The last few days she has been acting strange."

"But why did you contact me? I'm sure there is nothing I can do to help you. "

"Actually, when I did a GPS search to find out Ichinose-san's position, I found that it was at the same E3 as Ayanokouji-kun. However, it is the opposite D3 side."

Even in the same area, there is a certain distance between the extremes. And now, I've already set foot on F3

"What was the final designated area of Ichinose yesterday?"

"It was D5. Ichinose-san arrived there. She started performing at dawn without telling anyone, and now she was here at E3 for some reason?....In the morning, I realized that we had lost a point. I checked with the people in the group, but there was no sign that anyone had used the GPS search. It seems that Ichinose used it. It is not known if her objective was E3 or a further area, but it is normal to think that she went to meet someone. "

I guess so. If she had stepped into the designated fourth zone within yesterday, that's the only reason she would move first thing in the morning.

"I thought maybe it was to meet Ayanokouji-kun, but ..."

"I'm sorry, but I don't know. I haven't seen Ichinose in this special exam. If you wait, Ichinose can get to F3's side, sorry, I'm in a hurry. What are you going to do?"

“The first designated area we had to go to was E6. I'll discard the reward on a first-come, first-served basis, but I must ignore it. In the worst case, if you withdraw, it will not have a great negative effect on this last day. "

That said, the Sakayanagi group is a worthy team of seven. They were in a great position to get on the podium and they were in fourth place at the end of the 12th. Losing Ichinose here would have been a blow.
On the other hand, she's acting selfishly on such an important last day. It is an inexplicable behavior that Ichinose, who acts for her friends more than anyone else, cannot imagine.

"You are in trouble?"

“Accidents are destined to happen, you know. Well, even if you let it, the special exam will be over in half a day, so I don't think there is any problem. If you ever see her, tell her about the situation. "

Sakayanagi ends the communication, saying that anything else would be a hindrance.

"Where is Ichinose going ……?"

I keep the walkie-talkie in my backpack while I walk, and now I take out my tablet. It's the last day and I don't need to think about recharging. With 31% charge remaining, I'm good to go.
The map displayed on the screen shows the designated zone to which I must go and the challenges spread by the zone.
Over the past two weeks, challenges have appeared all over the uninhabited island.

However, on this last day, it seems to me that there is no challenge in the northern areas of the island, from 1 to 3. On the contrary, the central and southern areas, from 5 to 10, and more. Specifically from A to E, they have a large number of challenges. This is simply because it is the last day of the test, and it makes sense for students to be driven back to where they started. It's wise to go quickly through designated zones and take on the challenges.
I had been thinking of using GPS search to find out Ichinose's location, but now I am at risk of being expelled from school. It is a good idea to save points here to increase the survival rate as much as possible.

Part 1

The second destination they showed me today was I2, the northeast corner of the uninhabited island.
Now that we've managed to stop the penalty, I can head there with some ease.
After 3:00 pm when the exam ends, you basically walk back to the starting point, but in some cases there seems to be a plan to pick up students at any time in a patrol boat.
Looks like a patrol boat will arrive at J6 at 5pm if it's close.

"It's the end of the day, and they have put designated areas in the most absurd places. ....."

The test environment remains the same, with problems concentrated on the south side of the island, but the designated area is the most northeast. I am convinced to regret the fact that it is obviously a trap; it will be of no use.
It would be easier if it could be distributed that way, but I was starting to feel somewhat unsettling here. Since this morning, none of the other students have crossed paths or seen each other first. Although the island is large, there are many opportunities to see or hear someone's voice whenever you are on the move.
Of course, I couldn't get to the final designated area yesterday, so I'm not sure I can't meet the students in the same square as me.
The test environment remains the same, with problems concentrated on the south side of the island, but the designated area is the most northeast. It may be a good idea to step on I2 and then ignore the designated end zone to get to the challenges.
H3 has a narrow river that divides the area.

This river cannot be used as a shortcut, so it is a troublesome place where you are forced to take a detour.

The advantage is that you can walk along the river and do not have to worry about getting lost. Don't be in a hurry, go down the river to the southwest, get to the point where you can cross the river, and go northeast. You can walk along the river until you reach the mountains. That's when I got to the other side of the river, near the center of H3.

“Ayanokouji-kun———!”

I was walking while listening to the sound of flowing water when a voice calling my name came from a distance. The direction of the voice was the north side of the river I had just gone around.

Over there was Ichinose, covered in mud, looking at me, gasping.

“Ichinose… You came to H3?”

According to Sakayanagi, Ichinose should have been in E3 now.

Now that the time was after 10 A.M if the sun started to rise at 5:30 A.M, Ichinose probably had to walk continuously for 4 and a half hours to get here. Despite that, it was relatively quick as well.

“I….I, I came here because I wanted to see you, Ayanokouji-kun.”

Even though she looked like she could barely speak, exhausted, she called out from across the river.

“I’ll come over to your side now!”

Saying that, Ichinose ran staggeringly along the river.

Because her backpack was in the way being too heavy, she left it there.

No matter how you look at it, the place where Ichinose was walking was pretty dangerous. And it should be difficult to walk over here with her strength that was reaching it’s limit. I turned back the way I came, and hurriedly met up with her.

It took about 5 minutes to meet up with her along the river, and then walk to a place where we could congregate.

Since I couldn't let Ichinose exert herself like that, I crossed the river to the north.

"I, fin-finally, finally caught up… Wait, I'll come to your side."

Did she feel responsible due to calling out to me first that she kept chasing after me like this?

"Ah."

Ichinose fell, and I caught her in a hug.

"So-sorry! Ah, heheh? Why? My feet… They aren't obeying me…"

She panicked, and wanted to leave my touch, but her knees were trembling, as if she couldn't stand up.

"What's going on, Ichinose?"

Ichinose looked up at me, and spoke, desperately trying to sort the situation out.

"I, I have something I have to tell you, no matter what, Ayanokouji-kun!"

"Something you have to tell me?"

"I've been troubled, troubled. I've always been troubled… to protect my friends and classmates…"

What exactly was she trying to say? I didn't know specifically, but her desperate effort was real.

"But, despipte this, I'm still worried about your safety, Ayanokouji0kun, no matter what…"

In this special exam, Ichinose and I didn't have a consistent point of contact.



Did something unexpected happen?

In order to tell me about this, Ichinose spent more than 4 hours walking to me, desperately.

“I, my watch broke, so I wanted to go back to the starting point to change it… And then, Acting Director Tsukishiro, and Shiba-sensei, those two, they were there…!”

Ichinose was so tired that her breathing hadn’t even stabilized yet, as she stammered along

Although I didn’t know when this was, I guess she had been distressed about this for a few days now.

“If you’re safe in the last day, Ayanokouji-kun, you’ll be called to I2 and be buried.”

Words such as “I2” as well as “bury”. Indeed, just hearing those words would fill one with dread. The reason why Tsukishiro and Shiba were overheard by her was because her watch was broken, so the GPS didn’t respond?

“Saying that you wanted to protect your classmates, were you threatened by Tsukishiro?”

Ichinose seemed to be surprised for a moment that I had guessed it, but nodded then after.

“If I told this to you… Acting Director Tsukishiro would make my classmates drop out… But I can’t turn my back on you no matter what, Ayanokouji-kun…!”

“You should give up telling me this, without caring about the consequences. I’m your enemy.”

If only she could think in such a way of the plan could be carried out to make me drop out of school.

Ichinose shook her head strongly to express her disagreement after hearing something I said.

“It can never be like that! Ayanokouji-kun, Ayanokouji-kun…. Is not my enemy!”

Ichinose clutched my shirt near my chest.

“I think I’m an enemy.”

“Because….Because to me, Ayanokouji-kun is…”

The hand that was clutching my shirt tightened once more.

“Because I, because I like you, Ayanokouji-kun…!”

Those are words that Ichinose herself probably didn’t expect to say out loud.

As soon as those words came out, Ichinose averted her eyes, as if she was trying to shut herself up.

“No, that’s not right! That, eh, just now, why did I, eh, ehhhhhhhh!?”

She herself probably didn’t understand it, and fell into panic, shaking her head repeatedly.

“What did I, just, say?!?”

It was like the memory of what she just said had suddenly disappeared and fell into a panic, not understanding.

“Can I say something? About what you just said to me.”

“Um, um …… ah, no, no! Ah, so I haven’t said it yet and I remembered wrong!!!”

“–Thank you, Ichinose.”

“Eh? Eh? Ehhhh!?!”

I expressed my gratitude to Ichinose once again.

She gave priority to me rather than her classmates, and her group that was formed for the purpose of winning.

I won’t belittle that sentiment of hers.

“If you hadn’t told me of something like that, Ichinose, I don’t know what would have become of me.”

I guess this was a big watershed moment for me.

If I hadn’t met Ichinose here, I wouldn’t have thought that Tsukishiro would have gone to I2. Tsukishiro had threatened Ichinose, but even so, she was here, right before my eyes.

Despite the danger, she told me everything.

“Did you mean what you just said?”

“That, that, so, um, it’s not, that, that, right?”

“If not, deny it now, it’ll be my misunderstanding.”

“…That…. misunderstanding… it’s not a misunderstanding…”

Ichinose originally wanted to deny it, but she felt that she couldn’t run away from this anymore.

“…..I like… you…”

She admitted in a faint, hoarse voice, that sounded as if it was about to disappear.

“I think, I probably just noticed this myself too…. S-sorry.”

She didn’t need to apologize.

“To be honest, I’m a little surprised that you would think that, Ichinose.”

“So-sorry…. It’s a pain, isn’t it?”

“Nothing of the sort, I just can’t respond to your feelings this right now.”

“Well….well, my words, aren’t worthy of Ayanokouji…”

“That’s not it. I think that there’s still a few things that has to be addressed, and I don’t think someone can answer yes or no in this state.”

And it’s also necessary to avoid telling her about Kei right now.

Even though she would be hurt if she found out afterwards, this was the climax of the uninhabited island exam.

Since there was still a bit of time left, it wasn’t worth taking away energy for the battle because of it.

“It may not be acceptable, but that’s the answer I can give you right now.”

“Well….I understand.”

Ichinose nodded, neither disdainful nor dissatisfied.

“I’m going to go to I2 now, there are things that have to be done there.”

“No, you can’t! It’s dangerous!”

“If I don’t do that, I won’t be able to protect you, Ichinose, and your precious classmates, right?”

It’s because she herself had been so troubled that she understood.

Since Ichinose contacted me and told me about it, it wasn’t hard to imagine that Tsukishiro would also know.

However, it’s necessary for me to tell Tsukishiro, that it wasn’t the end of the road for me. Rather, it’d be akin to coming back from the dead.

“You get some rest, and then rejoin your group, alright?”

I patted her head, and headed to I2.

Part 2

There was a rock field next to the border of I2 and I3, with knee high bushes nearby.

“So it’s somewhere here?”

I was carrying a heavy backpack.

As long as I didn't know what awaits me, carrying the backpack would only get in my way. I decided to put everything, including the tablet, into the backpack. If I walked along the coastline, I wouldn't get lost and would be able to get back to this rock field.

Ichinose said that this was the place where Tsukishiro prepared to bury me.

Groups that had the same schedule as I was probably assigned a completely different designated area. I would have liked to confirm this, but I also wanted to avoid losing one point from using the GPS search.

Since I knew that Ichinose was involved in the matter, I had to go. If I decided not to, Tsukishiro would mercilessly attack her class. I couldn't imagine what kind of punishment he would inflict on her.

After those preparations, I began to walk towards I2.

"Ayanokouji, what a coincidence."

Nagumo, holding the tablet, looked over with interest.

Given my situation, it was unnatural for anyone to be in the area.

Was this guy also involved with Tsukishiro apart from the matter of the bounty?

No, the title of the student council probably didn't mean much to Tsukishiro.

It didn't seem necessary to connect his appearance here with the matter, but I still kept wary.

"President Nagumo, why are you here?"

I looked around slightly but didn't see any of Nagumo's group members.

"Don't worry. We are the only ones here."

Maybe he had used GPS search, as he wanted to remove the wariness within me.

"There aren't any events nearby. Why are you here?"

Nagumo approached from the southeast direction.

“I was having fun on the beach at I4. Life on this uninhabited island is coming to an end, after all.”

On the last day, while almost all the students focused on collecting points, he was playing on the beach.

“Is this the so-called calmness of a king?”

Nagumo laughed and did not answer the question.

“But I’ll ask you the same thing, Ayanokouji. This place is not a designated area and doesn’t have an event, so why did you come here? Did you meet up with Honami?”

It’s not surprising that her name popped up. Even if he didn’t see Ichinose directly, it would be obvious that she was nearby if he had done a GPS search.

“Is there a problem with that?”

“No. If you two are still together now, you would have spoken about quite a bit. But you are here by yourself, so it means you have a different objective. What’s there at I2?”

I decided to ignore the question. Nagumo changed the topic and continued.

“The uninhabited island exam is coming to an end, right? I just wanted to talk to you once, as there aren’t many situations at school where you and I, the student council president, can talk to each other.”

“That’s true.”

I was just an inconspicuous student.

On the other end was the student council president that could make a child cry without even uttering a single word. This was not an appropriate match up.

However, I didn’t think he had come all the way over here just to engage in small talk.

“You seem to be aware of the attack on me by the 1st years.”

“Your critical thinking ain’t bad.”

It was about the bounty. The person who got me expelled would be awarded 20 million points.

Although Tsukishiro was the one in control, it was true that Nagumo was also involved.

If it were a man like Nagumo, it was not surprising for him to observe my situation through GPS at any time.

From looking at the movements of the first years and me, it was obvious that I had been attacked.

Nagumo saw the big picture of this special exam on the same level as I did. No, even more so than me.

It was also because he had a grasp of my movements that he was able to show himself so easily here.

“Don’t blame me for the bounty. It wasn’t my proposal in the first place.”

“It was Acting Director Tsukishiro’s.”

“Since you know this much, I’ll be blunt. The money’s all from the Acting Director. I just lent the name of the Student Council president to him.”

It didn’t matter whether he wanted it or not; as long as it was an order from the Acting Director, Nagumo couldn’t disobey.

“It’s an order from the Acting Director, so you had to accept it. But if it’s the Student Council President I know, I think you would have refused such a proposal, right?”

“If it’s about the matter of the bounty, I wouldn’t have accepted it, if it were a student other than you. But the one which he named was none other but you, the only man that Horikita-senpai trusted.”

So Nagumo did indeed see me as one of Horikita Manabu’s people.

“Answer me, Ayanokouji. What do you plan to do next?”

[Don’t concern yourself with such an insignificant existence like me] It would be easy to say this.

But Nagumo wouldn’t take that for an answer.

Since I didn’t know what awaited me ahead, it’s all the more important to cherish the time I had now.

“This has nothing to do with you, President Nagumo. Shouldn’t you be concentrating on the end of the exam? The score difference between you and Koenji should be small. If you don’t go back, you won’t get the arrival points, you won’t be able to participate in some events, and that situation will stay the same.”

That was, he left open the possibility of him being overtaken.

“Don’t worry about it. On this last day, I have completely overwhelmed Koenji.”

Saying this, Nagumo took out a transceiver from his back pocket.

Even if he was separated from his group, it would be enough to give instructions.

“Although I do care what you’re going to do, if you won’t answer, then I’ll change my question. Let me see if you, who hold the expectations of Horikita-senpai, have the strength worthy of my expectations, which of course means that you’ll have to get serious.”

So this was the biggest reason for him to come here.

“Does it mean that I have to fight with the Student Council President right here?”

“I don’t hate brawling, but I prefer a serious fight. Even if this uninhabited island exam is over, there’ll still be a lot of inter-year battles afterwards, and I want you to be my opponent.”

The student council president directly called me out.

“Isn’t the winner between us already decided from this uninhabited island exam?”

Nagumo had steadily maintained 1st or 2nd place in the exam up to now.

Although the fierce Koenji still had a chance of reversing it, this was undoubtedly a tough battle.

“You are one person, and I’ve got 7 people. It’s a strange way to have a match like this, right?”

“Wouldn’t Koenji be a better fit? Although he’s a weirdo, he’s a powerhouse. On the other hand, I haven’t been in the top ten even once.”

If you wanted a strong opponent, go to Koenji. I urged him like this.

“Well, he certainly exceeded my expectations, as he was the only one who made me take an offensive move in the exam. “

Admitting that about Kouenji, he shrugged his shoulders as if he was amazed.

This offensive move was referring to the transceiver he’s using right now.

“Managing the entire third year to take all the arrival bonus points and the events. This is something only the student council president can do.”

Unlike the first-years and second-years, almost all the third-years were under Nagumo’s control.

If he wanted to completely block off Kouenji, he would surely be able to do so by mobilizing all the third-years.

No matter how much physical strength he had, it was useless if he couldn’t complete events over a long period of time.

All the other years that show off by being in the top 3 ranks will be erased.

As a result, Kouenji could only get arrival points.

Meanwhile, Nagumo’s groups will widen the point gap by continuously gaining points.

“So you indeed see through this much. When did you notice?”

“I’ve felt suspicious ever since the beach flags event. The vacant space Vice President Kiriyama left intentionally open was reserved for you.”

However, since I arrived first, they had to register with a vacant space.

Nagumo was playing leisurely while waiting for Kiriyama and others to finish the event.

“I thought you and Vice President Kiriyama were rivals, but it seems different.”

“That guy teamed up with me, even though he hates me, just to get into Class A.”

“Let’s put aside Koenji, who’s a special case, for now. I wouldn’t want to do anything to your average student.”

Upon hearing my response, Nagumo seemed to think something was funny and laughed.

“Did you really just call me that? You don’t think I am strong at all.”

“That’s not—”

I wanted to deny it, but Nagumo interrupted.

“Maybe you thought I won by just mobilizing all the third-years, but that’s not the case. I will show you my superpower now.”

“Superpower?”

“Let me guess your group’s ranking at the end of the 12th day.”

Only the rankings of the top 10 and bottom 10 groups were public. Excluding those 20 groups from the 157 groups in total, there were 137 groups. Of course, I was the only one who knew my exact ranking.

At the final moment before the date changed, I was ranked 16th.

“You’re ranked…11th, right?”

Nagumo said so confidently, but he was slightly off.

However, I couldn't just point that out with a smile. On Day 12th, as a response to the attacks of the 1st years, I repeatedly used GPS search. It was plausible that I would be 11th without using those points.

But it was part of the rules. He couldn't know the rankings of all the groups.

Essentially, there's a basis for what Nagumo said.

"A little off? Then you're ranked around 15th or 16th right?"

"Yeah. Truly admirable of you."

If I admitted this straightforwardly, Nagumo would just calmly accept it.

"I joked around with that superpower stuff. I just guessed, assuming that you really have hidden your strength."

It seems like this man Nagumo was much better than I thought.

"In order not to attract attention, your ranking is a bit lower than 10th, but still, you've maintained an upper-ranking position. If I lose the battle against Koenji, then you'd have a chance to make a comeback.

In order not to attract attention, I would lurk around this rank before Day 12.

As fatigue settled in for everyone, the upper ranks would lose momentum. Depending on the circumstances, you could build up your points, and in a flash, aim for the top 3. Unfortunately, I had planned to stay at my current ranking.

"Have you noticed? From the very start, this wasn't possible."

The strategy we developed was rendered useless by Nagumo from the very start.

"Kurona from third-year has been keeping the 10th place, right? I had him maintain that rank to block those who had been secretly saving points and aiming to make a comeback."

Although there was quite a point gap between the 9th and 10th place, it became harder for me to aim for the top places day by day.

This was all according to Nagumo's plan.

Forcefully eliminating those invisible enemies, he limited his gaze to those visible to his eyes.

"I've always doubted whether you were strong enough, but now I understand. You've been granted the right to be crushed by me, so rejoice."

"Was it part of your plan? Your command of the attack on Koenji on the last day?"

"If I want to earn points, whether that's 400 or 500 points, I can earn them. However, that's not interesting, right? Now there's hope that he might beat the second and first-years. Besides, if he lost in the battle with me, we might be able to see his regretful expression."

Nagumo, as part of the strongest group, went through the two weeks of battle totally relaxed.

Then, on the last day, he would defeat Kouenji, becoming the first placed existence.

If Nagumo became serious, he would know the points of particular groups. From GPS searches and Nagumo's partners' eyewitnesses, he would be able to know whether arrival points were gained and the results of the events. Even today, when the exact points of the rankings was unknown, there's no doubt that Nagumo had an accurate grasp of Kouneji's points.

In other words, it was possible for him to direct a dramatic victory of winning by just one point.

"Anyway, Kouenji's matter is whatever. The last thing I will do at this school is to defeat you, Ayanokouji."

Nagumo, who had been chasing after Horikita Manabu, wanted to see his shadow on me.

He wanted to completely beat him, to decide the winner and loser, no matter the format of the battle.

“Unfortunately, the leader of Class 2-D is Horikita. Even if there’s a special exam that competes with the third-years, I won’t fight you.”

“Then I would have to force you to appear on the front stage, which includes using the bounty.”

In other words, he wouldn’t hesitate to say expose my situation.

“I’m sorry, but I’m in a hurry. Let’s continue with this topic next time.”

“You think you can escape this easily? I won’t let you go before you agree to a fight with me.”

Nagumo seemed to want to follow me and caught up from behind.

If something awaited me ahead, Nagumo would be affected. Since the opponent was Tsukishiro, in the worst-case scenario, Nagumo could lose everything he had built up and be expelled under his name.

If I tried to persuade him with my words here, Nagumo wouldn’t accept it no matter what.

Of course, I couldn’t get away with a lie either.

I stopped walking and looked back.

“You want to fight me—”

As Nagumo misunderstood, delighted, I pushed on his chest, forcefully, without warning.

Nagumo probably didn’t expect a kouhai attacking him, so he fell on his butt without any resistance.

The tablet he was holding, and the transceiver in his pocket fell to the ground.



“What—”

Nagumo looked as if he didn’t comprehend what just happened to him.

I’ll do what I need to do before he can comprehend what happened.

“President Nagumo, although your abilities are different from President Horikita’s, it still allowed you to brilliantly stand at the top of this school. You maintained a top ranking in this special exam with ease, and it’s no exaggeration to say you had complete control over it. Even so, I plan to beat you.”

Before he calmed down or got angry, I continued.

“It’s just that there are certain areas where you shouldn’t step into. Please understand.”

“Huh?.... Don’t be ridiculous. You presume to give me orders?”

“It’s because you have the status of being a senpai worthy of my respect that I am not going to be lenient here.”

“Ah? What are you doing—”

I looked into Nagumo’s eyes with all my killing intent.

“Urgh....!?”

“Don’t you understand what I said?”

Nagumo stood up powerfully as if to not admit his fear.

“Stop while you’re ahead? You’re the first person to underestimate me to such an extent, Ayanokouji...”

Right then, the transceiver that fell on the ground next to Nagumo received something.

[Nagumo, I’ve gotten in the way of Koenji’s event three times in a row. Please give me your next instructions.]

The cheerful voice of a certain 3rd-year student could be heard.

Their strategy to obstruct Koenji seemed to be going well.

Nagumo didn't react to that voice at all and just stared at me.

[Hey, Nagumo, if you don't give instructions, your subordinates can't act. In order to drop Koenji down to 2nd, isn't it necessary to continue with the attack until the end?]

"You sure you're okay with not answering that?"

Hearing those words, it was clear that this should be important to Nagumo.

Nagumo silently picked up the receiver and then switched the power off.

"What's important to me isn't Koenji."

Without even brushing the dirt off his body, Nagumo walked over.

"I will defeat you completely. This is my last job as the student council president."

Letting his emotions affect his decisions? The student council president steeled his resolve, shrugging off the pressure coming from my side.

"I...!?"

I punched Nagumo in the chest without hesitation.

"Ah, you...!!!"

In a flash, he was unable to breath, and fell to the ground, seemingly having lost his consciousness.

I caught Nagumo, and let him lean under a tree in the shade.

Since he didn't listen to my clumsy advice, this would be the only way to deal with it on this occasion.

Nagumo's watch probably detected his abnormal status, and sounded the warning alarm, which rang for 5 seconds.

It shouldn't be long until he woke up.

20 or 30 minutes.

No matter what, Nagumo wouldn't get involved with what came after this. Of course, other problems would inevitably arise after this uninhabited island exam was over. But right now, this was but a trivial matter.

If I didn't solve the issue of Tsukishiro, I wouldn't be able to open a path to the road of the future.

Part 3

On the last day of the exam.

It was after 10:00 a.m., and I, Horikita Suzune, was heading north along the border between I4 and I3, with I2 being my destination. This was the last day of the special exam, and so I was about to use up the remainder of my strength. Fortunately, at least until 12:00 a.m. last night, no group in Class 2-D had fallen into the bottom 10.

The bottom 5 groups in the expulsion range were all 3rd years.

But we still couldn't relax now. At the end of the day, if those 5 groups merged with other groups, scores were bound to go up, and rankings might change. In that case, it'd be inevitable for them to switch rankings with the groups in 6th or 7th place. In the extreme case, if the bottom 10 groups all merged with top groups, then all 10 of them may be able to get out of their current predicament.

The tablet showed my assigned region as I7. The exact opposite of I2, where I was headed.

This was because I would be ignoring the designated area that I should be going to.

Why would I do that? The answer to that was written on a piece of paper I was holding on my right hand. It was folded up and I found it this morning when I woke up in my tent.

When I opened it up, the words “Noon”, “K.A”, “Expelled”, and “I2” were written on it randomly.

When I first saw these words, two things came to mind.

First, the person who wrote this had such beautiful handwriting that I could use as a model.

Secondly, the paper and pen were not part of the freely distributed items.

“How many points would I need for this notebook and pen…”

Although I vaguely remembered it in the uninhabited island exam manual, I judged it to be worthless then, so I didn’t remember the exact price. If the tablet ran out of power, or malfunctioned suddenly, you might need to take notes. Basically, some random person bought this notebook, and sent this somewhat coded message.

“No, it’s too simple to call this coded.”

I2 referred to an area on the uninhabited island, and noon was the time. Since this was the last day to be able to send a note, this was the 14th day. But what was in here? A mere prank? But this wasn’t the case with the remaining two words.

“Expelled”, and “K.A”. Let’s first pay our attention to the latter.

If the other students had seen this note, they wouldn’t necessarily understand the meaning of it.

I grasped the meaning the moment I saw it. It was the initials of Ayanokouji Kiyotaka.

“If we consider this to be the meaning, then at noon today, Ayanokouji will be expelled at I2…”

I thought this was a joke.

So when the designated area was announced at 7 a.m, I was going to ignore this.

But the fact that Ayanokouji-kun's GPS signal was on E3 made me a bit worried.

However, as time passed, he got closer and closer to I2. Maybe this was more than a joke.

Thinking about it, I decided to use GPS search. If it was a trap to make me use that 1 point, then I have undoubtedly fallen for it.

As a result— Ayanokouji-kun advanced from F3 to G3.

If he went to I2 like this…

Driven by this hunch, I decided to head north in order to confirm this.

After all, he was the target of a bounty. So I couldn't discount the probability that this could be a hint from someone else.

There was still some time before noon, and I didn't know where he had gone.

Of course, this could just be a coincidence, and maybe he had already gone somewhere else.

The urge to use GPS search came over me, but I resisted. My score would have been well in the top 50%, but from here on out, discarding arrival points and events, and using the search function again, that wouldn't be guaranteed. If this was going to be a waste, then it would be better just to head there.

"Ah! Finally caught up! Wait, Horikita!"

As the view gradually opened up, and the river could be seen, this voice came from behind.

"…Why are you here?"

Ibuki appeared, glaring at me, panting.

It wasn't a coincidence. She probably used GPS search.

“Score, show me the score.”

“Wait, what are you on about?”

Suddenly appearing and asking me, her enemy, to show her my score was incomprehensible behavior.

“Didn’t I say? I’m not going to lose to you in this special exam.”

She jabbed her index finger at my eyes.

“There’s no need to confirm it now though? The exam isn’t over yet.”

“After the exam is over, nobody will know if the school will publish all the scores, right?”

“Maybe so. After all, it’s only the top and bottom ranking groups that really matter.”

There was no guarantee that the students would be able to view the rankings of all the groups.

Of course, there was a possibility that they would be made public.

“So, let me confirm it now.”

On the last day, she wanted to decide who’s the winner, who had more points.

“This is so stupid, I can’t believe it… You purposely came here for this, seriously? How many times did you use GPS search?”

“… 3 times. Because you were right next to me, I thought this would be the only time where I could do this.”

The farther the distance, the harder it was to meet up with the person you wanted to find.

It seemed like Ibuki used her GPS search 3 times to get to me here.

“Poor you.”

“I don’t need your sympathy, tell me your score, I’ve got 131 points!”

As if to say, “How about it, I’m strong right?”, Ibuki forcefully declared her score to me.

“Thanks for telling me so casually. But I want to say two things. First, I can’t guarantee that you’re telling me your real score.”

“Huh? Then why don’t you look at it?”

I stopped Ibuki, who was about to take her tablet out of her backpack.

“Second, even if you disclose your real score, I won’t tell you my score.”

“Huh? What did you just say? Are you saying the same thing as that bastard?”

That bastard…? Although a little concerned, I continued on. (it’s ayanokouji)

“Although we’re both 2nd years, we’re enemies. I don’t want to risk leaking information.”

I didn’t think I was in the bottom 10 groups right now.

But, the score might still change, until the end of the end.

Even if it was the last day, the possibility of being tricked by Ibuki-san’s information was not 0.

“I know now. You’re scared after hearing my score? You’re losing, right?”

“As for whether I’m winning or losing, I’m not going to answer that either.”

Although I repeatedly said that I was not going to give her any information, Ibuki said this with a straight face.

“How about you just admit it? Admit that you can’t beat my score.”

“Fine then, just go back to your exam.”

I'll try to just go along with Ibuki, if she's satisfied with that.

"... You're so irritating. Come on, just show me your score!"

"I've conceded defeat, aren't you satisfied?"

"I want to know your real score. I want to know by how big of a margin I beat you."

"How dull..."

"It's important to me."

"Sorry, I'm in a hurry."

"Are you running away?"

"I'm rushing to get to my designated area, so it would be a bit strange to describe it as running away."

I was hurriedly rushing to I2.

Probably thinking I was running away, Ibuki followed closely behind.

"Do you have a designated area in the north? Or are you just chasing me?"

"What I want to know now is your score. If I know that, I will go back to my designated area too."

She was dead set on following me.

Being trapped here like this was honestly pretty bad.

I was already being led by the nose by a piece of paper, and I didn't want to waste time.

"...I lost to you."

"Ah, admit it? You finally admit to losing?"

“No, I mean I lost to your persistence. My score is 145 points. It’s a pity that even though you came here in person, I still win.”

Bringing that out into the open, that information that was supposed to be hidden.

That’s the reason I declared it my loss.

“You won against me? If you won, give me proof, proof.”

Of course it would turn into this.

But I was not going to stop.

To confirm his safety, I wanted to go to I2 as soon as possible.

“—I know.”

This should be the most efficient… No, I don’t think it was the right choice.

Even if I let Ibuki know my score on the last day of the exam, it wouldn’t make much of a difference, right? But every minute was precious now.

Putting down my backpack, I reached for the tablet that was placed in an accessible area inside.

Ibuki was waiting with a serious face to see my score.

Just as I took out the tablet and was about to press the power button, Ibuki and I raised our heads almost at the same time as we felt the unmasked intensity of the scent in front of us.

“Found you.”

It was an innocent voice, like a child meeting their playmate.

“Hello, Horikita-senpai!”

Seeing the female student who appeared at some point, Ibuki unabashedly expressed her displeasure.

“…Who are you?”

“Class 1-A’s Amasawa Ichika.”

Although it was possible that she appeared here by chance, it was strange.

Keeping my guard up, holding my tablet, I gave Amasawa a look.

Considering the matter of the bounty for the 1st years and what was written on the paper— could it be her?

“You guys don’t need to mind me, just continue doing your own thing, okay~~?”

“That’s not okay, we’re talking about something personal.”

I wanted to tell Amasawa about my reluctance to reveal the score to her, and Ibuki understood it fully. If I showed my score on my tablet here, Ibuki would also understand that this wasn’t the time to decide who the winner and loser was, right?

I wanted to politely urge her to leave, but Amasawa didn’t budge.

Perhaps impatient from watching, Ibuki said something.

“You’re a nuisance.”

“Is Sudo-senpai okay? Horikita-senpai.”

“Huh? Ignoring me?”

There was no way Amasawa didn’t hear Ibuki’s question, but she ignored her.

She put her backpack down and twisted her shoulders around, as if she wouldn’t be leaving anytime soon.

“….Well, thanks for saving him, I’m grateful.”

She smiled faintly, with no intention of apologizing at all.

Did she feel there was no need to apologize to me for the way she treated Ayanokouji-kun, and the things she did?

Or was it a general premise that she didn't feel bad for what she did?

"Didn't I say that you're a nuisance? I have business with her, so get out of here."

"Business? Didn't Ibuki-senpai run over here without permission?"

It was almost as if she had heard of our conversation from a while back.

Maybe that was true.

"Even if that's the case, it's still fine."

"Nuisance, go away". Ibuki's tone hardened.

If this continued, Ibuki might make a move.

Even after being threatened like that, Amasawa just laughed, amused.

"What's your purpose, Amasawa-san?"

I temporarily let my attention off Ibuki, and turned it to Amasawa.

Although I didn't want to waste any more time, this couldn't be helped.

"Fine."

Although Ibuki was impatient, she waited for me anyway.

"I want to ask you a question. Where are you going, Horikita-senpai?"

"Right now, I'm standing and chatting with Ibuki-san, so when I finish with her, I'll immediately rush to F3."

That's a lie. I was going to give up on going to my designated area.

However, it wouldn't do any good to tell Amasawa that.

She was colluding with the other 1st years, discussing a plan to get him expelled in order to get the bounty for it.

It's best not to say anything unnecessary about Ayanokouji-kun.

Although that was what I thought, I soon realized that it wouldn't work.

"It's not good to lie, Horikita-senpai! Your designated area isn't in this direction right?"

"What do you mean? Are you trying to make me fall into a trap using strange methods?""

"Misleading is useless though. The designated area you were supposed to go to is I7, isn't it?"

The designated area that Amasawa immediately responded with was undoubtedly the correct answer.

This wouldn't make sense if it were a mere coincidence.

Judging from her expression, I can only assume that she was trying to find me from the start.

"We 2nd years have a way of fighting as 2nd years, and so not everything can be told as it is."

Saying that, I continued.

"Isn't it a given to be wary of the people trying to frame Ayanokouji-kun?"

It was necessary to switch the subject smoothly here.

Since the 1st years were enemies, there was no need to act timid.

“Oh, so that’s it. Perhaps.”

Saying that, I didn’t actually feel as if my words had reached her ears.

At this time, her attitude made it seem like she had already reached a conclusion.

“Where are you planning to go, Horikita-senpai? It’s not I2, is it?”

It seems, that this was going in a bad direction, I thought.

“You’ve seen through a lot, huh. But I decided to go to I2 because of what happened this morning. You’re really observant, aren’t you?”

Even if she used GPS search to accurately observe my location, it would be impossible to get a head start like this.

If that’s the case, the piece of paper I got today should be related to Amasawa.

I hesitated to ask a question about this, as Ibuki walked away/

“Are you guys ever going to stop talking?”

I felt a similar kind of anxious feeling.

If this continued, the time spent replying to Amasawa will make me even more impatient than Ibuki.

“Ibuki-san.”

I mentally prepared myself to divulge the information, opening the tablet and showing Ibuki my score. In any case, it’s possible to see the score and the 3 boxes to add members, but I wasn’t going to end up using it anymore, so there was no real harm.

To her, it didn’t matter what the maximum number of members of the group was.

The moment she saw the score, Ibuki clicked her tongue.

Scratching her head, she translated her fretful mood into words.

“Ah, seriously? Well that sucks.”

It was a brutal response to her efforts over the last two weeks.

Although, I thought that Ibuki had worked hard.

It was an admirable result for her, with a low learning ability, to compete with me.

“If you’re satisfied now, go along to your designated area. On the last day, the score you’ll get is twice as high, so you still have a chance to bounce back.”

“Yeah, but… What do you mean by abandoning the designated area?”

Perhaps a little concerned with what Amasawa had said, she asked.

“Ibuki, this is a great opportunity. I’m in a state where I can’t score right now.”

From the start, I didn’t need to explain it for her to understand. I told her using my eyes.

“Indeed, the winner and loser will be decided at the end of this uninhabited island exam. If you say you’re going to stop now, I won’t hesitate to make a comeback for good.”

Ibuki froze up for a second, and then seemed to accept it, turning away.

Me and Ibuki separated then.

As I put my tablet back into the backpack, I thought of how I would respond to Amasawa.

“I’m going to I2 now, what are you going to do?”

“Why are you going to such an irrelevant area as I2? There’s not even an event there. Is this something you should be doing during a special exam?”

“Don’t tell me you don’t know why?”

“What do you mean?”

“Don’t play dumb, what’s the purpose in throwing this piece of paper in the tent when I was asleep?”

I held the small piece of folded paper between the thumb and the forefinger of my left hand, and handed it to her.

“…Paper? Is that for me?”

Acting like this is some sort of monkey show. The paper was no longer useful anyway.

I handed it to her, the one who I thought was the original owner.

Amasawa took the letter, and opened it up to confirm the contents.

“It’s a string of irregularly arranged words… “Noon”, “K.A”, “Expelled”, “I2”.

Reading it once more, then closing her eyes.

“I really hate… how you like to play games, even to this extent…”

“Games? What are you planning to involve me and Ayanokouji-kun in?”

“This, I don’t know. Because I’m just one of the bystanders, just like you.”

“Don’t misunderstand. You appearing in front of me is the best proof that you wrote this.”

Amasawa flashed a difficult smile, and tore the paper to bits.

Tearing it 7 or 8 times, shredding it, throwing it away.

“Looking at those 4 words, what kind of bad feeling are you experiencing?”

“Ayanokouji may be expelled. It’s not hard to understand it like that.”

“Well-“

Her tone seemed to be clearer than mine.

Anyway, playing word games with her again was a waste of time.

I put my backpack on, and walked towards her.

“What a bummer. You obviously don’t know anything about Ayanokouji-senpai. You’re just acting like his partner because you’re in the same class.”

When I reached her, Amasawa uttered that.

“About Ayanokouji-senpai’s situation. You don’t know anything about that, right, Horikita-senpai?”

I stopped in my tracks, as I cared about what was just said.

“So, are you saying that you know him better than I do?”

I looked over at her. She stiffened up and met my eyes for a moment, smiling smugly.

“That’s right. I know Ayanokouji-senpai very well. Why is he so handsome, so smart… and so much stronger than anyone else?”

I didn’t think a 1st year who just started school would know Ayanokouji well.

So, they knew each other before highschool?

Just like how Kushida and I were in the same middle school?

Amasawa continued, unconcerned.

“Then, what do you know, Horikita-senpai?”

What did I know?

In this school, he….Ayanokouji was my first…friend.

That’s right, he could be considered a friend.

We talked a lot because our seats were right next to each other…

At first, I thought he was just an average student, but he was actually much smarter than I thought.

He was recognized by my brother early on, and his fighting ability was good.

But he usually always hid that part of himself, wanting to live a quiet life on campus.

Very few people knew about his strength, but other than that, there's no much difference in the information that others had on him.

"Yeah, it's true. I probably know nothing about him. I can't deny that."

Thinking about Ayanokouji-kun again, it was natural that I came to that conclusion.

Maybe Amasawa was well aware of that.

Hearing those words that could be interpreted as a declaration of defeat, Amasawa smiled happily.

"But…"

"But?"

That wasn't the point.

I thought that it didn't matter how much I knew about him right now.

"from now until graduation, I want to continue understanding him better, as my classmate… As a friend, more than you are now."

That was my wish now, free of lies.

I have been helped by him more than once.

He was an indispensable person to the class, an important comrade who we can't do without.

If he was in a dangerous situation right now, it would be impossible for me not to run to his side now.

That was the reason why I was going to give up on my designated area, and run there.

Now, I realized once again what I had to do.

There was nothing wrong with this choice.

It would have been better if it were just me worrying about nothing.

“Do you think you can help? Horikita-senpai.”

“Maybe I’m not strong enough right now, but I intend to help him when he’s in trouble.”

After all, my school life had just taken a turn for the worse.

This conversation, which at first I considered a waste of my time, might have a great meaning within.

I must thank her for making me realize this.

I was about to walk away when Amasawa stretched her right hand out and blocked me.

Seeing her face again, her smile had disappeared, and she looked at me with an intense killing intent.

“There’s something I got out of our conversation. Something’s gonna happen at I2. Otherwise, you wouldn’t try so hard to stop me here.”

I couldn’t waste any more time here.

“Where are you going?”

“Don’t you understand? I’m going to I2 to help Ayanokouji-kun.”

This was the first step for me to become an existence that could help him when he was in trouble, as I said earlier.

“Don’t kid me, how could Ayanokouji-senpai need your help?”

She said this, as if to correct what I said.

“That’s true, at least for now.”

“So you’re saying that it’ll be different in the future?”

I nodded, and gave her a look.

“One more thing, I learned that you genuinely don’t want me to go to I2, which means you’re not the one who wrote that.”

I tried to walk past her right hand, avoiding it, but once again, Amasawa got in the way.

“I can’t let you go over there, Horikita-senpai.”

“The more you try to stop me, the more I must go to I2. From your tone of voice, shouldn’t he be having a hard time now?”

This has nothing to do with how much I knew about the situation.

It was obvious that something was happening around Ayanokouji-kun right now, of that I can be sure.

“Do you think you get past me?”

“Yes, I do think I can get past you.”

Even if I had to forcefully clear the obstacle in front of me now.

“Well~ Your determination has been conveyed to me. I’ll only wait until you put your backpack down.”

In other words, she was going to overpower me with force.

I didn’t think this was just a verbal threat.

I accepted that, honestly, and slowly put my backpack down by my feet.

“Let me tell you something first. I have experience with martial arts.”

“I already knew that.”

“…Ah, you really are an information warrior.”

Not just about Ayanokouji, but she also understood me.

“Let me also say right now that I’m super powerful, so you better keep that in mind.”

From the moment she unleashed her anger on me, I could tell firsthand that she was no ordinary student.

That must not have been a lie.

The fatigue from the uninhabited island exam has accumulated.

Even the Amasawa in front of me is the same.

There didn’t seem to be anything wrong with her body, so as far as physical state, it can be said that we were evenly matched.

In that case, I wouldn’t be defeated so easily.

I slowly got into my stance, watching Amasawa’s movement in front of me.

She didn’t go into a particular stance, instead opting for a strange expression.

“Since you said you’re going to meet up with Ayanokouji-senpai, I’ll play with you for a bit.”

Amasawa’s left foot left the ground.

“Huh?!”

I was obviously on guard, but I felt the danger immediately, and jumped backwards. Her extended arm didn't have any force behind it, maybe she wanted to grab me.

I needed to avoid the first blow, that was what I thought. But the moment I returned to my senses, she had already grabbed my shirt near my chest.

"Impossible..."

As I muttered those words, I felt my vision turning around in a circle.

It was only after feeling the pain in my back that I had realized that I had been hit with a body throw, landing on my back

"What's impossible, huh?"

"Kgh-!"

It hurt so much that I couldn't breathe, as I spit out the air within me.

"Oh no, you can't take this lightly. Okay, I'll give you some time to recover, stand up."

Amasawa looked down at me with an evil grin on her face.

I didn't need to elaborate on how humiliating this was.

It only took one encounter with her to fully understand that Amasawa was extremely strong.

It was reasonable to say that even if there was a difference in strength, it would only be a small one, as we were both girls.

Hard work, resourcefulness, agility, luck. With those elements, it would be possible to beat her.

But I was probably too naive in thinking that.

Anyway, the damage to my back wasn't light, it was enough to make the average person yield straight away.

Fortunately, there was dirt beneath me, but it still took some time to recover from the damage.

If my opponent prided herself on being in a position of absolute superiority, then I had to use that. I decided to stand up by taking a few dozen seconds for each step of the way.

“I’ll wait for you, don’t worry. It’s okay to take a 5 or 10 minute break just like that.”

“I’ll do that, as long as your motive isn’t to stop me from going to Ayanokouji-kun.”

“It’s best to give up with the fighting, right? At least for you, Horikita-senpai.”

That was true. If I started a fight in the final stages of the uninhabited island exam that had been going smoothly until now, it might be bad enough for me to withdraw from the exam, or maybe I’ll even be expelled.

“….Again.”

When the pain in my back had almost disappeared, I once again assumed a fighting stance.

This was the same kind of fighting as earlier.

I merely had insight into martial arts, but I’m not very good at fighting.

I can only play to what I have learned, and unleash my strength like that.

The speed of Amasawa’s movements was surprising, but if she was just good at Judo, I had some ideas. There was once a karate teacher who taught me what to do if a boy grabbed a girl, pushing her down.

As I recalled that in my brain, I practiced the moves in my brain.

It would be dangerous, but if the other person was Amasawa, there would be nothing to worry about.

Give up on the fact that she was younger than me, and convert it to the mood similar of fighting with a master.

“Yahahahah!”

What I noticed was not Amasawa’s face, but the subtle movements of her feet, and shoulders. She seemed to find this amusing, and laughed out loud.

“Uhuh, I get it, Horikita-senpai, I do understand how you feel. Buuuuuuuut~?!”

I couldn’t play word games with her.

Now, I needed to give my full attention to see through her moves–

I realized after an attack and pain that I had managed to deal with her right foot, but the left foot approaching me at high speeds hit me directly above the side of my abdomen.

“Ah!”

Close to tears from the pain, I was kicked to the ground.

My arm didn’t have the time to defend myself, as I was kicked in the body. I rolled twice or thrice on the ground, threw into confusion, even though I knew what just happened.

“You thought I just used judo, didn’t you? That’s too naive of you.”

“Huff, hu….huuu….!”

As I subconsciously pressed on the right rib that was kicked, I closed my eyes.

The pain was so intense that my heart instantly surrendered to it.

This was the second time where I had felt such desperate pain.

Since the confrontation with Housen-kun…

That was something that happened only recently, and if this kind of thing would happen regularly, it would make me lose confidence.

“The 1st years this year, they aren’t cute at all…”

“So you’re saying that last year’s Horikita-senpai was a cute kid, unlike me?”

Although I thought she asked the question trying to be mean, it still stung.

Although we were different types, her uncuteness was comparable to me.

I tried to stand up, but when I tried using my leg, there was a sudden feeling of disengagement.

Because of the body slam and the kick, my strength was slashed beyond imagination.

“Who are you? You seem to know the Ayanokouji-kun in the past…”

One thing was certain. Amasawa had incredible strength, just like him.

When he fought against my brother, and when he fought against Housen-kun, Ayanokouji-kun showed us his true strength.

“How do you expect me to tell you about these things, senpai?”

“True, you don’t seem like the kind of person who would respond honestly to that.”

In any case, her willingness to match me in delaying the fight was one of the few pieces of good news I had.

Her objective was to block my way to Ayanokoouji. It didn’t seem to matter how much time she took. In order to move forward, I had to let the damage to my back recover a bit.

“How should I say this? You really are a disappointment. You aren’t as good as I thought you are, Horikita-senpai. It’s because of this that Ayanokouji-senpai didn’t seek your help.”

Amasawa’s eyes gazed at me, as if she were peering straight into my heart.

“When you say you want to help him, it actually is to find out what Ayanokouij-senpai thinks about how you aren’t being trusted by him.”

“…Maybe so.”

“I also just said, Horikita-senpai, you aren’t worthy for Ayanokouji-senpai to rely on.”

“Even so, this shouldn’t come from your mouth, but his.”

“Do you know what I mean by that?”

She didn’t hide her agitation, and walked over to me.

“Still, even Kushida-senpai is more discerning.”

“Kushida-san? Why did you say her name?”

“Stand up, Horikita-senpai. I no longer want to talk to you. It’s annoying me. So let’s end this.”

At least she gave me a sort of mercy, as she gave me the time to get back to my feet.

But, even I couldn’t give up on the fight until the end.

Mercy was shown, to say the least, as she gave me the time to get me back on my feet.

Then, even I, in the end, could not give up on this fight.

Standing up, I focused everything into seeing Amasawa’s attacks clearly.

Again, as this was all that I could do. There was no other way.

“Alrighty!”

Amasawa ran over, with a brisk pace.

Defend? Evade? Neither would work, surely.

In that case, I’ll try and get my revenge–!

Boom! The sound of a fist rang in my ears.

But there was no pain. A figure appeared in front of me, blocking my view.

“You, why….”

A student grabbed the fist in front of me, and said, without turning around.

The short figure’s back belonged to Ibuki, who was supposed to have left.

“Ahah…. Do you call that fighting?”

“Good catch~ You startled me, with that slightly unexpected entrance.”

I hadn’t understood the situation yet, my body still couldn’t move, and Ibuki, who turned around, glared at me.

“The one who beat you is me, and so I don’t want you losing to some first year I don’t know in front of me.”

She said, releasing a tightly clenched fist. Once away, Amasawa pulled away.

“I’m Amasawa Ichika. Please remember my name, Ibuki-senpai.”

“I’ve got a bad memory. If you want me to remember, you’d better impress me a little, yeah?”

“Ahaha, that seems a little interesting.”

“I’ll have fun with her, so you go where you want to go.”

“What are you talking about? You worked hard in this special exam just to beat me, right?”

“Aren’t you going to give up on the designated area as well? In that case, even if I comeback and get the W, there’s no point in it.

[Is that the sort of thing you came back for?] I swallowed those words back.

“She’s incredibly powerful. You might regret it later, is that okay?”

“What? Are you saying that I’ll lose?”

“She’s a formidable opponent.”

“I don’t see me losing to Ibuki-senpai at all.”

“…Huh, isn’t that great?”

My clumsy warning seemed to backfire, instead igniting Ibuki’s emotions.

“Even if you defeat Amasawa, if you go too far, or raise an emergency alarm, you’ll likely be withdrawn from the exam. You might even be expelled by yourself.”

“You’re the same, right?”

“Ah? Well, yeah.”

“I have faith that I’m stronger.”

Saying this, she waved her hand at me, indicating that I should leave quickly.

“Who’s going to fight? Hurry up and decide~~”

“I will fight her.”

“You really saying that? The person who just almost lost? You’re going to be a hindrance, back off.”

“This is my fight. It’s none of your business.”

“Talking about how strong your opponent is and now you’re messing around like this? Did you bang your head or something?”

That’s—”

No, there was no way to stop Ibuki with such a half-hearted statement. But I can’t just leave this to her now.

I grabbed Ibuki's shoulder, and forced her to back up.

"What the hell!"

"I've thought about it, and if you ask me, you can't win against her."

"Stop joking around. Don't decide before it even happens."

"That's the truth. I couldn't do anything, so there's no way you can win against her."

Since she was already angry, I'll just ignite the flames of her rage till the very end.

"Then prove it, right here in front of me…."

I stretched my left hand out to Ibuki.

"What for?"

"If you don't want to lose, if you want to break this stalemate, show me your resolve. Form a group with me. If something happens to one of us and have to withdraw, the group will still survive. That's the only way to effectively prevent the withdrawal."

"Are you kidding me? Why would I form a group with someone like you?"

"Didn't I just say? I need you to come to an understanding. If you haven't yet, then don't join this fight."

"So annoying…"

"It's alright if you don't like it, but I'd like to rely on you if you're going to join the fight."

"This sucks. But it wouldn't be much fun if you'll be forced to drop out because of some 1st years."

Although we both knew that our minds were completely incompatible with each other.

But, each of our watches were crossed in an overlapping position.



10 seconds was needed to complete the formation of the group.

Amasawa would be able to stop it if she wanted to, but she showed no sign of taking action.

Amasawa looked down on our side, in a god-like manner, seemingly enjoying it.

“It’s not a bad strategy. If separate students form a group, it’s true that if something happens to one of them, they can still avoid being expelled.”

Amasawa turned her back to us, quietly keeping her distance.

This 2 vs 1 situation didn’t make her feel any sense of danger.

After moving some distance away, she stopped, looking back our way.

“But there’s just one thing you thought incorrectly, Horikita-senpai.”

“Incorrect? What exactly do you mean?”

“It’s alright for one person to withdraw, which means, it’s okay for me to break one of you.”

She showed a smile I had never seen before, a smile of pure evil.

“Made you angry, huh? Isn’t that great?”

Ibuki had directly felt the opponent’s power, but acted happy.

At that moment, the signal of the end of group formation sounded.

“So which one should I destroy first—?”

The expression of Amasawa, who ran up to us in one breath, was excited.

She didn’t make any sort of stance, just coming our way, with her hand outstretched.

“Hahahah! Hahahahhahaha!!”

A high-spirited smile emerged on her face, looking too distorted to be human.



Was it me? Or Ibuki?

Although from her perspective, I was the problematic presence, I couldn't assume that it was me who was being targeted.

"Let's go, Ibuki! You go to the left!"

"Don't order me around!"

Ibuki said, while moving to the left.

I moved to the right, in order to confirm who Amasawa's target was.

Amasawa, who was running straight towards us, had no intention of playing any tricks.

Not going to let me make a judgement at the last second?

Even then, I could slowly see it clearly.

As both sides took action, the distance was instantly closed, and collided.

Because my fists and Ibuki's could not possibly work in tandem, the timing of our attacks would naturally diverge.

But even so, it would be impossible to respond to it easily.

Nonetheless, Amasawa dodged as easily as if it were training.

We kept attacking, bringing out the most out of our consecutive attacks.

"Alrightly, let's stop for a while."

In response to our consecutive attacks, Amasawa calmly accepted them and stopped us.

"What's going on, this 1st year....!"

"Seriously..."

We stood together, panting, looking at Amasawa in front of us.

Despite her being only a temporary partner, it was still 2 against 1.

If it were a normal situation, we should have been able to overwhelm her, but instead, we were being overwhelmed.

Within the framework of common sense, she was an unrecognizable existence.

It was like a sharp blade pressed right against us. If we did as we pleased here, we might be forced to withdraw.

"Ibuki, don't get too careless."

"Let go of me!"

Perhaps being unable to bear being pinned down, Ibuki used her soft body to show off her kicking ability to the max. As if she were waiting for it, Amasawa grabbed it with her flexible arm to counter, grabbing her.

“Ah!!”

“Didn’t I tell you to stop?”

In that moment, I felt an indescribable sense of uneasiness during this inhibited battle.

There was a clear battle gap. Was Amasawa engaging in this battle like a game?

It looked like she was fighting using minimal movements just now.

It was the same when fighting with me one-on-one. What if she wasn’t just waiting for me to recover?

But this can’t be considered the right answer.

With her power she could easily suppress us both.

I came up with a strategy that I wanted to try.

But first, we had to break out of this situation.

“Ha!”

I swung my left fist at Amasawa’s side, but she easily avoided it, just like she avoided Ibuki.

“Okay, let’s start over.”

Amasawa looked down at us with a slight smile, and pulled away once more.

“Aren’t you the same as me?”

“I’m not like you, I went for it knowing that it would turn out that way… In order to reassess my strategy.”

“Excuses, how lame.”

Probably anyone would say the same about me if they looked only at our current situation.

“Since you don’t believe me, I’ll tell you.”

She climbed up, so I grabbed Ibuki’s arm to stop her from acting alone.

“What are you doing?”

“Now that you’re my partner, follow my instructions. You can do that, right?”

“Huh? Impossible.”

“If you don’t then there’s no point. You should understand how strong Amasawa-san is. Neither you or I cannot beat her alone.”

“Even if that’s the case, I won’t follow your instructions.”

I was thinking.

What’s the best way to deal with Ibuki?

If Ayanokouji-kun was here, in the same situation as I was, what would he do?

How should I get us two, who didn’t get along well, to work together in this situation?

“Ibuki-san.”

“Didn’t I tell you that I don’t want to?”

“I am aware that our relationship is like water and oil. Although it turned into this due to the dispute we had in last year’s uninhabited island exam, there’s one thing that I approve of you.”

Yes, that’s what I needed to do now, without hesitation.

“Your fighting sense is comparable to me. No, I think you are slightly better than me.”

“Huh, so sudden. So you gonna admit losing?”

“However, your fighting style is specialized for one-on-one fights, and I am more familiar with how to fight with strong opponents two-on-one. The word cooperation may be unsuited for you, but lend me your strength.”

After listening to those words, for a moment Ibuki looked at me..

“You are equal or stronger than me in terms of fighting, but that’s it. In other areas, we are not on the same level. You are not good at academics, you can’t lead your class, and you can’t cooperate with others. I don’t want to be mean, but calling yourself my rival is just you being narcissistic.”

Although the words may make her angry, I would not stop talking.

“It’s about time for you to change yourself as well, isn’t it? Mio Ibuki-san.”

“…What was that all about?”

“If you keep fighting alone like this, you will surely be in danger of expulsion at some point.”

“Not a big deal, if that happens.”

“Which means it’ll be your complete loss to me. Is that fine?”

“Huh?”

“If you get expelled halfway, you can’t be considered my rival. You need to persist til the very end, and grow into a rival that can pose a threat to me.”

“Arghh, I know, I know, so shut up. I will only listen to you here. That’s enough, right?”

“Good.”

“So, what should I do?”

“Like before, we attack Amasawa-san at the same time. However, actually hitting her is of secondary importance. I want you to dodge her attacks, make sure not to get caught, and continue to attack.”

“Hitting her is of secondary importance? What use would that be?”

“If my guess is correct…that will be our chance to win. When I give you the signal, attack with all you’ve got.”

Although Ibuki didn’t quite get it, she still left to assume her position.

” Meeting time ended? Then, why don’t we start the second round?”

We started moving at the same time, heading towards Amasawa from both the left and the right.

In order to not get caught, getting too close to her was forbidden.

I judged the timing to extend my fist, according to the distance of my reach,

Of course, if Amasaka didn’t do anything in response, the attacks would hit her. Therefore, she had to exhaust energy in order to deal with the continuous attacks.

I didn’t rush, stayed calm, and put distance between us when I sensed danger.

If I were alone, I wouldn’t be able to escape. However, now that her attention was split in two directions, this fighting style worked.

Not yet.

Before I got out of breath, faster, faster—!

Due to our dangerous continuous attacks, Amasawa’s movements began to slow down.

Although she was still smiling, she was obviously breathing quicker.

“—Now!!”

In order to not miss this perfect chance, I swung my right fist at Amasawa with all my strength.

She stopped my attacks easily with one hand up until now, but she took a defensive stance.

Although my fist didn't hit her body directly and was blocked by her, Ibuki who moved behind her stomped at the ground, her tightly clenched fist hitting Amasawa, who was turning around to respond, in the face.

An attack hit her for the first time, and Amasawa's body started shaking.

"Ah! Ah!"

I crouched down deep, unleashing a punch on her undefended abdomen.

Spitting out some air, Amasawa went down.

I straddled her body in the next instant, rendering her immobile.

"Ah… That worked really well…"

"Hah, hah…. Heheh, Amasawa…. I'll admit that you're strong, but it seems like your stamina isn't infinite."

I caught her out on this surprising weakness and finally turned the tide.

"Ahhhhh, have I been exposed? My physique is actually unexpectedly weak then."

Despite the situation now having been reversed, she stuck her tongue out, smiling.

As I absentmindedly stared at Amasawa's gym clothes, I couldn't believe my eyes.

Her skin was faintly exposed from underneath her outfit.

I couldn't help but grab her uniform, and forcefully pull it above her navel.

"What is this…"

It was a mark like a bad bruise. You could tell that she had been hit several times already.

It was a completely different kind of damage from the one clean hit that I managed to land.

It was an injury that had been sustained before the fight had begun.

“I just had a fight, before I fought you senpais.”

Normally, in such a situation, her expression would have been distorted in pain, and her walking would have been affected.

And yet, she was still stronger than the two of us in this near crippled state.

She was not without stamina.

From the beginning, she fought, on the verge of collapse.

She was fighting in a condition where she needed more recovery than I did.

This fact made me feel lightheaded.

Someone who faced Amasawa in perfect condition and was able to injure her so much.

Even if I considered the boys, I could only think of Housen-kun.

“Do you want to know who caused it? Could it be Housen-kun—?”

There was no doubt that Housen-kun was strong.

He would be able to gain an advantage even against Amasawa who had unrealistic strength.

However, her personality was easy to understand if you just put a little thought to it. She wouldn’t answer honestly.

In the end, she only offered me one convincing answer that I would accept.

If that's the case—there's someone else that could beat Amasawa?

Even if we considered every student in the school, I couldn't think of someone.

If it was Yamada…. No, he wouldn't gain anything from this.

"Sorry, but I can't believe you. Who is it?"

"That's not something I can answer….. Ah!"

Seeing that I was careless because of the shock, she didn't let this moment pass.

"Oi, what are you doing!"

"…Yeah, I was too careless."

It was clear that this was our only chance, and yet I let Amasawa escape.

"Nice going, we're both back to square one now."

Although our opponent had already taken a lot of damage, the situation has now been reversed again.

Could I overpower her again… Honestly, I wasn't confident.

But that was the only thing I could do.

And now, not knowing what she was thinking, she walked to her backpack and took out her tablet.

"It seems like it's over. It's a bit interesting, but it's going to be a while again."

"What are you talking about?"

"That's that. If you guys want to pass, feel free~~"

Saying that, Amasawa opened up the path that she herself had strongly defended, not letting us pass.

Was this some kind of trap? Before I could grasp the situation, Amasawas was already getting ready to leave.

“Where are you going?”

“Where? Well, to the designated area i guess. After all, there’s still a special exam going on.”

In any case, if she was hear to buy time, I should go and confirm Ayanokouji-kun’s status—

“Ah, by the way, I don’t think you need to go after Ayanokouji-senpai anymore.”

“…Why?”

“It’s all over. If you think I’m lying, go ahead and see for yourself.”

“—What about Ayanokouji-kun?”

Hearing that question, Amasawa closed her eyes slightly.

“Why don’t you go and confirm it yourself? But it might be too late for you to regret it by then, though.”

It seemed like Amasawa really was planning to walk back, passing us.

Could it be that he had been injured by someone?

“What are you going to do? You going to go after Ayanokouji? That’s why you fought with Amasawa, right?”

“Yeah, I’ll go.”

Having already come to this place, it was even more impossible to go back without confirming the situation now.

“Then I’ll go too.”

“Why?”

“I’m thinking, if Ayanokouji’s in danger, I can taunt him next to you.”

“You really are a bad person.”

We hurriedly put on our backpacks and ran towards I2.

Part 4

I had crossed the border to I2, but there was no sign on my watch that I had arrived.
Normally, I would have suspected it was a GPS error, but this time it was unlikely.
So I had to move as close to the center of the zone as possible to compensate for the error of my watch.

Ofcourse I had not experienced such a situation in the last two weeks, and it was probably an unavoidable factor, including the fact that the tip of Island I2 was close to the center. It was designed so that even if Ichinose hadn't come to me, I would have gone to the place.
I walk slowly along the path that does not allow me to escape.

After less than ten minutes of walking, the deep forest gradually began to absorb the light, and I could see the blue sea and blue sky stretching beyond my vision.
Although I had made it this far, my watch was showing no sign. Instead, there were two adults standing on the small beach in front of me, staring at me.

One is a man I know well, Tsukishiro, the Acting Director. He was wearing a sweater, which made him look somewhat out of place. And the other one is Shiba-sensei, the teacher from the freshman class D.
It's a strange combination, but apparently it is.

"You have decided to take a very strong approach, Acting Director Tsukishiro."

I said as I walked to the beach

“I can't seem to do anything about it. This is the best option I can do. "

I look back and saw the last 14 days of this special test. It became clear that Tsukishiro's final trap was luring me to I2. But it is not without its drawbacks.

Since there are no designated or assigned zones around this northeast zone, there would be no other students coming here. But at the same time, there must have been a future where he left the designated area and would have gone for the task. Or a future where he was working with Nanase or someone else in the same box.

It's just a matter of luck, and there's no way Tsukishiro has prepared this final event. It means that long before, my arrival here was already a "predestined" future.

Nanase's defeat to me and going our separate ways. He wanted to act just to make a plan to hide around 11th place targeting higher ranks. The timing and details of the first year's attack I think it's safe to say that the whole thing was planned by Tsukishiro's side from the beginning.

"So what will happen to me after this?"

The small boat in the corner of my field of vision is anchored, rocked by the waves with the engine running.
This means we were ready to go at any time.

"If possible, we would like you to follow our instructions and come on board with us. It would be a way to declare a voluntary withdrawal of Ayanokouji Kiyotaka, it would fit perfectly ”.
I'm sure you'll be glad to hear it, "he added.

"Do you think I would choose to go voluntarily to the ship?"

"Certainly. If you're honest, you didn't have to come to an uninhabited island."

“Not that he had any particular connection to Shiba-sensei at school, but it means that he was on the side of Acting Headmaster Tsukishiro. "

Due to the fact that he had no contact with us, perhaps he was an Amasawa watchdog. Now that that need is gone, it seems like he no longer intends to hide. I'm sure it's a bit

suspicious being in the northeast where there is no one, but Ichinose and Nagumo could also be seen around here. In that sense, it works well as a camouflage.

No, either way, it's safe to assume that the people who are monitoring us are on Tsukishiro's side.
But he doesn't appear to be wearing anything visibly dangerous.

“If I used a weapon or something like that, it would be easy to take control here, but unfortunately, you are a valuable commodity. It is my duty to bring you back safe and sound, so I have decided that what I need is only my fists. "

Standing on the sandy beach, Tsukishiro smiles fearlessly and spreads his hands slightly. So, to resist until the last moment in this place, I have to fight with Tsukishiro. Unlike what happened with Nanase, I don't think my method of evading attacks is going to work.

"So the only way to avoid expulsion is to take it."

"That is what is going to happen"

“ I'm not saying that violence is a bad way to solve a problem, but I am a student at this school. By normal rules, this is a 'foul'. ”

“That may be true. However, Ayanokouji-kun, you are a successful example who has accomplished something special in the White Room. Even if you fight within the limited rules, you will have no enemies. Don't you think it's silly to compete with others in this school? Or have you come to take pleasure in being the king of the mountain? "

“If so, is it an evolution ..... or a regression that would disappoint that man? “

“No, no, it's not like that, is it? The desire of the White Room is to take over Japan and, by extension, the world. If you, the successful body, feel that way, then the growing body will eventually take over the world and enjoy it. "

From a small Japanese institute, the story stretches to take control of the world. If someone heard of such a fantasy, they would most likely laugh. Probably Tsukishiro

himself, who is in front of me, must be very incredulous about how realistic it is. Just trying to do his duty faithfully and without hesitation.

"Well, to tell the truth, I didn't think this school was much."

"I guess so. Because for you, this school level is a path that you went through in your childhood".

“It is only limited to the curriculum. I finally start to have an idea of where I want to be and what I want to do in this school. I know I'm going to have a lot of fun until I graduate, and there are a lot of good people outside of the White Room. "

In fact, I'd say it's a pool of talent that the White Room could never produce.

“I do not intend to denigrate the students of Advanced Nurturing High School. As you say, there are always talented people around the world. Sometimes you are outperformed in sports, sometimes in studies. But the important thing is not that part, but the people who can excel in all situations and lead others. "

Acting Director Tsukishiro gives Shiba a light look.

"What happened to Nagumo-kun and Ichinose-san?"

"Nagumo has stopped moving, and Ichinose has already moved away, so there is nothing to worry about."

I'm sure he must have calculated that I would stop Nagumo and Ichinose.

"So, regarding unplanned actions, Amasawa seems to be blocking the movement."

Unplanned actions? There are no designated zones or problems around this zone.
Was someone other than Ichinose and Nagumo getting closer?
If an unrelated student showed up here, it would be a nuisance to Tsukishiro.

It seems that Amasawa is the one delaying that irregular existence.

"She has been educated in her own way, hasn't she?"

"It did not seem that Amasawa ally with Acting Director Tsukishiro."

"She is, simply," a traitor. " She was the one chosen to bring you back, but she never intended to bring you back. "

As if to say that the useless talk is over, Tsukishiro takes a step forward.
He didn't want to waste time with others. He was reducing the distance between us little by little.
But we were still five or six meters apart from each other.
Shiba-sensei slowly walks behind me to make sure I don't run away.

“You wouldn't call it unfair a two against one, right? After all, you are the best in the White Room. I'm even a little nervous about this. "

That said, there was an overwhelming amount of space for Tsukishiro.
I can sense that he was convinced that he could compete well in a one-on-one, and that he had chosen to have me fight alone against the two of them.
There is no pride in it. It's a rock solid position. I shifted my gaze to the ship waiting on the shore.
From what I can see, the only member of the crew is the pilot.
Which means that if they are launched, I will only have to eliminate a maximum of three enemies.

"Do not worry. It’s only Shiba and I who will fight against you. "

I'm not the type of person who would take your word for it.
He may be carrying a concealed weapon, though he's empty-handed from the way he just spoke.
As I face two adults with unknown abilities, both at agent level, I will have to fight in a cautious manner for the presence of weapons, reinforcements, and other uncertain factors.
Normally doing multiple actions at once would burn my brain, but I don't have to be mentally upset.
Fighting in absurd and disadvantageous situations has been instilled in me repeatedly since I was a child.
It is the same as the process of unconscious breathing that is essential for human life.

"You have a look that says you don't think for a minute that you're going to lose."

"Do you think I have that look?"

There were no visible results of my face anywhere. The only way to open the future is for me to take it here.
I had a situation where I had them in front and back, and waiting to see what will happen.
Normally, I would be inclined to take the first step, but it is not a good idea.
They are not students, the people in front of and behind me are from the school.
If I am the only one raising my hand, I will be at a disadvantage in situations other than fighting.

“Although I know that I will have an advantage, I cannot start it myself. As well as you” Tsukishiro, who has a detailed knowledge of education policy regarding the White Room, discusses it.

"So, let's start at once, Shiba-sensei"

As soon as he said his name, the two adults started walking towards me at the same time. Both were not in a hurry and calmly approach closing the distance as if they were advancing the Shōgi pieces. (It's Japanese chess)

Shiba's presence and footsteps disappeared at the same time as I turned backwards. The distance between Tsukishiro and me, who is walking in front of me, is 7 steps, 6 steps, 5 steps, 4 steps ....

Shiba's two hands came to grab my face from behind, and I ducked a little to avoid them. The first thing he will do is come from behind.

In the middle of the evasive movement, Tsukishiro extends his arm and comes to grab me like Shiba did. I evaded it while rolling down the beach, and made the effort to get up and run at the same time to escape the chase.

The dust danced in the sea breeze. The two adults did not rush to chase me and look at me silently, I am aware of them, as they are of me.
They are trying to measure my ability through concrete movements, from the data that they could not count.

My feet sink into the sand. I guess I should have taken my shoes off earlier if this was going to happen.

Under the hot sun, the two of them go out to close the distance they had parted again.
Observing the face and body of the two, I keep a distance backing up at the same pace.

With my back to the sea, I am going to move away from the soft sand and secure myself towards a foothold, while avoiding being turned over.

"It's a good idea, but I'm not sure it's the correct solution Ayanokouji-kun."

They won't be able to take my back, but they will narrow my escape route.
If I go lower, the waves will hit my legs, and that's where Tsukishiro and Shiba will come in.
The outstretched arm keeps trying to grab my body. They still don't mean to hurt me with their blows.

"You're good at running away."

They both move very fast, and the space to avoid them is suddenly taken from me.
After dropping to the very edge of the water, I couldn't take it anymore and ran away.

"Oh? Have you given up on the sea protecting your back?"

It's easier to provoke your opponent to make mistakes if he's in a hurry. While I was thinking about it, Shiba and Tsukishiro were kicking the sand and heading towards me.

Now that it's two against one, and if any of them catch me, then it's game over.
Four arms are extended in each other's place, and if you show the slightest gap, the situation will end.

I started running and trying to distance myself, but they weren't going to let me go and started chasing me.
Running in a place like this will only continue to drain my stamina.
It is clear that they intend to take away the resistance with the heat and the bad points of support.

I had to make a choice. I abandoned my flight movement in the middle of the day, and making the most of my body's spring, I stepped forward with my left foot, stepped on the sand, and turned to attack Shiba, who was right behind me.

"Mwah !?

Shiba's movement stiffened slightly due to my movement, which showed an unexpected trajectory.

I feinted with the left fist aiming for the chest on the right, but sensing the danger, Shiba didn't panic and kept his distance.
It's a sign that he's more concerned with avoiding me rather than catching me.

"Well ..... you've been doing an excellent job facing the two of us, Ayanokouji-kun."

He tried to defend me, dodging attacks from both sides, but I can't get a clean hit.

"But human strength is limited. Isn't it time you started to catch your breath?"

"Acting Director Tsukishiro, is a difficult opponent to fight."

"My job is to take the initiative and do what people don't want to do."

There is nothing clean or dirty, just a fighting style that aims to capture me and take me home.
But he wasn't wasting stamina for nothing, either. What I have won so far. There seems to be a slight combat ability between Tsukishiro and Shiba.

Tsukishiro is said to have a score of 4 while Shiba has a score of 6, and I have learned that Shiba has better movement. My intuition tells me that Tsukishiro is above.
Anyway, the balance to be attentive is slightly changed from 5 to 5 (It refers to the score of 10 put as half and half).

He had always thought that he left his back at least capable, that is, Shiba, but it was the other way around. This is their way of fighting.
It's tempting to start with the least capable, Tsukishiro, but even so, his ability is far from the truth.

It is in a higher dimension, it is not easy to end it. In fact, if he realizes that I have completed my analysis, there is a possibility that Tsukishiro will become aware of his defenses.

I'll take down Shiba in one hit, without letting him realize that I have noticed the difference in his abilities.

In simple terms, a shot is fired in one shot with the intention of hitting the other. The other side hasn't thought of hitting me yet, so now is my chance.
If I am lucky it will be the only thing that can inflict one-sided damage.
And after neutralizing Shiba, I'll quickly deal with Tsukishiro in a one-on-one I have a second to think. While they both attack me at the same speed.

But the fist that looked like it was going to grab him clenched and turned into a blow. It was read.
The aim of the damage exchange is to be read, if I keep shooting like this, they will both eat me. Even so, I'm going to have to get over them.

I tried to turn my consciousness to trade damage with Shiba behind me, but something unexpected happened. I felt a cold mark on my neck and was forced to interrupt the counterattack.
I don't know how many times I've had to take evasive action to get away from Tsukishiro

The sound of Shiba's fist, balanced with a slight delay, reaches my ears dryly. If I wasn't good at damage exchange, it could have stopped me in my tracks. Shiba's strike definitely has the same power as mine.
It is not more than that....

I looked at Tsukishiro's movements, which should be inferior to Shiba's, but they were both faster than I had expected.

"..... You are still a complicated person, Acting Director Tsukishiro."

I avoided it just in time, and for the first time in years, I break out in a cold sweat in a fight.
If I hadn't trusted my instincts, I don't know what I would have done.
Not only would I have been hit by Shiba's blow, but I could have been left unprotected by Tsukishiro's attack.
Tsukishiro's reading that it is 4, and Shiba 6 is itself false information created by the other party.
They intentionally save their abilities and then attack above your alert level.

"I would have killed you now, but your reaction time is not normal."

Perhaps, it is convenient not to rule out that possibility.
It is not natural that the Tsukishiro in front of me is inferior in skill to Shiba. I'd say that was the only thing that helped raise my guard to the limit.
They are both cautious and do not risk as much as they can, but they do not hesitate to take risks if they think it will be to their advantage.

I guess the situation is a bit disadvantageous for me.
Even if you try to crush one of them first, it's going to cover at the perfect time, making it difficult for me to hit them with a proper attack. It's hard to believe that they got together overnight.

“How is your analysis going? Ayanokouji-kun "

The fight has only lasted a little over two minutes. I have already tried several different patterns, but none of them are convincing.

“It would have been easier if it was like a children's fight, purely fighting and fighting only with our strength and power. But we adults do not hesitate to take the best measures not to lose, even if it is something dirty, and it is not something well seen. "

Tsukishiro has also read 99% of my thoughts. It is a very accurate way to fight without hesitation, but at the same time, it does not allow you to read your own thoughts.
I'm sure you'll agree that it's a great idea. Anyway, in the current situation, a decisive blow is missing. It seems that I will also have to risk a lot if I want to stay in the game.

"Acting Director Tsukishiro"

The one who broke the silence was Shiba, who had kept his mouth shut until that moment. Immediately after his name was spoken, Tsukishiro seemed to have noticed a strange change.
It was something that no one here had expected.

“I wonder what the Acting Director and the classroom teacher do with a student in such a deserted place. What are they doing? I would love to hear about it”.

She was an unwelcome visitor.

"I'm pretty sure you are...."

“She is Kiryuuin Fuka from Third year group B ”.

Why the hell was she here? I thought I was the only one that had this I2 designated as a designated zone.

"You don't look like a lost kitten. What can I do for you?"

After abandoning his fighting stance, Tsukishiro asks in his usual tone.

“Actually, I've been watching you from behind the big tree for a while, but I couldn't take the two-on-one situation. That is why I have appeared here. "

Of course, it was impossible that Tsukishiro and Shiba hadn't seen the GPS signal.

“Could this be the cause? It seems that an accident caused my watch to fail.”

Kiryuuin laughs and shows a watch that has been smashed on the surface.

“Let me ask you this, since we have people from the school in front of us, there is nothing wrong with it, right? Even if my watch breaks, only the scoring function will be disabled. I am free to go wherever I want ”.

"No problem, Anyway, it is a test in which the clocks are constantly breaking."

Tsukishiro doesn't seem to be bothered by the irregular existence in this place. Normally you should withdraw if a student sees you in these kinds of situations. However, Tsukishiro understands that this is the last place he can do it, so he won't back down. Kiryuuin was likely listed for elimination.

"Ayanokouji, were my actions unnecessary?"

If you have seen the distorted battle between teachers and a student, there is no point in repairing it.
I prefer to make the most of this accident that has occurred.

“That depends on what happens next. Am I correct in assuming that you will give me a hand? "

"Of course. As your senpai, shouldn't it be normal for me to protect my kouhai? " She said that and stood next to me, and laughed.

"But how did you get here?"

“Yesterday, you were running away from the first-year students. I was curious and wanted to ask you, but I figured you'd rather run away. "

“So you went to the trouble of breaking your watch so it wouldn't know you were coming.”

"I am glad that you have piqued my curiosity. For this reason, I have been invited to a very interesting development."

Well, it is not a development that would normally be possible.

"Shiba-sensei, I'll let you take care of her."

“From what I see, the abilities of the Acting Director and Shiba-sensei are at a ridiculous level. I don't know how much I can help, but it probably won't be much.” Kiryuuin happily held her fist at my side.

"If you can attract them for 1 second or 2 seconds, you are welcome."

"I'll tell you. I'll hold them for a minute or two at least. But Ayanokouji, can't you show me more?"

"Show me more?"

“You don't look very good with that scruffy expression on your face. Keep your fists up and try to create an atmosphere of tension. "



I never thought I'd hear you say that in a place like this.
But under Kiryuuin's strange pressure, I had no choice but to strike a pose that looked like it. It's like something you would see in a fight scene in a drama.

"How about?"

“Huh, you're that clumsy. Oh well, let's say you've met the minimum standard. "

Smiling, Kiryuuin also struck a fighting pose once more.

"Have you ever hit someone?"

"I am a lady. What do you think? "

"..... Are you serious?"

"Don't worry, I was thinking that I would like to hit you in the face at least once ..."

We keep a distance from each other and move into a clearing one against one.

"Let's solve this, Acting Director."

“So you have decided that I am the only one who can beat you? "

With his usual smile on his face Tsukishiro prepares himself, showing no concern.

“Then let's see. I want to know what you are capable of one against one "

The opponent in front of me I receive it as an equal enemy. If I don't, I'll be the one who gets a surprise. But it will still be decided in less than 1 minute. I'm going to get it before Kiryuuin is held back by Shiba.

Tsukishiro came charging towards me. I dodged Tsukishiro's attack without warning and hit Tsukishiro's cheek with my left fist.

- "!!!?"

I jabbed lightly and with speed, hitting hard. The power of each shot is slight because I concentrated only on hitting.
However, upon hitting him repeatedly, Tsukishiro's smile faded.
The target was the nasal pole. A certain effect is activated in the human body if even slight damage is received. That is "tears".



All human beings induce tears when they hit us on the nose. Tears welled up at the pain, taking away important visibility. It doesn't matter if you are an adult or a child, young or old. It is a mechanism of the human body.

As Tsukishiro's vision faded, I swiftly swing an uppercut to his chin.
Staring at the sky Tsukishiro, he probably bit his mouth and a little blood spurted out.

"I wonder how much time has passed "

Wiping the blood dripping from his lips, Tsukishiro smiled wryly.

“I admit it, considering that you are a second year high school boy in front of me. You are an undeniable masterpiece. "

Of all the rivals I have fought with, Tsukishiro is without a doubt one of the best. It was enough for Tsukishiro to decide that he could fight one-on-one and win.

"I don't like being hard on people, but I'm having a lot of fun."

Laughing in amusement, Tsukishiro prepares himself again. But he didn't come right away, and he backs slowly.
It could be seen as a way of buying time until Shiba defeats Kiryuuin.
I calmly try to follow the path of victory, without rushing too much.
Tsukishiro looks at the sand at his feet. For just a moment.

I reached out and put all my strength into my right fist
- "It's absolutely magnificent ——!"

I hit on Tsukishiro's body who received it as if squirming.
I hit it with most of my ability. But even so, Tsukishiro's smile didn't go away. While losing his posture, Tsukishiro grabs a handful of sand from the ground with his left hand and throws it at me.

Then, with his free hand that plunges further into the hole in the sand, he stands up. Even if the right fist that swings up like an uppercut hits me straight, it wouldn't do much damage if you don't have good posture. But, I didn't receive his right hand from

the front, and I pulled Tsukishiro's arm away and I immediately grabbed his right arm so he wouldn't move.

"!!"

I looked at Tsukishiro's right arm, which is holding a Stun Gun (Taser)

"How did you know?"

" I didn't know until just before. However, in a situation where you can't even let a single moment of time go by, you dropped your gaze once as if to check your feet for some reason. I was uncomfortable with that. If your goal was to remove my vision with sand, you don't need to bother checking your feet. "

Even when his left hand grabbed the sand and threw it at me, my consciousness was beyond that.

"It also seemed a little natural to me that you deliberately put yourself as if you were going to receive a blow from me"

We both needed to change the course of the fight, as we were very even.

“If it was possible, I didn't want to take this risk, it was an insurance policy, but your skill was enough to make me impatient”.

I loosened his right hand and the stun gun slammed into the sand and stabbed.

“So what do we do now? You have caused me profound damage, but ..... "

At this point, Acting Director Tsukishiro raises his hand and sends a signal somewhere. Then the pilot of the small anchored boat started trying to land with something in hand, clearly the last trump card in case they are defeated. But it is the same in this case.

"I'm afraid your time is up, Acting Director Tsukishiro."

Suddenly, the pilot stopped preparing to land, and the little boat revved its engines and took off quickly, leaving the acting director behind.
The reason may be that he saw another small boat coming from the sea.

"..... I'm surprised. What did you call the boat? I have been preparing the ground naturally. So you wouldn't ask the school for help if you needed it. And I knew you wouldn't want the school to know either. "

“It is a simple matter. You just have to take a good look at the smaller boats to realize it."

If you look closely at the end of the small boat, you could see Mashima-sensei and Chabashira-sensei. And that's how Tsukishiro found out.

“What would happen if someone reports that a student from class A and class D in the 2nd year has collapsed in I2 and they are in danger? It is not something that can be hidden very easily. I have already confirmed that a classroom teacher was included in the selection of people who came to help the victim in an incident that occurred some time ago”.

This was simply a rule that the school had decided that class teachers were the best at identifying them at a glance.
When you find out that it is the 2nd A class and the 2nd D class, you have no choice but to bring your class teacher, even if you don't want to.
If it is an emergency, there is no time to check the GPS one by one. If it contains information that the watch appears to be broken, they will definitely check it, even if there is no response from the GPS.

"If they had checked all the students by GPS, would the rescue have arrived and changed the situation? Now, from the map, you can see that a student from class A and another from class D from the second year have lost the GPS response of their watches. I think it was more of a question of trust. "

“You were going to buy time from the beginning and let this unfold. That's why you focused on escaping in the beginning, knowing the downside. "

"It was a mistake to threaten Ichinose halfway. If you were going to do this you should have handled it thoroughly."

As a result, Tsukishiro gave me the opportunity to ask Sakayanagi for help before coming here.

“Even so, my position is still that of a priest, you know? I can't do such a disturbing thing."

I'm not sure if that's true or a lie, but Tsukishiro laughed when he said it.
Shiba immediately withdrew his hand from Kiryuuin as he saw that Tsukishiro had already resigned.

“Fuf... You were saved Ayanokouji-kun. Strangely, I couldn't take it anymore. "

Then he knelt to rest his body
I was watching the fight between Shiba and her, although it was out of the corner of my eye and she could hold out well, even if she only defended herself.

It's great that he recognized the obvious superiority of the team and tried to entertain her without putting too much pressure on her.
If even Shiba had participated in the battle alongside the flawless Tsukishiro, he wouldn't know how it would have turned out. In the end, the boat landed and Mashima-sensei and Chabashirasensei got off.
The walkie-talkie that Sakayanagi lent me was useful to the end.

"I won, so I wonder if you will accept it"

"I guess I can't help but admit it for the moment."

As things stand, there shouldn't be enough cards in hand to deliver Tsukishiro from here.
Even the fact that he changed the designated area just for me is sure to come to light if investigated.

"Your score is quite complicated, but I think you're fine. As for me, now that you're out in the open, I can't help but protest if you're in the bottom five.

"Don't worry. I think I can see that I'm at the safe limit"

"It was an unnecessary worry. Well then, I'll leave it like that for now."

"For the moment. I hope I don't have to do more of these power tricks using unnecessary violence. At least I don't think it goes against the philosophy of this school. Of course, if it is a test of strength according to the regulations, it is a welcome thing. "

With a smile on his face, Acting Director Tsukishiro looks at Mashima-sensei and Chabashira getting out of the boat.

"Let me ask you one last thing, Acting Director Tsukishiro. Did you really try to expel me? It is true that there were strong restrictions, but if I were in your place instead, I would have prepared a more reliable method and carried it out."

I don't think the man in front of me is foolish enough not to think about it.

"You are overestimating me. I did everything in my power to get you out of school according to the instructions of my superiors. But it turned out that I could not do it, and I fell before you like that."

One thing I found out is that the man named Tsukishiro hasn't shown everything he has yet. I don't know if there was any lie or falsehood in what you just said, but I'll have to assume that it had other goals.

"May I ask you to give a message to Amasawa-san"

"I hear you".

“Amasawa Ichika, you are disqualified for disobeying your orders. There will be no more places to return to. You can stay or leave this school as you see fit. "

Is it true? Or will it be false? I can't see that from Tsukishiro.
Even after admitting defeat, that doesn't smell like he wavered at all.
If Amasawa really did leave the White Room, I don't think it's the end of the story.
One thing is for sure.
I just don't think this is the end of the whole White Room thing.
There is still something. And, it makes me think.

"Let's see how you fight to the end."

When he slowly gets up, Tsukishiro raises both hands as if he has an idea and walks over to Mashima-sensei and the others.

"Nothing has occurred here. Ayanokouji-kun and I just had a chat. "

"You think that's enough."

"There is nothing to do, it is already decided. The teachers cannot do anything about it. In fact, you should be grateful that I do not resist."

I looked at Mashima-sensei and nodded and said it was okay.

"Then let's go. The students haven't finished their special exams yet."

After confirming that the adults are heading to the ship, I look towards Kiryuuin.
Perhaps she was exhausted from dealing with Shiba, she sat on the beach and got on her knees looking out to sea.

"Well done, Ayanokouji."

"No, Kiryuuin-senpai you were also amazing against Shiba-sensei."

“I can't even take that as a compliment after seeing you in action. Don't worry; I'm not going to tell anyone about you. But I'd like to hear what you have to say. "

I didn't expect them to see me, but I'm glad it was Kiryuuin

“I have a somewhat complicated family situation. That's all."

“A complicated family situation. That doesn't seem like an easy thing to deal with. "

Getting up and lightly brushing the sand off his butt, Kiryuuin starts walking towards the forest. When I left I2 with Kiryyuin and went back to I3, Miyabi Nagumo was no longer there. But instead, I ran into some unexpected students.
As soon as they saw me they looked at me and were surprised.

“It's a rare combination Horikita. Strolling with Ibuki, is it going to rain hail today? "

"...., Are you okay?"

"What do you mean by" good "?"

"Well, no. I thought you might be having a little problem with someone."

This time, Kiryuuin and I looked at each other and denied it at almost the same time.

"Do not? There is no one in the way. "

"So what were you doing here?"

“It has been a very exhausting two weeks. I was resting on a secluded beach, looking at the sea. "

“You have a lot of free time. You probably got the minimum score. "

Why Kiryuuin-senpai? As she sent a look.

“I found a student who was slacking off and I brought him back. I told him to be diligent to the end. "

With that said, Kiryuuin-senpai tapped my back and started walking.

"Then I'll see you on the boat after the exam."

Horikita stands by my side and confirms it again by whispering to me

"Are you sure you were okay ……?

"What?".

"The thing is…. I just heard some of that. On a small piece of paper "

"Paper?"

“No, it's nothing, don't worry. There are still a lot of things I don't understand, so I'll do some research on my own and then we'll talk. "

I was curious, but I don't know what she was talking about, but I didn't want to prolong the conversation about what happened in I2. I can't tell her about Tsukishiro.

“Why are you and Ibuki here? There is no homework around, right? "

Ibuki was going to say something, but Horikita stopped her.

"Ibuki had challenged me to a match and that's why we were checking each other's scores .. Your GPS was in a strange place, so I thought I'd check it out. I'll call it a tie."

"How can that be, clearly I won, right?"

"Error, error."

"Even if it is not a mistake or a mistake, if I beat you with 1 point I will win "

I'm not sure, but through this exam Horikita and Ibuki have become friends ……?
And soon after, the test of the uninhabited island comes to an end.

Epilogue: And The Results Are In

Intro

The long two weeks of testing on the uninhabited island have finally come to an end. On the last day, it appears that some of the students in the group who tried to force themselves and were injured, but the ordeal somehow came to an end. At the starting point of the test, the teachers welcomed the students to the camp.

After six in the afternoon, when the world was starting to turn red, we received a call informing us that all the participating students had returned to the ship and had been brought back.
It was announced that the results would be released on the ship, but as there was a possibility that many students would drop out, the lower groups were notified in advance.
The reality is that they will probably find out about it shortly after they get back on the ship, probably before they go to sleep.
It looks like it won't be a public execution in front of all the students.
The last five groups are called in beforehand to see if they can take preventive measures earlier.

The students who can avoid expulsion will be saved by paying the price here.
Students who do not have enough private points, or those who do, but do not use them for any reason, will be expelled at this time and will have to pack their belongings and get on a small boat.
After taking a shower for the first time in days, I decided to take a boat ride.
Normally, I would have used my mobile phone to communicate with my friends and loved ones, but since the school kept holding my phone, I was not allowed to do so.

I passed some “D-class” students and we exchanged a few words of thanks for each other's hard work, but I made my way to the deck. There, I saw an interesting combination of two people.
They both faced each other and were talking face to face.
I didn't do anything in particular to hide, so one of them immediately noticed me.

His face was covered in scars, indicating that he had had a fierce battle with Housen Kazuomi during the exam.

" I'm sorry to interrupt you, but don't forget the promise you made to me, okay? And some money. "

"Of course, Ryuuen-kun. Please tell me when the time comes."

In the back Sakayanagi and Ryuuen smiled happily. Ryuuen, who mentioned the word promise, returned to the ship looking at me.

"Promise?"

"Yes. I did not know the strength of first graders. I trained Ryuuen-kun as a good soldier, but he is not the type of person who would cooperate for free. I told him that if he asked me for a favor, I would grant it to him. . "

I see. So that's why Ryuuen appeared to confront Housen.

"By the way, do you know the result of the fight?"

"I am not sure about that. I know that Ryuuen-kun and Housen-kun returned to the starting point covered in injuries, and received medical treatment and were removed. "

So the fight ended with a painful outcome with both sides withdrawing, although the winner of the fight is unknown.
But it must not have been easy for that guy who was so focused on winning the desert island event to change his mind.

"So ... was it a good idea to make a promise that easy?"

"Yes. It's a promise that may not come true anytime soon, plus ... that wish is like strangling yourself in the near future. "

Sakayanagi smiled after saying that. She had the innocent eyes of a child.
It seems certain that it is not such a sweet promise to have a light date.

"I'm glad you're well. Did you have a problem with the timing of the GPS disappearance that was indicated?

"It was the perfect moment. I will definitely pay you back."

"That is a difficult proposition."

"I get it. Ayanokouji-kun now wants to lead a quiet life as much as possible. I am well aware that you won't do anything that will make you stand out unwittingly. Do not rush. We still have almost a year and a half of school life left. "

Sakayanagi says that if there is an opportunity to compete somewhere before graduation, that is fine.

"It's almost six o'clock, it's time to announce the results, right?"

"So is."

Which group won and which group lost?
Let's see it.

Part 1

At 7 o'clock, the members of class D began to meet and eat in the same place. Naturally yesterday and today, the lower group lists weren't available, so the only way to know which group was underperforming was to ask them directly.

"First of all, ... I think it's great that no group from class D, from the second year, has been able to complete the special exam without missing a beat. And the fact that all the students from class D were present here it was an important factor in avoiding expulsion."

That was really good.
Looking at his companions, Yousuke just said that with all his heart. I was a little worried because I had never met Yousuke on an uninhabited island, but he seemed more worried about his friends than his own exhaustion.
In case you are not sure what to do, you can always ask for help.
I decided to take a quick look at the rest of the sophomore class.
If we're all here, it means that Haruka and Airi's group were safe too.

I decided to take a quick look at the rest of the sophomore class.
It does not appear that any student is excessively tired. Students are enjoying a large meal for the first time in two weeks, but cannot fully enjoy it.

When the teachers begin to meet, the 8:00 pm signal is given and the microphones are turned on.

"Please stop eating, it's time for the announcement"

Class 3A teacher Sasaki announced, and the students look at the teacher.

" First of all, thank you for your hard work on the uninhabited island special survey. We, the faculty and staff, are surprised by the fact that, despite a total of thirteen students dropping out, no group of students was absent during the two weeks. ”

They begin by thanking us for the hard work.

“It is possible that some classes have already noticed the lack of some students, but the last five groups were penalized and withdrawn from the school, as we had explained beforehand. If there is more than one person in a group, we will read the name of one person as a representative. The five groups are:
The 3rd D Mutou class, the 3rd D Kawakami class, the 3rd C Shinonome class, the 3rd C Katsumata class, and the 3rd B Mikitani class. For a total of 15 people. "

The first and second graders muttered at Sasaki-sensei's explanation.
Names were confirmed to be in the lower ranks just before the end of the 12th, but it was too surprising that the group of everyone who dropped out of school was third year
They had assumed that Nagumo would be the one to rescue them. I also thought that some of the freshmen and sophomores would drop out as well due to the hectic mobility.

But it turned out that five groups of three third-year students were eliminated.
Given that none of these students could benefit from the recovery measures, a total of 15 students have been confirmed to drop out.
Based on this result, was it secretly decided that 5 groups of 3rd grade students would drop out of school?
Thinking like this, I saw the faces of the third graders, but apparently it wasn't like that.
The faces of many of the students were puzzled, as if they couldn't believe what they were seeing. It seems as if they were scared of the result, as if it were an example.

I tried to find Nagumo, but the face I saw for a moment was unusual for him. However, perhaps the aggression of the last hour with me could have influenced this result.

The power of the huge screen is turned on, a white image is projected on the screen and another person comes out.

"Then, we will announce the three main groups as a result of the special examination of the uninhabited island."

Acting Director Tsukishiro. I didn't think he had been so calm, after fighting with me.
He proceeded calmly, as when he declared the start

"Third place, 2nd year Group Class A Sakayanagi Arisu.
261 points "
Suddenly, a group of sophomores showed up for third place.
They seemed to have made the most of the advantages of the only seven-member group allowed for sophomores, and had slowly worked their way up the rankings amassing a solid score and slipping into third place.
On the last day, Ichinose left the team in the middle of the tournament, but the effect was not so serious.

As for the scores, Ryuuen and Katsuragi's group also fought hard, but Ryuuen's withdrawal on the 13th must have had a big impact. With Katsuragi alone, the order of arrival of the rewards disappeared and the number of challenges he could participate in decreased. It must have been two very hard days for him, as he had to act with caution to avoid the risk of withdrawing.

The doubling of the score on the final day must have been a headwind.
For a change, Sakayanagi had things in order. The students who were sent to detain the freshmen were all outside of Sakayanagi's group. The tablet used was also from another group and was not at higher risk.

She responded well to dangerous opponents with Ryuuen involved.
She must have foreseen that interacting with Kazuomi Housen was also dangerous for Ryuuen.
Today there are many people who are looking for the best way to get the most out of their life.

Was it moved because of the high school connection or is it related to the "promise"?
If it's the latter, then it's more attractive than the increased 3rd place and try card rewards.
However, it was surprising to see how Kiriyama's group was left standing at the end of the match.
And what about second place.
It is not an exaggeration to say that everything is decided here.

At the end of the 12th, it was confirmed that it was between Nagumo and Kouenji
Even if they lose a few points, they won't wreak havoc when it comes to the third-place score.
Is it Nagumo who brought the 3rd years together, or is it Kouenji who kept showing an unstoppable rhythm on his own?

"2nd place, 2nd year Group Class A Nagumo Miyabi. **325 points "**

When acting director Tsukishiro read this, there was not a cheer but a shout.

Without pausing for a moment, he moved on to the first place announcement.

"1st place, 2nd year class D Kouenji Rokusuke. **327 points "**

The moment the name was spoken, Kouenji caught the attention and gaze of all the students.
No one was attracted to the appearance of winning, and he stood still. If you look only at the result, there is only 2 points of difference. and it could have been canceled by a small incident.
However, Kouenji achieved the feat of 1st place in the harshest conditions of being alone.
He obtained the 300 class points that should be distributed for the first place, a million private points for each person and a protection point.

"You really have done it, Kouenji-kun."

Kouenji turned his gaze to Horikita and said: - "I'm sure you understand, right?"

As promised, Kouenji has been granted immunity until graduation.
It also means that, from now on, he was going to do whatever he wanted with his school life.

"I'm not ... happy at all, or at least I can't say I'm disappointed ..."

“I think we can be happy now, right? We have achieved 300 class points on our own, which is a very important point to move up to class A. It is the second time we have left class D. "

Furthermore, Kouenji was originally doing what he wanted and they had no control over him.

"Yes, that's right. Now let's go up again. It doesn't matter what changes from class B to class D."

"As long as we don't make a mess this month during our day-to-day activities and things don't go too low."

Class points are slightly reduced due to daily activities and behavior problems.

"... Do not say foolishness."

However, I think again that the difference between these two points is of great significance. Today I remember the figure of Miyabi Nagumo who took the trouble to visit me.
His partner's voice that I heard from his walkie-talkie at the time.
If Nagumo had responded to that voice at that time, the first and second place results would have been reversed.
And I think there would have been a difference in the group that was expelled.
It is not something that can be answered by thinking about it here.
First of all, this long special exam ended successfully. Miraculously, not a single sophomore was absent and the summer was able to get through.

I also found out that Amasawa Ichika is a White Room student.
I don't know why, but at least now she's taking my side instead of Tsukishiro's side.
There is no way of knowing if this is a coordinated strategy or if Amasawa is acting alone after betraying the White Room, but the information I have obtained is not insignificant.
Even so, there are still some mysteries to be solved.
Maybe this summer vacation won't end well.

THE END

Author's words

Since last year, I have been working all the time without time to breathe. Hi, I'm Kinugasa.
I have nothing to write on my postcards!
My left thumb has been throbbing really hard lately. (Maybe not the gout).
(It might not be a drop.) My new neighborhood hot curry shop is so delicious I can't help but go there. (I really do not care.)
After looking at the website for an hour to order a food delivery, you end up going to pick it up yourself by bike while you think about the surcharge and delivery fee. (And that?) There is nothing new, and I get on with my day.
Well OK. That's it for a status report, I guess.
Please understand that this is a very empty postcard, as always.
. . . . . .
If there is demand, I would like to write the episodes of each character separately, but I don't know if there is demand or not, so I will ignore it for now.
Since last year, I have been working all the time without time to breathe. I've been working on this for a while.
Here is the second part of the uninhabited island test

This is the fourth volume in the series, but if we look back again, it was a lot of work! And even though there were almost 700 pages in total, there were still plenty of episodes I wanted to write about. There were a lot of battles between the main characters on the desert island, and I wanted to write about them too, but I couldn't because it would stray from the main plot, so I decided to write about them in
. . . . . .
If there is demand, I would like to write the episodes of each character separately, but I don't even know if there is demand, so I will ignore them for now.
In the volume 4 main story, the battle against Tsukishiro will end here for now, but the story related to the White Room will continue for a while longer. Those of you who have read it will surely get an idea of what is going on.
The next installment will be the summer vacation on the luxury cruise ship in volume 4.5,
after being released from the special exam.
I hope you pay attention to the details of the desert island review and the episodes with the characters that I have not mentioned.
There may or may not be changes in the love life of Ayanokouji and the other

characters. Also, even the White Room relationship I just mentioned——.
So even though this is a summer vacation story, there will be some intense developments
that are the same as the desert island test, so please look forward to it.
Well then everyone, see you again in four months at the latest.

Short Note

Hey Everyone. **Anime Boii** here..

A big thanks if you are reading up until here. There are a few things that I would like to say.

First of all.. I don't claim that this piece of work is owned by me. It belongs to the author of the book Shogo Kinusuga.

I also don't claim that this whole book has been prepared by me…although the amount of correction and editing it took was enoromous..also some text of this book belongs to other translators namely ConfusedTls and TLG translations…I only took their text only to compile with the whole story so make sure to thank them on their website as they are currently in middle of translating the year 2 vol 4.

And Secondly…

I think that's it.

Thanks for reading and also if you want to thank me, you can subscribe to my channel. Here..

https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCsCMXA_DzbevS3keLrtwttA

Stay at home and Stay safe :-D